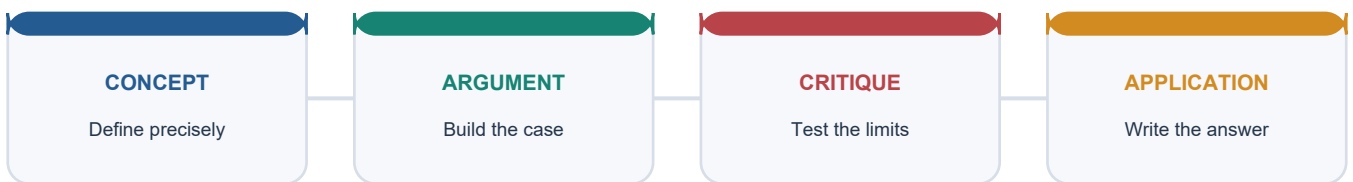


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 04 - Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 16 teaching sessions, 32 diagnostics, 17 solved PYQs, 6 original Mains models and register notes

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 04 - Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation

Uncompressed complete learning session | Approval: pending explicit user approval

Syllabus owner (verbatim): "Soul : Immortality; Rebirth and Liberation." **Learning rule:** simple explanation first, technical doctrine second; no artificial speed target and no skipped doctrine. **Evidence order:** canonical Markdown -> OCR-searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion* and the *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, with Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma for the Indian schools -> bounded official live anchor. Qdrant was not required. **PYQ control:** all 17 primary-owner Philosophy Optional question-parts from 2018-2025 are reproduced from the audited ledger, out of 112 Paper II parts. This is the heaviest clause in the whole of Section B - 2018:2, 2019:1, 2020:2, 2021:3, 2022:3, 2023:2, 2024:2, 2025:2. **Objective-question status:** Philosophy Optional is Mains-only. Every MCQ in this package is original UPSC-style practice, never a claimed Prelims previous-year question. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *self* (*ātman*), *individual soul* (*jīva*), *no permanent self* (*anātman*; Pali: *anattā*), *dependent origination* (*pratītyasamutpāda*; Pali: *paṭiccasamuppāda*), *re-becoming* (*punarbhava*), *rebirth* (*punarjanma*), *wandering-on* (*saṃsāra*), *release* (*mokṣa*), *final cessation of pain* (*apavarga*), *aloneness* (*kaivalya*), *extinguishing* (*nirvāṇa*; Pali: *nibbāna*), *liberation while living* (*jīvanmukti*), *liberation at the fall of the body* (*videhamukti*), *already-fructifying karma* (*prārabdha*), *unseen moral potency* (*adr̥ṣṭa/apūrvā*), *subtle body* (*sūkṣma-śarīra* / *liṅga-śarīra*), *latent dispositions* (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*), *inflow of karmic matter* (*āsrava*), *bondage* (*bandha*), *stoppage* (*saṃvara*), *shedding* (*nirjarā*), *omniscience* (*kevala-jñāna*), *devotion* (*bhakti*), *self-surrender* (*prapatti/śaraṇāgati*), *discriminative discernment* (*viveka-khyāti*), *restriction of mental modifications* (*citta-vṛtti-nirodha*).

Package counts

Component	Count
Verified owner PYQs with full model answers	17
Original core diagnostic MCQs	24
Original remedial MCQs	8
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Original solved Mains questions	6 (2 x 10m, 2 x 15m, 2 x 20m)
Correct-option placement	Independently randomised, balanced and unpatterned
Topic approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Exact printed ownership and cross-topic firewall

The printed clause owns **soul, self and person concepts only insofar as they control immortality, rebirth and liberation**, together with the survival arguments, the identity criteria, school-specific continuity-bearers and every terminus called "liberation".

Owned here	Boundary
comparative soul, self and person models needed for survival	full Indian-school self-metaphysics remains with the Paper I canonical owners
arguments and objections concerning post-mortem survival	revelation and faith-based warrant remain with Reason, Revelation and Faith

Owned here	Boundary
religious experience only as a bounded survival argument	phenomenology and veridicality remain with Religious Experience
karma only as continuity, rebirth and liberation mechanism	karma as an answer to suffering remains with Problem of Evil
Buddhist and Jain liberation and their non-creator implications	the full case for religion without a creator remains with Religion without God
resurrection, replica and duplication only as identity tests	detailed doctrinal eschatology and intermediate-state speculation are not independently required by the PYQ corpus
the God-soul relation only where it fixes what liberation can be	the independent definition of the divine attributes remains with Notions of God

ANALYSIS: Soul, self, person, immortality, resurrection, rebirth, reincarnation and liberation are not synonyms. No empirical, parapsychological or neuroscientific claim anywhere in this package is presented as scientific proof of survival.

BASIC / MUST KNOW - independently complete for UPSC Philosophy Optional

This section contains every survival concept, every named argument for and against immortality, every continuity model, every school-specific liberation terminus, every objection with its reply and every verdict needed for the seventeen verified owner PYQs and for a complete core answer. **No Advanced section is required to repair a missing thinker, doctrine, distinction or PYQ concept.** In particular, the Sāṃkhya-Yoga module, the bhakti module, the three-means dispute and the resurrection-rebirth-reincarnation module are taught here in the Basic sessions; they are not deferred to the optional block.

0A. SOUL, SELF, PERSON AND CONTINUITY-BEARER ANALYSIS:

Model	What the person or self is	Survival implication	Main pressure
Substance dualism	an immaterial thinking substance distinct from the body	the soul may survive bodily death	interaction, individuation, and dependence on brain and body
Hylomorphism	the soul is the organising form of a living body	isolated disembodied survival is harder; resurrection restores the embodied person	how the numerically same person is reconstituted
Bundle / no-substantial-self	a series or bundle of physical and mental events without a permanent owner	causal or psychological continuity may replace substance survival	responsibility, and <i>who</i> survives
Embodied-person view	the person is an irreducibly embodied psychophysical unity	survival requires resurrection, re-creation or another continuity relation	the replica and duplication problems
Indian substantial-self models	an enduring self (<i>ātman</i>), an individual soul (<i>jīva</i>) or the Nyāya self carries continuity	transmigration and reincarnation are intelligible	memory, evidence and school-specific attributes
Buddhist no-permanent-self model	dependently arisen aggregates and causal continuity without an unchanging self (<i>anātman</i> ; Pali: <i>anattā</i>)	rebirth does not require a transmigrating substance	neither-same-nor-different identity, and moral responsibility

Personal-identity criteria answer different questions: bodily continuity, memory or psychological continuity, soul-substance, and causal continuity. John Hick's **replica thought experiment** tests whether a unique psychophysical duplicate with continuous memory and character *is* survival; the bare possibility of **two** replicas exposes the gap between qualitative similarity and numerical identity.

MEMORY: The single most useful move in this clause: never ask "does the soul survive?" first. Ask "**what is the continuity-bearer, and what is it a bearer of?**" Substance, psychological series, causal stream and divinely re-constituted person are four different answers, and every school in this topic is a choice among them.

Local source and factual control

- John Hick's local searchable PDF, print pp. 120-143 (PDF pp. 131-154), controls immortality, the resurrection and replica identity discussion, and the karma/reincarnation treatment.
- The local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, "Death and the Afterlife", beginning at print p. 366 (PDF pp. 378-391), controls the soul, embodied-person and personal-identity alternatives.
- The local Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma texts control the school chapters - Buddhist rebirth, Jain bondage and liberation, Nyāya release, Advaita liberation - and are used as comparative evidence, never as a substitute for the Paper I canonical owners.
- Plato is cited from the *Phaedo*; the *Bhagavad Gītā*, *Bhāgavata Purāṇa*, *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* and *Yoga-sūtra* are cited by chapter/verse, kārikā and sūtra number, with translations paraphrased rather than quoted as fixed English.
- CAUTION: No case-study literature on remembered past lives is used as evidence anywhere in this package. Where such material is mentioned it is described as contested reportage, not proof.

Origin and chronology of the debate

ANALYSIS: A chronology is examinable here because the positions are historically layered: the Upaniṣadic self, the Buddhist and Jain śramaṇa alternatives, the classical school syntheses, the Vedāntic commentarial dispute and the modern analytic identity debate each answer an *earlier* formulation. Scripts that float free of the sequence misattribute doctrines.

Stage	Date	Development
Early Upaniṣadic teaching on the self and the wandering-on	first millennium BCE	the enduring self (<i>ātman</i>), action and its fruit, and rebirth within <i>saṃsāra</i> become the shared Indian frame
Śramaṇa alternatives - Buddhism and Jainism	c. 6th-5th century BCE traditional dating	Jainism keeps an eternal individual soul (<i>jīva</i>) without a creator; Buddhism keeps rebirth while denying a permanent self (<i>anātman</i>)
Plato, <i>Phaedo</i>	4th century BCE	four a priori arguments for the soul's immortality, and Simmias' harmony objection inside the same dialogue
<i>Bhagavad Gītā</i>	classical period	the imperishable embodied self; garments (2.22), the indestructible self (2.23), return from heaven (9.21), the convergence signal (5.4-5), the final surrender verse (18.66)
<i>Sāṃkhya-kārikā</i> of Īśvarakṛṣṇa	classical period	threefold suffering (kārikā 1); no <i>puruṣa</i> is bound or released (62-63); the potter's wheel (67) and <i>videha-kaivalya</i> (68)
Patañjali, <i>Yoga-sūtra</i>	classical period	restriction of mental modifications (1.2-1.3); the five afflictions (2.3); Īśvara as a special <i>puruṣa</i> (1.24); cloud-of-dharma absorption (4.29) and aloneness (4.34)
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika systematisation	classical period	the eternal self-substance, the defect-activity-rebirth-false-knowledge chain, and release as <i>apavarga</i>
Śaṅkara's Advaita commentaries	traditionally 8th century CE	liberating knowledge, <i>jīvanmukti</i> and already-fructifying karma; rejection of the knowledge-plus-ritual combination
Rāmānuja's Viśiṣṭādvaita	traditionally 11th-12th century CE	the eternal individual soul in communion; devotion as steady loving recollection, with self-surrender as the accessible alternative

Stage	Date	Development
Madhva, Vallabha, Caitanya and the Bhakti movement	13th-16th centuries CE	knowledge-grounded devotion, the path of nourishing grace, and love as a fifth human end
The Śrīvaiṣṇava grace-effort split	later medieval	the cat and monkey illustrations (<i>mārjāra-</i> and <i>markaṭa-nyāya</i>) state the grace/effort problem in its sharpest form
Aquinas on the soul as form	13th century CE	the rational soul secures the identity of the person raised at the resurrection
Kant's paralogisms of pure reason	1781/1787	the soul is not a knowable substance; immortality returns only as a postulate of practical reason
Oscar Cullmann, <i>Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?</i>	1955	the canonical claim that Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are opposed , not complementary
John Hick, <i>Philosophy of Religion and Death and Eternal Life</i>	1963-1976	the replica theory as a thought-experiment defence of resurrection identity
Peter van Inwagen on the possibility of resurrection	later 20th century	God preserves the body or a core of it, leaving a simulacrum, so that re-assembly need not be from scattered matter

ANALYSIS: Two anachronisms are penalised every year: treating the Buddhist denial of a permanent self as a *reply to* Cartesian dualism, and treating resurrection as a variant of rebirth that happens to occur in heaven.

Source-complete coverage ledger and learning labels

[**FACT**] marks retained repository doctrine and question data. [**INFERENCE**] marks the learner-facing organisation and graded verdict. This ledger maps source units to their final location rather than merely asserting reconciliation.

Source corpus and unit	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical 0 and 0A: one-screen map, the immortality->rebirth->liberation question, soul/self/person models, identity criteria and the replica test	Basic Sessions 1 and 2	Retained complete; the continuity-bearer question becomes the topic's answer spine
Canonical 1: Plato's four <i>a priori</i> proofs, the critique and the Indian eternity parallel	Basic Session 3	Each of the four arguments taught separately with its own objection, as the 2023 stem requires
Canonical 1.1: the five argument families and the body/brain objection	Basic Session 4	Retained as a full table plus the burden-shifting verdict
Canonical 1 Indian material and <i>Gītā</i> 2.23	Basic Session 5	Taught as the Hindu immortality route owned by the 2021 20-marker
Canonical 2: karma-saṃsāra, the debt analogy control, rebirth in karma theory	Basic Sessions 6 and 7	Split into the karma mechanism and the rebirth field so that both 2021 Q8(b) and 2023 Q7(b) have a home
Canonical 2 Buddhist challenge and the necessity verdict	Basic Session 8	Taught with the modal verdict, the flame and milk-to-curd illustrations and the responsibility objection
Canonical 3 and 5A: the liberation table and the parity bench	Basic Session 9	Retained complete as the highest-value comparative device in the topic
Canonical 8.2: Vedāntic self, rebirth and release	Basic Session 10	Taught as Advaita versus Viśiṣṭādvaita, with <i>jīvanmukti</i> and the real-agent question

Source corpus and unit	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical 8.4: Jain soul and liberation	Basic Session 11	Taught as the soul-and-bondage ladder demanded by 2022 Q8(b)
Canonical 8.5 and 8.9: Nyāya release, Advaita embodied liberation, Sāṃkhya-Yoga aloneness	Basic Session 12	Retained in full, including kārikā 62-63, the potter's wheel and the non-creator Īśvara
Canonical 8.6 and 8.7: devotion as a path, and the knowledge-action-devotion dispute	Basic Session 13	Both owner-modules taught in full, with the grace/effort illustrations and the production-versus-removal apparatus
Canonical 8.8: resurrection versus rebirth, and rebirth versus reincarnation	Basic Session 14	Retained complete with the comparative grid, the gap and re-assembly problems and the three replies
Canonical 2 and 3 anti-theistic implications	Basic Session 15	Taught as the owner-module for the 2018 10-marker on anti-theistic rebirth
Canonical 9, 10, 11: inter-school grid, criticisms and replies, fourteen traps	Basic Session 16 and the register	Preserved where each performs a distinct learning role rather than duplicated
Canonical 4, 5, 6: statement bank, applied drills and PYQ-mapped skeletons	Practice	Absorbed into the seventeen complete model answers and the diagnostics so that no answer exists twice
Canonical 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17: keyword bank, PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, verdict ladder, quotation discipline	Basic Session 16 and the practice apparatus	Taught as an answer-construction session rather than listed as reference tables
Premium workbook practice apparatus	MCQs and Practice	Rebuilt as 32 original diagnostics with 128 option explanations, 17 solved PYQs and 6 original models
Philosophy of Religion dossier, item 4	Optional Advanced	Retained in full after core practice, with the core prerequisite marked as already taught

Visible answer-worthiness labels. The six survival terms, the named arguments, the school-wise continuity-bearers and the liberation termini are **CORE PAPER II**. Modal verdicts, objection-and-reply, comparison and cost-grading are **CORE ANSWER**. Historical supplements and extra illustrations are **SUPPORTING**. Technical personal-identity machinery beyond the taught level is **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What to do with the material. Memorise the parity bench in Session 9 before anything else; half the marks lost in this clause are lost to term-merging. Understand why a *sufficient* condition is not a *necessary* one. Use Buddhism as a counter-example, not as an exception. Reserve the finer identity-criterion machinery for a high-value 15- or 20-marker.

Current evidence policy - SUPPORTING

CURRENT: No dated news item is used as evidence in this topic. Survival, rebirth and liberation are not settled by contemporary reportage, and using popular past-life or near-death material as proof would breach the repository's verification rule. Where a contemporary reference appears it is illustration of the *interest* in the question only, and carries no probative weight.

Learning route

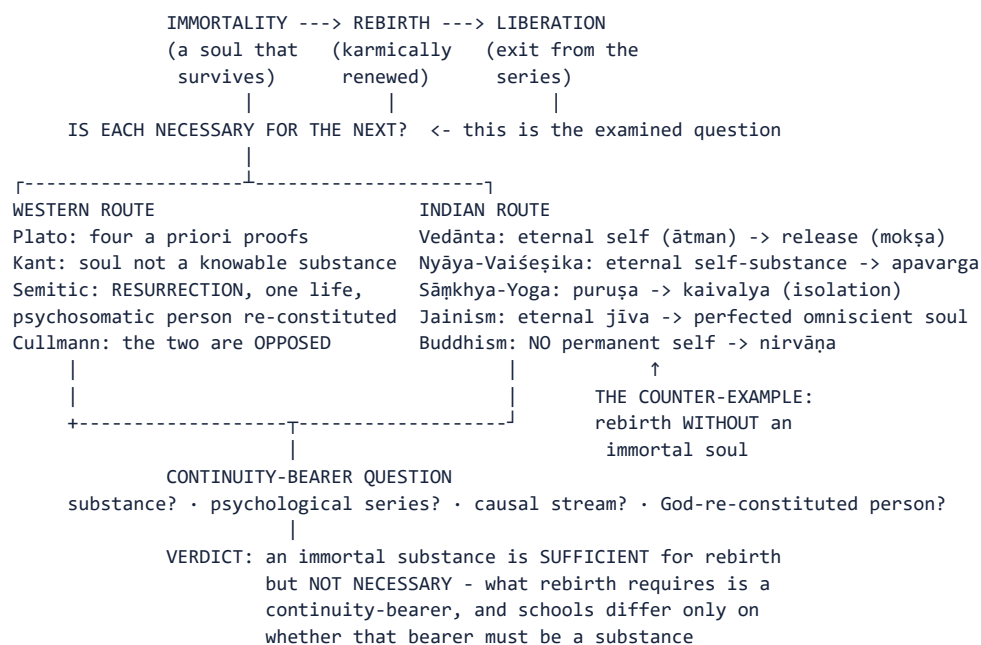
The retained source sequence moves from the vocabulary and the identity question, through the Western arguments for immortality, to karma and rebirth, to the Buddhist counter-example, then across the seven liberation termini school by school, then to the paths, then to the Semitic comparator, and finally to comparison and answer construction. Notions of God, the problem of evil, faith and religious experience appear only as bounded links or as the target of a premise; they are not silently absorbed into this topic.

UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Section B · Philosophy of Religion · Syllabus item 4

Evidence key used throughout: FACT: canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or a local source text · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis or inference for exam use · CAUTION: contested or textually variable · CURRENT: dated contemporary anchor only, never authority.

Roadmap

EXAM ROUTE High-value transition: the topic moves from separating the survival vocabulary, to reconstructing the arguments for an immortal soul, to the karmic field in which rebirth operates, to the Buddhist proof that rebirth needs continuity rather than substance, to the seven non-identical destinations called liberation, and finally to the modal verdict the examiner is actually buying.



Session	Subtopic	Core focus
1	The survival vocabulary and the necessity question	Six terms kept apart; the immortality -> rebirth -> liberation chain; what the examiner is buying
2	Soul, self, person and the identity criteria	Five models of the person; bodily, memory, soul and causal criteria; Hick's replica and the duplication problem
3	Plato's four <i>a priori</i> proofs	Opposites, recollection, affinity, the Form of Life; Simmias' harmony objection; Kant's paralogism
4	The five argument families for immortality	Simplicity, identity, moral order, desire, experience - and the body/brain dependence objection
5	Immortality in the Hindu tradition	The indestructible self; <i>Gītā</i> 2.22-2.23 and 9.21; the subtle body; the 2021 20-mark route
6	Karma as moral causation	Unseen potency; stored, fructifying and future karma; effort versus destiny; karma as an essential postulate

Session	Subtopic	Core focus
7	Rebirth and the wandering-on	<i>Punarjanma</i> , beginninglessness, the subtle body, why rebirth is required by karma theory
8	Rebirth without a permanent self	No-self, dependent origination, flame-to-flame, neither-same-nor-different, and the modal verdict
9	The liberation parity bench	Seven destinations that share one English word and no single content
10	Vedāntic self, release and embodied liberation	Advaita versus Viśiṣṭādvaita; <i>jīvanmukti</i> and <i>videhamukti</i> ; liberation without a real agent
11	Jain soul and bondage	Inflow, bondage, stoppage, shedding; omniscience; the four infinitudes; perfected individuality
12	Cessation and isolation	Nyāya <i>apavarga</i> without consciousness; Sāṃkhya-Yoga <i>kaivalya</i> ; the <i>kevala</i> terminological trap
13	Paths to liberation	Devotion in full; the knowledge-action-devotion dispute; production versus removal
14	Resurrection, rebirth and reincarnation	The comparative grid; gap and re-assembly problems; Aquinas, van Inwagen, Hick
15	Anti-theistic rebirth	Karma without a divine judge; the significance claim; Jain and Buddhist soteriology without God
16	Answer architecture for this clause	Directive decoder, graded verdict ladder, 10/15/20-mark construction, quotation discipline

PYQ priority: FACT: Highest in Section B - **17 topic-owned question-parts across 2018-2025 out of 112 Paper II parts**, spanning anti-theistic rebirth and devotion (2018), karma-rebirth-reincarnation (2019), immortality as a presupposition and the three means (2020), Hindu immortality, Advaita liberation and karma as a postulate (2021), the Buddhist necessity question, liberation without a real agent and Jain soul-and-bondage (2022), Plato's proofs and rebirth in karma theory (2023), Nyāya *apavarga* and the robust-conception question (2024), and embodied liberation and the *Gītā* necessity question (2025).

MEMORY: Master mnemonic - "I -> R -> L, and the B-break": Immortality, Rebirth, Liberation, with Buddhism breaking the chain at the first link. Whenever a stem asks whether one is necessary for the next, the Buddhist counter-example is the hinge of the answer.

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST -----

BOOK: Book context: Authored Markdown paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md read in full, sections 0 through 18; the advanced dossier item 4 read in full; local OCR-searchable John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion*, print pp. 120-143, consulted for immortality, replica identity and karma/reincarnation; the local *Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion*, "Death and the Afterlife" from print p. 366, consulted for the soul, embodied-person and identity alternatives; Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma consulted for the Buddhist, Jain, Nyāya and Advaita school chapters.

SEARCH: CA Search: "soul, immortality, rebirth and liberation - scholarly debate and Indian philosophy coverage 2025-2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: None used as evidence. Contemporary interest in survival, near-death reports and past-life claims restates the question without adjudicating it, and is not cited here as proof.

SESSION 1 - THE SURVIVAL VOCABULARY AND THE NECESSITY QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This clause asks three connected questions - does anything of us survive death, does what survives come back into a new life, and can it get out of that cycle altogether?

Technical definition: *Immortality* is the claim that a subject is deathless; *rebirth* is karmically conditioned re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series; *liberation* is the exit from that series. The examined question is **modal**: is each of these a *necessary* condition for the next, or only a *sufficient* one?

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Immortality, rebirth and liberation are three separate claims joined by a disputed implication, and the whole examination value of this clause lies in refusing to let the words collapse into one another.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- immortality
- rebirth (punarjanma) and re-becoming (punarbhava)
- reincarnation
- resurrection
- liberation (mokṣa / nirvāṇa / kaivalya / apavarga)
- continuity-bearer
- necessary versus sufficient condition

How to use them: Open by separating the terms in two lines, state which one the stem is really about, give the substantialist answer, then produce the counter-example, and close with an explicit modal verdict.

EXAM-READY LINE: A persisting soul would *guarantee* rebirth, and therefore is sufficient for it; but Buddhism secures re-becoming without any such soul, and therefore it is not necessary.

SIX WORDS THAT ARE NOT SYNONYMS - FIX THESE BEFORE WRITING

TERM	CLAIM MADE	WHO OWNS IT
IMMORTALITY	a subject is deathless	Plato, Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism
SURVIVAL	something of the person continues after death	the weaker, neutral claim; not deathless
REBIRTH (punarjanma / punarbhava)	renewed becoming, karmically conditioned, in a beginningless series	the WIDER term; the only correct one for Buddhism
REINCARNATION (re-enfleshed)	a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-enters flesh	Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism - NOT Buddhism
RESURRECTION	God re-constitutes the whole embodied person, ONE life	Judaism, Christianity, Islam
LIBERATION	exit from the series; SEVEN non-identical destinations	every Indian school, each with its own

MERGE ANY TWO OF THESE AND THE SCRIPT CAPS AT ABOUT 50%.

ANALYSIS: This six-row bench is the cheapest mark in the entire clause. Almost every stem - "is immortality necessary for rebirth", "karma, rebirth and reincarnation", "immortality is a basic presupposition of religion" - is half-answered the moment the terms are separated in the opening paragraph.

1. The chain and the question asked about it

FACT: The canonical chain is **immortality -> rebirth -> liberation**. Substantialist systems read it as a straight implication: something deathless is what transmigrates, and that same thing is what is finally freed. The examiner never asks you to *describe* the chain; the examiner asks whether the links hold.

THE THREE STEMS THE EXAMINER ACTUALLY SETS

(1) Is immortality necessary for REBIRTH? -> 2022 Q5(c); 2025 Q7(c)

(2) Are immortality AND rebirth necessary for a robust conception of LIBERATION? -> 2024 Q6(a)

(3) Is 'immortality' a basic PRESUPPOSITION of religion as such? -> 2020 Q5(b)

ALL THREE ARE MODAL QUESTIONS. Answer with the words 'necessary', 'sufficient' or 'neither' - not with a survey.

2. Necessary, sufficient, and why the distinction earns the marks ANALYSIS:

Modal claim	What it asserts	Test that settles it
Immortality is sufficient for rebirth	if a deathless soul exists and is karmically bound, re-embodiment follows	can we describe a case with the soul and without rebirth?
Immortality is necessary for rebirth	there can be no rebirth unless a deathless soul exists	one working counter-example refutes it
Neither	rebirth is independent of any soul-claim	requires showing rebirth needs no continuity at all - no school holds this

FACT: The counter-example is Buddhism, which affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*). Because a single counter-example is enough to defeat a necessity claim, the correct verdict is: **sufficient, not necessary**.

ANALYSIS: Note what this does *not* say. It does not say rebirth needs nothing. It says rebirth needs a **continuity-bearer**, and the schools disagree only about whether that bearer must be a substance.

3. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The printed clause is three words joined by semicolons - *Soul : Immortality; Rebirth and Liberation* - and this is the heaviest-loaded clause in Section B with **17 owned parts in eight papers**. The examiner is testing whether the candidate can impose the following order on it:

SEPARATE -> the six terms, in the first two lines
 LOCATE -> which link of the chain the stem is about
 STATE -> the substantialist position, named school by school
 COUNTER -> the Buddhist (or Sāṃkhya) case that breaks the implication
 VERDICT -> necessary / sufficient / neither, in those words

4. The one-line school map to carry into the hall ANALYSIS:

School	Continuity-bearer	Rebirth?	Terminus
Advaita Vedānta	self (<i>ātman</i>), ultimately identical with Brahman	yes	release (<i>mokṣa</i>), including while living
Viśiṣṭādvaita	eternal individual soul (<i>jīva</i>), a mode of God	yes	release as communion and service
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	eternal self-substance	yes	final cessation of pain (<i>apavarga</i>)
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	<i>puruṣa</i> as witness; <i>prakṛti</i> carries the subtle body	yes, but strictly <i>prakṛti</i> transmigrates	aloneness (<i>kaivalya</i>)
Jainism	eternal individual soul (<i>jīva</i>)	yes	perfected omniscient individuality
Buddhism	causal stream of dependently arisen aggregates	yes	extinguishing (<i>nirvāṇa</i>)
Semitic resurrection	the psychosomatic person re-constituted by God	no - one life	resurrection and judgement

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not equate immortality, resurrection and rebirth; they differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge and identity-bearer.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer a modal stem with a descriptive survey of schools; the words *necessary* and *sufficient* must appear.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Buddhism denies continuity. It denies a permanent substance-self, not the conventional person, not causal consequence and not rebirth.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not use "reincarnation" as a neutral synonym for rebirth; it carries a substantialist commitment Buddhism refuses.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not treat liberation as one state with several names; Session 9 exists because it is several states with one name.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not open with a definition of the soul; open with the term-separation, then define the soul the stem needs.

Revision notes

- The clause joins three separable claims: deathlessness, karmic re-embodiment, and exit from the series.
- The examined question is modal, not descriptive.
- A single counter-example defeats a necessity claim; Buddhism is that counter-example.
- Rebirth requires a continuity-bearer; schools differ on whether the bearer is a substance.
- Reincarnation presupposes substance; rebirth does not.
- Resurrection is one life, a divine act and an embodied person - a different structure entirely.
- Liberation is a family-resemblance word covering at least seven destinations.
- Seventeen owned question-parts in eight papers make structure worth more than novelty here.
- The correct headline verdict is "sufficient but not necessary".
- Term-separation in the opening two lines is the highest-yield habit in this clause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE SURVIVAL VOCABULARY AND THE NECESSITY QUESTION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW THE SURVIVAL VOCABULARY AND THE NECESSITY QUESTION			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS immortality · survival · rebirth (punarjanma/punarbhava) · reincarnation · resurrection · liberation · continuity-bearer · necessary versus sufficient	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Separate the terms, locate the link the stem is about, state the substantialist implication, then test it against a counter-example.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Substantialists read the chain as a straight implication; Buddhism breaks the first link while keeping rebirth.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not merge the terms and do not answer a modal question with a descriptive survey.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Immortality, rebirth and liberation are three separate claims joined by a disputed implication, and the whole examination value of this clause lies in refusing to let the words collapse into one another.			

SESSION 2 - SOUL, SELF, PERSON AND THE IDENTITY CRITERIA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Before asking whether you survive, you have to say what "you" is - a soul, a body, a stream of memories, or a whole embodied person.

Technical definition: Theories of the person divide into **substance** views (an immaterial thinking substance, or an enduring self), **hylomorphic** views (soul as the form of a living body), **bundle** views (a series without a permanent owner) and **embodied-person** views. Personal-identity criteria - bodily, psychological/memory, soul-substance and causal continuity - are then rival answers to *what makes the later being the same being*.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The survival debate is not settled by evidence about what happens after death but by a prior decision about what a person is, because each theory of the person makes a different kind of survival intelligible in the first place.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- substance dualism
- hylomorphism
- bundle theory / no-substantial-self
- embodied psychophysical unity
- bodily, psychological and causal criteria of identity
- replica theory (Hick)
- numerical versus qualitative identity

How to use them: Name the model of the person the school holds, derive the kind of survival it can support, then apply the identity criterion that model requires, and finish with the objection that model uniquely faces.

EXAM-READY LINE: Qualitative similarity, however perfect, is not numerical identity - which is why a duplicate that remembers everything is still, on the face of it, a duplicate.

FIVE MODELS OF THE PERSON -> FIVE KINDS OF SURVIVAL

MODEL	SURVIVAL IT ALLOWS	ITS OWN PRESSURE
SUBSTANCE DUALISM immaterial thinker	disembodied soul persists	interaction; what individuates souls
HYLOMORPHISM soul = form of body	resurrection of the embodied person	how the SAME person is re-constituted
BUNDLE / NO-SELF series, no owner	causal or psychological continuity	who is responsible; who is 'reborn'
EMBODIED PERSON psychophysical unity	re-creation or resurrection only	replica and duplication problems
INDIAN SUBSTANTIAL SELF (ātman/jīva)	transmigration of an enduring self	absence of past-life memory; evidence

THE QUESTION IS ALWAYS: WHAT IS THE CONTINUITY-BEARER?

1. The four identity criteria, and what each is for ANALYSIS:

Criterion	Says the later being is the same because...	Strength	Standard difficulty
Bodily continuity	it is the same living organism	matches ordinary practice and law	fails outright at death, and again in resurrection cases
Psychological / memory continuity	memory, character and intention run through	captures what we care about in survival	memory is circular (it presupposes identity), fallible and branchable
Soul-substance	one and the same immaterial substance persists	secures strict numerical identity	souls are unobservable, and individuation is hard to state
Causal continuity	the later state is causally descended from the earlier	works without any permanent owner	permits "neither the same nor wholly other", which strains ordinary identity talk

FACT: These criteria are not competing answers to *one* question. Bodily and psychological criteria answer *how we tell*; soul-substance and causal continuity answer *what makes it so*. A script that notices this is already writing at the top band.

2. Hick's replica thought experiment, in its exact form **FACT:**

The experiment is a **defence of resurrection identity**, not an argument for a natural immortal soul:

STAGE 1 A person disappears in one place and an exact psychophysical replica - same body-pattern, same memories, same character - appears in another place on earth.
 ↓ Ordinary criteria would, in practice, treat this as the same person.
 STAGE 2 The same thing happens at the moment of death.
 ↓
 STAGE 3 The replica appears not elsewhere on earth but in a DIFFERENT SPACE, a resurrection world.
 ↓
 HICK'S CLAIM: for all the purposes that matter - memory, character, recognition, responsibility - this IS the same person.

ANALYSIS: The duplication objection. If God can make one replica, God can make two. Two replicas cannot both be numerically identical with the original, because identity is one-to-one. So either the criterion is not identity, or identity depends on the accident that no rival was made. **Hick's reply** restricts the case to a *unique* replica and argues that our ordinary criteria are satisfied when there is no rival claimant. **The critic's rejoinder** is that the mere possibility of duplication already shows the criterion tracks similarity, not identity.

3. What each Indian school takes the bearer to be FACT:

- **Vedānta and Nyāya** take the bearer to be an **enduring self** - a substance, not a series. The subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*) carries dispositions, but it is not the self.
- **Jainism** takes it to be an **eternal individual soul (jīva)** whose extension varies with the body it occupies during bondage.
- **Sāṃkhya** is the subtle case: *puruṣa* is the witness and does **not** transmigrate; it is *prakṛti* in the form of the subtle body (*liṅga-śarīra*) that migrates.
- **Buddhism** takes it to be a **causal stream** of dependently arisen aggregates - continuity without an owner.

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: Two of the seventeen owned questions (2022 Q7(b) on liberation without a real agent, and 2022 Q5(c) on the Buddhist necessity claim) are *personal-identity* questions wearing Indian clothes. The candidate who has the criteria table can answer both without improvising.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat memory as the *definition* of identity; it presupposes what it is supposed to establish.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present the replica theory as proof of survival; it is a thought-experiment defence of the *coherence* of resurrection identity.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Sāṃkhya's *puruṣa* transmigrates; the school explicitly denies it.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse the subtle body with the self in Vedānta; the subtle body is an instrument of continuity, not the continuant.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not use "bundle theory" as a synonym for Buddhist no-self without noting that Buddhism adds a causal-conditioning account the bare bundle lacks.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude that because the criteria conflict, identity is meaningless; the exam wants the graded verdict, not scepticism.

Revision notes

- What survives depends on what a person is taken to be.
- Five models: substance dualism, hylomorphism, bundle, embodied person, Indian substantial self.
- Four criteria: bodily, psychological/memory, soul-substance, causal.
- Bodily and psychological criteria are evidential; substance and causal criteria are constitutive.
- Hick's replica defends the coherence of resurrection identity, not natural immortality.
- The duplication objection shows similarity is not identity.
- Vedānta and Nyāya: substance bearer. Jainism: eternal individual soul. Buddhism: causal stream.
- Sāṃkhya is the exception: *prakṛti*, not *puruṣa*, does the migrating.
- Memory's absence across lives is an objection to rebirth, answered by distinguishing memory from continuity.
- Naming the continuity-bearer is the structural move that unlocks half of this clause.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SOUL, SELF, PERSON AND THE IDENTITY CRITERIA

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | SOUL, SELF, PERSON AND THE IDENTITY CRITERIA

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

substance dualism · hylomorphism · bundle theory · embodied person · bodily/psychological/soul/causal criteria · replica theory · numerical versus qualitative identity

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Fix the model of the person, derive the survival it permits, apply the identity criterion it requires, then face the objection unique to it.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Substance views secure strict identity but must individuate souls; continuity views explain persistence but strain identity talk.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not define identity by memory and do not treat the replica as proof of survival.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The survival debate is not settled by evidence about what happens after death but by a prior decision about what a person is, because each theory of the person makes a different kind of survival intelligible in the first place.

SESSION 3 - PLATO'S FOUR A PRIORI PROOFS IN THE PHAEDO

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Plato tries to prove, by reasoning alone rather than by evidence, that the soul existed before the body and cannot be destroyed by the body's death.

Technical definition: The *Phaedo* offers four *a priori* arguments - from opposites (the cyclical argument), from recollection (*anamnesis*), from affinity, and the final argument from the Form of Life - each intended to establish either the soul's pre-existence, its indissolubility, or both.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Plato's four arguments are not four statements of one proof but four different attempts, and a critical examination must ask of each separately whether it establishes pre-existence, indestructibility, or merely the soul's resemblance to what is indestructible.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- cyclical argument (from opposites)
- recollection (*anamnesis*)
- argument from affinity
- final argument (the Form of Life)
- Simmias' harmony/attunement objection
- Kant's paralogism
- pre-existence versus post-mortem survival

How to use them: Take each argument in order, state its premise, state what it actually establishes, then attach the objection that fits *that* argument rather than a general complaint.

EXAM-READY LINE: The recollection argument, even if sound, establishes only that the soul existed *before* birth; it takes a second and independent step to show that it will exist *after* death.

THE FOUR ARGUMENTS AND WHAT EACH ACTUALLY BUYS

#	ARGUMENT	WHAT IT ESTABLISHES	OBJECTION THAT FITS IT
1	OPPOSITES / CYCLICAL living->dead->living	souls persist through the transition, both directions	the analogy from hot/cold to being/ not-being is weak
2	RECOLLECTION (anamnesis)	PRE-EXISTENCE only	needs a further step for survival
3	AFFINITY simple, invisible, akin to the Forms	likeness to the invisible and stable - hence indissoluble	resemblance is not identity; a simple thing may cease
4	FORM OF LIFE (the 'final' proof)	soul essentially brings Life, so cannot admit death	essential-predicate reasoning may show only that a LIVING soul is not dead

'CRITICALLY EXAMINE' = FOUR MINI-ASSESSMENTS, NOT ONE SUMMARY.

1. Argument from opposites (the cyclical argument) FACT:

Premise. Opposites come to be from their opposites: the larger from the smaller, the weaker from the stronger, waking from sleeping. **Application.** Being dead comes from being alive; so, if the symmetry holds, being alive must come from being dead. **Conclusion.** Souls must exist in some state between deaths, or the supply of the living would exhaust itself.

ANALYSIS: **Assessment.** The argument works well for *qualities that admit of degree* and much less well for existence and non-existence, which are not two ends of one continuum. It also gives at best a cosmic balance-sheet, not the survival of *this* soul.

2. Recollection (anamnesis) FACT:

Premise. We judge sensible things - two sticks, say - to be *deficiently* equal. **Step.** To judge a deficiency, one must already possess the standard, Equality itself, which no sense-experience supplies. **Conclusion.** The soul acquired that knowledge before embodiment; learning is recollection.

FACT: **Canonical example.** Equal sticks never perfectly instantiate Equality, and yet we judge their shortfall by a standard not derived from them alone.

ANALYSIS: **Assessment.** Even granted, this proves **pre-existence**, not post-mortem survival. Plato himself feels this, which is why the argument is combined with the cyclical one in the dialogue: pre-existence plus cyclical replacement is meant to close both directions.

3. The argument from affinity FACT:

Premise. There are two kinds of thing: the composite, visible, changing and perishable; and the non-composite, invisible, stable and imperishable. **Step.** The body resembles the first, the soul the second. **Conclusion.** The soul is akin to what is indissoluble, hence itself indissoluble.

ANALYSIS: **Assessment.** The argument is explicitly one of *likeness*, and Plato presents it with more caution than the summaries suggest. Resemblance to the imperishable does not entail imperishability; and simplicity itself is assumed rather than proved.

4. The final argument: the Form of Life FACT:

Premise. Some things bring a Form with them wherever they go: fire brings heat, snow brings cold. **Step.** Soul brings **Life** wherever it is. **Step.** What essentially brings a Form cannot admit that Form's opposite; snow cannot admit heat and remain snow. **Conclusion.** Soul cannot admit death; it is deathless, and therefore indestructible.

ANALYSIS: **Assessment.** The inference from "cannot admit the opposite" to "cannot cease to exist" needs a bridge. Fire does not become cold, but it does go out. The argument shows that a soul cannot be a *dead* soul; the critic asks why it may not simply cease.

5. Simmias' harmony objection - and Plato's reply FACT:

Objection. The soul is an attunement (*harmonia*) of bodily elements, as the tuning of a lyre is of its strings. When the instrument is destroyed the attunement perishes, however "divine and beautiful" it was.

Plato's twofold reply:

1. Recollection already establishes that the soul existed *before* the body - but an attunement cannot precede the instrument it tunes. So the two doctrines are incompatible, and Simmias must give one up.
2. Attunements admit of degree and never oppose their own components; the soul **rules** the body, opposing appetite and desire, which no attunement does.

ANALYSIS: This is the moment to note that the harmony objection is the ancient ancestor of every modern dependence argument from brain to mind.

6. The critique from the outside: Kant ANALYSIS:

FACT: Kant's **paralogisms of pure reason** argue that the "I think" which accompanies all representations gives us a formal unity of consciousness, not knowledge of a simple, persisting *substance*. Rational psychology mistakes a condition of thought for an object of knowledge. Immortality therefore cannot be theoretically demonstrated; in the second *Critique* it returns only as a **postulate of practical reason**, required by the moral law's demand for the complete good.

ANALYSIS: Note the sharp consequence for this clause: Kant does not refute immortality; he relocates it from proof to postulate - which is exactly the move the 2020 stem on immortality as a "basic presupposition" invites.

7. The Indian parallel, used carefully FACT:

The self (*ātman*) in Vedānta, the individual soul (*jīva*) in Jainism and the Nyāya self are all **eternal** in their systems, and the *Gītā* 2.23 gives the canonical image that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the embodied self.

ANALYSIS: But the Indian route is scriptural and systematic rather than *a priori* in Plato's sense, and the parallel must be stated as a comparison of conclusions, not of methods.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not merge the four arguments into one summary paragraph; the directive "critically examine" demands separate assessment.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not let recollection do the work of survival; it establishes pre-existence only.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit Simmias; the objection and Plato's two-part reply are inside the same dialogue and are frequently what separates bands.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not describe the affinity argument as a proof of identity with the Forms; it argues likeness.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute to Kant the claim that the soul does not exist; his claim is that it is not a knowable substance.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not import Indian eternity as though it supported Plato's method; the conclusions converge, the arguments do not.

Revision notes

- Four arguments: opposites, recollection, affinity, Form of Life.
- Recollection gives pre-existence; the cyclical argument is what closes the other direction.
- Affinity argues likeness to the indissoluble, not identity with it.
- The final argument works by essential predication: what brings Life cannot admit death.
- The bridge from "cannot admit death" to "cannot cease" is the argument's weak joint.
- Simmias: soul as attunement of the body; Plato replies from pre-existence and from the soul's rule over the body.
- Kant's paralogism: formal unity of apperception is not knowledge of a substance.
- Kant relocates immortality from theoretical proof to practical postulate.
- *Gītā* 2.23 gives the Indian conclusion, by a different route.
- Assess each argument on its own terms; that structure is the answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PLATO'S FOUR A PRIORI PROOFS IN THE PHAEDO

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | PLATO'S FOUR A PRIORI PROOFS IN THE PHAEDO

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

cyclical argument · recollection (anamnesis) · affinity · Form of Life · harmonia objection · paralogism · pre-existence versus survival

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Each argument has its own premise and its own yield; combine them only after seeing what each separately establishes.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Recollection secures the past direction, the cyclical argument the future one, affinity the soul's kind, and the final argument its essential predicate.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not summarise the four as one proof and do not forget Simmias' objection and Plato's twofold reply.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Plato's four arguments are not four statements of one proof but four different attempts, and a critical examination must ask of each separately whether it establishes pre-existence, indestructibility, or merely the soul's resemblance to what is indestructible.

SESSION 4 - THE FIVE ARGUMENT FAMILIES FOR IMMORTALITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Beyond Plato, arguments for life after death fall into a small number of recognisable families, and each fails in its own characteristic way.

Technical definition: The families are arguments from **simplicity/indivisibility**, from **identity/continuity**, from **moral order**, from **desire/fulfilment**, and from **religious experience/testimony**. Against all of them stands the **body/brain dependence** objection.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The arguments for immortality are strongest as expressions of what a moral and religious life presupposes and weakest as demonstrations of what is the case, which is why the honest verdict is that immortality is a postulate rather than a proof.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- simplicity and indivisibility
- persisting subject of responsibility
- moral order and the complete good
- natural desire for unending fulfilment
- testimony and interpretation
- body/brain dependence
- burden of proof

How to use them: Give the family, its core reasoning, the objection it uniquely faces, and then a single closing sentence that grades the whole set rather than repeating the objections.

EXAM-READY LINE: Dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions does not deductively refute survival, but it does shift the burden decisively onto the survivalist to supply an account of interaction, individuation and identity.

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FIVE FAMILIES -> FIVE CHARACTERISTIC FAILURES
SIMPLICITY -----> 'no parts, so cannot decompose'
  +-- objection: simplicity unproved; a simple subject may still cease
IDENTITY -----> 'responsibility needs a persisting subject'
  +-- objection: psychological/causal continuity may do the same work
MORAL ORDER -----> 'complete justice requires more than one life'
  +-- objection: expresses moral hope, not theoretical demonstration
DESIRE -----> 'a deep natural desire points to a possible object'
  +-- objection: desires can be frustrated or socially formed
EXPERIENCE -----> 'contact with the dead / the eternal self'
  +-- objection: interpretation, diversity, alternative explanations
      |
  ALL FIVE FACE: BODY/BRAIN DEPENDENCE
```

1. The five families, stated exactly FACT:

Argument family	Core reasoning	Main objection
Simplicity / indivisibility	an immaterial simple soul has no parts into which it could decompose	simplicity is not established, and even a simple subject could cease or depend on embodiment
Identity / continuity	stable agency, responsibility and first-person unity require a persisting subject	psychological or causal continuity may explain persistence without an immortal substance
Moral order	complete justice, or the highest good, requires survival beyond one life	postulation expresses moral hope; it does not amount to theoretical demonstration
Desire / fulfilment	a deep natural desire for unending fulfilment points toward a possible object	desires can be frustrated or socially formed; existence does not follow from longing
Religious experience / testimony	experiences interpreted as contact with the dead, or as realisation of an eternal self, support survival	interpretation, diversity of reports and alternative explanations prevent demonstrative force

2. The body/brain objection, stated fairly FACT:

The objection. Memory, personality, temperament, reasoning and even moral capacity vary systematically with bodily and cerebral conditions - injury, disease, chemistry, development and decline. If mind depends on brain in this thoroughgoing way, a mind persisting without a brain is at best unexplained.

ANALYSIS: What the objection does and does not do. It does not *deductively* prove that no subject can survive; dependence during embodied life is compatible with a further condition after it. What it does is **shift the burden**: the survivalist now owes an account of (i) how an immaterial subject interacts with a body at all, (ii) what individuates one such subject from another, and (iii) what makes the post-mortem subject the *same* one.

3. The moral-order family and Kant's postulate ANALYSIS:

FACT: This family deserves separate handling because it is the one the 2020 stem is built on. The claim is not that immortality is *proved* but that a certain moral outlook **presupposes** it: virtue and happiness do not coincide in this life, and the moral law commands a completion that a single life cannot supply.

ANALYSIS: Two costs must be stated. First, this is an argument from what morality requires to what is the case, and that inference is exactly what a critic denies. Second, whole religious systems function *without* it - early Hebrew religion is largely this-worldly, and Buddhism reaches liberation without any deathless soul - so the presupposition is not universal.

4. Grading the whole set ANALYSIS:

Band of claim	What it can support	What it cannot support
Demonstration	nothing, on the current arguments	a proof that survival obtains
Coherence	that survival is intelligible on some models of the person	that it is probable
Presupposition	that certain moral and religious practices assume it	that the assumption is true
Postulate	that practical reason may adopt it	that theoretical reason establishes it

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present any of the five as a demonstrative proof.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the brain-dependence objection as a disproof of survival; it is a burden-shifting consideration.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate the moral-order argument with the argument from desire; the first appeals to justice, the second to longing.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not cite paranormal or past-life case literature as evidence; the owner's discipline forbids it.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not say religion universally presupposes immortality; give the Hebrew and Buddhist qualifications.

6. ANALYSIS: Do not end on scepticism alone; give the graded verdict (coherent, presupposed, postulated, unproved).

Revision notes

- Five families: simplicity, identity, moral order, desire, experience.
- Each has a characteristic objection; the objections are not interchangeable.
- The simplicity argument needs simplicity, which is assumed rather than shown.
- The identity argument can be met by continuity accounts that need no substance.
- The moral-order argument gives a postulate, not a demonstration.
- Desire yields possibility of an object, never its existence.
- Experience arguments face interpretation and diversity.
- Body/brain dependence shifts the burden without closing the question.
- The survivalist owes interaction, individuation and identity accounts.
- The honest verdict: coherent on some models, presupposed by some practices, demonstrated by none.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE FIVE ARGUMENT FAMILIES FOR IMMORTALITY

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW THE FIVE ARGUMENT FAMILIES FOR IMMORTALITY			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS simplicity · persisting subject · moral order · natural desire · testimony · body/brain dependence · burden of proof · postulate	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT State each family's reasoning, attach its own objection, then grade the whole set by what level of claim it can support.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Coherence and presupposition are achievable; demonstration is not.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not turn brain-dependence into a disproof and do not make immortality a universal religious presupposition.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The arguments for immortality are strongest as expressions of what a moral and religious life presupposes and weakest as demonstrations of what is the case, which is why the honest verdict is that immortality is a postulate rather than a proof.			

SESSION 5 - IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL IN THE HINDU TRADITION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: In the Hindu traditions the self is not something that *has* deathlessness added to it; it is what never began and never ends, while everything we ordinarily call ourselves does.

Technical definition: The self (*ātman*) is beginningless and indestructible; embodiment is a temporary condition sustained by action and its unseen potency, and the subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*) carries latent dispositions (*saṃskāra* / *vāsanā*) from one embodiment to the next.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

In the Hindu traditions immortality is not a reward that follows death but the standing nature of the self, so that what death removes is a body and what liberation removes is an error.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- self (*ātman*)
- indestructibility (*Gītā* 2.23)
- change of garments (*Gītā* 2.22)
- subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*)
- latent dispositions (*saṃskāra* / *vāsanā*)
- beginningless (*anādi*) bondage
- eternal self-substance (*Nyāya*)

How to use them: State that eternity is the *nature* of the self rather than a consequence of anything, cite the verse precisely, distinguish the self from the subtle body, and then name the school-by-school differences rather than writing "Hinduism says".

EXAM-READY LINE: The *Gītā*'s images of worn-out garments and of indestructibility are not proofs but statements of what the tradition takes the self to be; the argumentative work is done by the schools that then explain how such a self can appear bound.

THE HINDU SELF: WHAT IS ETERNAL AND WHAT IS NOT

SELF (ĀTMAN)	eternal · unborn · indestructible Gītā 2.20, 2.23 - not slain when the body is slain; weapons, fire, water, wind fail
SUBTLE BODY (sūkṣma-śarīra)	NOT the self - an instrument carries dispositions (saṃskāra/vāsanā), mind, senses, vital breath across lives
GROSS BODY	discarded like worn-out garments (2.22)

THE ERROR TO AVOID: treating the subtle body as 'the soul'.
It is the vehicle of continuity, not the continuant.

1. The scriptural base, cited precisely FACT:

- **Gītā 2.22** - as a person discards worn-out garments and takes new ones, so the embodied self lays aside worn-out bodies and enters others. Use for **rebirth**.
- **Gītā 2.23** - weapons do not cut it, fire does not burn it, water does not wet it, wind does not wither it. Use for **indestructibility**.
- **Gītā 9.21** - those who have enjoyed heaven return to the world of mortals when their merit is exhausted. Use to show that **even heaven is inside the wandering-on**, not an escape from it.

CAUTION: Translations vary; paraphrase, or quote a named translation. Never invent a rendering and attribute it to the text.

2. Why the tradition is not one voice ANALYSIS:

School	What the eternal self is	What bondage is	What immortality therefore means
Advaita Vedānta	non-dual awareness identical with Brahman	ignorance (<i>avidyā</i>) superimposing individuality	never <i>acquired</i> ; realised when ignorance ends
Viśiṣṭādvaita	an eternal individual soul, a mode (<i>prakāra</i>) of God	karma and dependence, ended by knowledge, devotion and grace	eternal personal existence in communion, never absorption
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	an eternal self-substance to which consciousness is adventitious	connection with body, senses and the qualities that generate pain	endless existence of the substance - but in release, <i>without</i> consciousness
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	<i>puruṣa</i> , pure contentless witness, plural	non-discrimination (<i>aviveka</i>) of <i>puruṣa</i> from <i>buddhi</i>	consciousness was never actually bound; isolation is recovered, not gained
Jainism (allied on eternity)	an eternal individual soul (<i>jīva</i>)	karmic matter adhering through passion	perfected omniscient individuality after shedding karma

ANALYSIS: This table is what makes a 20-mark answer. "Hindu tradition" is not a position; it is a field with at least four positions on what the deathless thing *is*.

3. The argumentative supports the tradition actually offers ANALYSIS:

1. **Continuity of the knower.** Waking, dream and deep sleep vary, and are known as varying; the witness that knows their variation is not one of them.
2. **Moral bookkeeping.** Action and its fruit are separated in time, often by more time than a life provides; a continuant is required for desert to be discharged.
3. **Scriptural testimony (śabda).** In supersensible matters, the schools accept scripture as a valid means of knowledge - a claim that must be *named as a presupposition*, not smuggled in.
4. **Beginninglessness.** Bondage is *anādi*, without beginning; this blocks the question "when did the soul first fall?" which so troubles the Western Fall narrative.

4. The standard objection, and the standard reply ANALYSIS:

Objection. If I am the same continuant, why do I remember nothing of earlier lives? **Reply.** Memory is neither necessary nor sufficient for metaphysical continuity; what carries over is dispositional (*saṃskāra* / *vāsanā*), not episodic; and forgetfulness within a single life already shows that memory is a poor criterion. **CAUTION:** The reply is coherent, but empirical warrant remains contested and must not be over-claimed.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write "Hinduism believes" where the schools differ; name Advaita, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Nyāya and Sāṃkhya separately.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse the subtle body with the self.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat heaven as liberation; *Gītā* 9.21 explicitly returns the meritorious to the world.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not quote the *Gītā* in a fixed English wording as if it were the text; paraphrase or attribute the translation.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present scriptural testimony as neutral evidence; it is a school-specific means of knowledge.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not describe the Nyāya self's immortality as blissful; consciousness itself is absent in release.

Revision notes

- Eternity of the self is a nature, not an acquisition.
- *Gītā* 2.22 for rebirth, 2.23 for indestructibility, 9.21 for heaven-inside-saṃsāra.
- The subtle body carries dispositions; it is not the continuant.
- Advaita: non-dual awareness. Viśiṣṭādvaita: eternal individual soul in communion.
- Nyāya: eternal substance, consciousness adventitious. Sāṃkhya: plural contentless witness.
- Supports: continuity of the knower, moral bookkeeping, scriptural testimony, beginninglessness.
- Beginninglessness blocks the "when did it start?" question.
- The memory objection is answered by distinguishing dispositional from episodic memory.
- Empirical warrant for rebirth remains contested; say so.
- 2021 Q6(a) wants exactly this school-differentiated treatment.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL IN THE HINDU TRADITION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL IN THE HINDU TRADITION			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS ātman · <i>Gītā</i> 2.22, 2.23, 9.21 · sūkṣma-śarīra · saṃskāra/vāsanā · anādi bondage · śabda	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Eternity is the self's nature; embodiment and its instruments are what change, and the schools differ on what the eternal thing is.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Advaitic non-duality, Viśiṣṭādvaitic communion, Nyāya's unconscious substance and Sāṃkhya's contentless witness are four different immortalities.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not write 'Hinduism believes', and do not turn the subtle body into the soul.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: In the Hindu traditions immortality is not a reward that follows death but the standing nature of the self, so that what death removes is a body and what liberation removes is an error.			

SESSION 6 - KARMA AS MORAL CAUSATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Karma is the claim that morally weighted actions leave a real trace which later produces a matching result, whether or not anyone is watching.

Technical definition: Karma is action together with its **unseen potency** (*adṛṣṭa* in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, *apūrva* in Mīmāṃsā), classified as **stored (sañcita)**, **already-fructifying (prārabdha)** and **future (āgāmi)**; it is a law of moral causation operating within a beginningless series, not a decree.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Karma is best read not as a doctrine of fate but as the claim that the moral order is causal rather than administrative - that desert is discharged by the structure of the world, and not by the decision of a judge.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- unseen potency (*adr̥ṣṭa* / *apūrvā*)
- stored (*sañcita*), fructifying (*prārabdha*), future (*āgāmi*)
- human effort (*puruṣakāra*) versus destiny (*daiva*)
- beginningless (*anādi*)
- desireless action (*niṣkāma-karma*)
- karma-superintendent (*karmādhyaṁṣa*) in the theistic schools

How to use them: Define karma as act-plus-potency, give the threefold classification, show why it is not fatalism, then state the one qualification that protects the answer - explanation is not permission to blame the sufferer.

EXAM-READY LINE: If karma were fatalism it would make effort pointless, but the classification into stored, fructifying and future karma exists precisely to locate where effort still operates.

THE THREEFOLD KARMA LEDGER - AND WHERE FREEDOM LIVES

SAÑCITA	the whole accumulated store, not yet ripening	
(stored)	-> can be burnt by liberating knowledge	
PRĀRABDHA	the portion already ripening - this birth,	
(fructifying)	this body, this span	
	-> NOT cancelled by knowledge; runs its course	
ĀGĀMI	what present action is now generating	
(future)	-> the liberated agent accumulates none	
↑		
FREEDOM ACTS HERE		
effort (<i>puruṣakāra</i>) works on <i>āgāmi</i> and, through knowledge, on <i>sañcita</i> - never on <i>prārabdha</i> .		

1. Act and its unseen potency FACT:

An act does not simply happen and vanish. It leaves an efficacy that persists until it matures. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika calls this **unseen potency** (*adr̥ṣṭa*) and treats it as a quality of the self; Mīmāṃsā calls the ritual analogue **apūrvā**, the "not-previously-existing" capacity by which a sacrifice produces its distant result. Both exist to solve one problem: **how a past act can produce a future effect across a temporal gap.**

2. Why this is not fatalism ANALYSIS:

Fatalism says	Karma theory says
what happens is fixed and effort is idle	fructifying karma fixes the <i>conditions</i> , not the response
there is no point in acting	present action generates future karma, so acting is exactly the point
the agent is a patient	the agent is both inheritor and author
moral striving is decorative	moral striving is the only lever available

FACT: The traditional formula is **effort (*puruṣakāra*) within destiny (*daiva*)**: the hand dealt is inherited, the play is not.

3. Who administers the law? FACT:

- **Non-theistic route (Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā):** the law is **self-regulating**. No judge is required; the moral order is built into how things work.
- **Theistic route (Nyāya, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Dvaita):** God is the **superintendent (*karmādhyaṁṣa*)** who *ratifies* and dispenses the fruits of karma rather than inventing the desert. God does not decide that cruelty deserves suffering; God ensures the fruit is delivered.

ANALYSIS: Naming this fork is what turns a description of karma into a philosophical answer, and it is exactly what the 2021 "essential postulate" stem is testing.

4. Karma as an essential postulate - how to argue it ANALYSIS:

The claim is not that Hindus happen to believe in karma but that removing it would break other commitments:

1. **Without karma, the distribution of fortune is arbitrary**, and the tradition's answer to unequal suffering collapses.
2. **Without karma, rebirth loses its rationale** - there would be nothing that requires a further life.
3. **Without karma, liberation has no content** - there would be no bondage to be freed from.
4. **Without karma, ritual and ethical injunction lose their efficacy** in the Mīmāṃsā framework.

ANALYSIS: **The costs, stated honestly.** (a) It is **unverifiable**, since the postulated links are not observable. (b) It risks **victim-blaming**, if present suffering is read as evidence of past fault. (c) It can appear to make God either redundant or subordinate to the law. **Replies:** unverifiability is shared with every eschatology; explanatory karma does not license social judgement, and the duty of compassion is untouched; and the theistic schools answer the third point by making God the *administrator* rather than the *author* of desert.

5. Karma and the two kinds of freedom ANALYSIS:

The *Gītā*'s **desireless action (niṣkāma-karma)** is not an exception to the law but its use: action performed without appropriating the fruit generates no binding residue. That is why the tradition can command action while holding that action binds.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not translate karma as "fate"; the threefold classification exists to defeat that reading.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not use the debt analogy as an explanation; the owner marks it as an analogy that must not replace a school's own causal account.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not make God the *author* of desert in the theistic schools; God is its superintendent.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the victim-blaming control in any karma answer.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not say karma requires theism; Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā run it without a God.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *prārabdha* as cancellable by knowledge; that error destroys the *jīvanmukti* answer later.

Revision notes

- Karma is act plus unseen potency (*adr̥ṣṭa / apūrva*).
- Threefold: stored, already-fructifying, future.
- Effort works on future and, via knowledge, on stored karma - never on fructifying karma.
- Effort within destiny is the traditional formulation, not fatalism.
- Self-regulating in Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā; superintended by God in Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas.
- As an essential postulate it underwrites distribution, rebirth, liberation and injunction.
- Costs: unverifiability, victim-blaming risk, and the God-and-law problem.
- Replies: shared unverifiability, no licence for blame, God as administrator.
- Desireless action uses the law rather than escaping it.
- The 2021 Q8(b) stem wants postulate-status argued, not karma described.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - KARMA AS MORAL CAUSATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW KARMA AS MORAL CAUSATION			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS adr̥ṣṭa/apūrva · sañcita · prārabdha · āgāmi · puruṣakāra/daiva · anādi · niṣkāma-karma · karmādhyaḥkṣa	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Act plus potency, stored and ripening in a beginningless series, with effort operating on what is not yet fructifying.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Self-regulating law without a judge in the anti-theistic schools; divinely superintended dispensation in the theistic ones.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not equate karma with fate and never omit the control against blaming the sufferer.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Karma is best read not as a doctrine of fate but as the claim that the moral order is causal rather than administrative — that desert is discharged by the structure of the world, and not by the decision of a judge.			

SESSION 7 - REBIRTH AND THE WANDERING-ON

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Rebirth is the claim that death is not the end of the story but a chapter break - the moral momentum of a life carries into another one.

Technical definition: Rebirth (*punarjanma*; Buddhist *punarbhava*) is karmically conditioned re-embodiment of a continuant within **saṃsāra**, the beginningless wandering-on, and it continues until liberation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Rebirth is not an ornament on karma theory but its enabling condition: it is the widened temporal field without which a moral law of desert would have to be abandoned or radically qualified.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- wandering-on (saṃsāra)
- rebirth (punarjanma)
- beginningless (anādi)
- subtle body (sūkṣma-śarīra)
- latent dispositions (saṃskāra / vāsanā)
- exhaustion of merit (Gītā 9.21)
- temporal field for karmic maturation

How to use them: State the function rebirth performs for karma theory *before* describing it; then the description reads as argument rather than as narrative.

EXAM-READY LINE: One life is too short for a moral law that is exceptionless, so rebirth is what allows the law to be exceptionless without being visibly false.

WHY KARMA NEEDS REBIRTH - THE FIT-PROBLEM

```
[-----]
| CLAIM: every morally weighted act matures into its result |
| FACT : many acts plainly do not mature within one lifetime |
| GAP : the good suffer, the cruel prosper, and infants suffer |
|         before they can have acted at all |
|-----+-----|
| THREE POSSIBLE EXITS |
| (a) abandon the exceptionless claim |
| (b) postulate a final judge and one post-mortem settlement |
|     -> the SEMITIC route: resurrection and judgement |
| (c) widen the FIELD of maturation across many lives |
|     -> the INDIAN route: rebirth within saṃsāra |
|-----+-----|
```

REBIRTH IS EXIT (c). THAT IS ITS PHILOSOPHICAL SIGNIFICANCE.

1. What rebirth actually contributes FACT:

- It **widens the temporal field** in which karmic consequences can mature beyond a single life, which is precisely the significance the 2023 stem asks about.
- It **explains initial inequality** without an arbitrary allocation: the conditions of birth are consequences rather than impositions.
- It **secures beginninglessness**: because the series has no first term, there is no "original fault" to be explained, as there is in the Fall narrative.
- ANALYSIS: It also **relocates the problem**: an infinite regress of conditioning explains each birth by an earlier one and never explains the series as a whole. State this as the cost, not as a refutation.

2. The mechanism, school-neutral then school-specific FACT:

School-neutral: dispositions formed by action persist; at death the gross body is discarded; the dispositions, carried by a subtle vehicle or by causal conditioning, determine the next embodiment.

School	Vehicle of continuity	Note
Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita	subtle body (<i>sūkṣma-śarīra</i>) with mind, senses and vital breath	the self is the continuant; the subtle body is its instrument
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	the eternal self, bearing unseen potency (<i>adr̥ṣṭa</i>)	the self itself carries the moral residue
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	subtle body (<i>līṅga-śarīra</i>), a product of <i>prakṛti</i>	FACT: strictly, <i>prakṛti</i> transmigrates; <i>puruṣa</i> does not
Jainism	the soul (<i>jīva</i>) with adhering karmic matter	karma is quasi-material, hence literally weighing the soul down
Buddhism	causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates	no vehicle-substance at all - see Session 8

3. The Gītā's own statement, used precisely FACT:

- **2.22** - as worn-out garments are discarded for new ones, so the embodied self takes new bodies. This is the standard **illustration** of rebirth, not an argument for it.
- **9.21** - those who have enjoyed the heavenly world return when their merit is exhausted. FACT: This is high-value: it shows that **heaven is a stage inside the wandering-on**, so a Hindu answer must not present heaven as the terminus.

4. The objections, and how far the replies go ANALYSIS:

Objection	Reply	Residue
No memory of past lives	memory is not the criterion of metaphysical continuity; what persists is dispositional	CAUTION: the reply preserves coherence but supplies no positive evidence
Unverifiable in principle	untestability is shared with resurrection and judgement; it is not a special defect of rebirth	ANALYSIS: shared unverifiability lowers the cost, it does not remove it
Morally hazardous	karma explains distribution without licensing social judgement of the sufferer; compassion remains obligatory	the risk is real and the answer must name it
Infinite regress	beginninglessness is a positive doctrine (<i>anādi</i>), not an oversight	the series as a whole remains unexplained

5. Why UPSC cares

FACT: The 2023 15-marker asks for the **significance** of rebirth *in the theory of karma* - not for a description of rebirth. The examiner is buying the functional analysis in the diagram above: rebirth is the exit that lets the moral law stay exceptionless.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not describe rebirth when the stem asks for its significance.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not present heaven as liberation; 9.21 forbids it.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the subtle body as the self.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit beginninglessness; it is what blocks the "first sin" question.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not offer past-life case reports as evidence.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not claim rebirth solves the problem of evil outright; it redistributes the explanandum and carries its own costs.

Revision notes

- Rebirth is karmically conditioned re-embodiment within a beginningless series.
- Its function is to widen the field of karmic maturation.
- Rival exits: abandon the law, or a single judgement (the Semitic route).
- Beginninglessness removes the need for a first fault.
- The subtle body carries dispositions in the Vedāntic and Sāṃkhya schools.

- In Sāṃkhya it is strictly *prakṛti* that migrates.
- *Gītā* 2.22 illustrates; 9.21 shows heaven is inside the series.
- Objections: memory, unverifiability, moral hazard, regress.
- Replies preserve coherence but do not supply positive evidence.
- The 2023 stem is a *function* question, not a description question.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - REBIRTH AND THE WANDERING-ON

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW REBIRTH AND THE WANDERING-ON			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS saṃsāra · punarjanma · anādi · sūkṣma/līṅga-śarīra · saṃskāra/vāsanā · Gītā 2.22 and 9.21	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Karma claims exceptionless maturation; one life cannot deliver it; rebirth widens the field instead of weakening the claim.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The Semitic alternative concentrates settlement into a single judgement; the Indian route distributes it across a beginningless series.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not describe when asked for significance, and never make heaven the terminus.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Rebirth is not an ornament on karma theory but its enabling condition: it is the widened temporal field without which a moral law of desert would have to be abandoned or radically qualified.			

SESSION 8 - REBIRTH WITHOUT A PERMANENT SELF: THE BUDDHIST COUNTER-EXAMPLE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Buddhism keeps rebirth but drops the soul - what continues is not a thing that travels but a process that keeps causing its own next stage.

Technical definition: No permanent self (*anātman*; **Pali: anattā**) denies an unchanging, independent self among or behind the aggregates; **dependent origination** (*pratītyasamutpāda*) supplies the conditioning that makes re-becoming (*punarbhava*) intelligible without a transmigrating substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism is the decisive counter-example in this clause because it holds together the two things the substantialist says cannot be held together - a denial of any permanent self, and a full doctrine of rebirth and moral consequence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- no permanent self (*anātman* / *anattā*)
- dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*)
- re-becoming (*punarbhava*)
- aggregates (*skandha*)
- causal stream / continuum (*santāna*)
- neither the same nor wholly other
- craving (*tṛṣṇā*) and formations (*saṃskāra*)

How to use them: Set out the argument in numbered steps, then immediately answer the "who is reborn?" objection, because the examiner will not credit the doctrine until the objection is met.

EXAM-READY LINE: The later stream is neither the same as nor wholly other than the earlier one, and that formula is not an evasion but a rejection of the assumption that identity must be all-or-nothing.

(1) ALL CONDITIONED FACTORS ARE IMPERMANENT

1

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flame -> flame : the second lamp is lit from the first;
                same fire? no. unrelated fire? also no.
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milk -> curd    : continuous transformation, not identity
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4. The modal verdict, stated in the examiner's own vocabulary ANALYSIS:

CLAIM UNDER TEST: 'Immortality of the soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth.'

|

SUBSTANTIALIST SYSTEMS (Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism)

+-- YES: a persisting self is what transmigrates

|

BUDDHISM

+-- NO: causal continuity of a conditioned stream suffices

|

ONE COUNTER-EXAMPLE DEFEATS A NECESSITY CLAIM

|

VERDICT: an immortal soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth, NOT NECESSARY. What rebirth requires is a CONTINUITY-BEARER, and the dispute is only about whether that bearer must be a substance.

5. Why this is the hinge of the whole clause ANALYSIS:

Three of the seventeen owned questions (2022 Q5(c), 2024 Q6(a), 2025 Q7(c)) are necessity questions, and one more (2018 Q5(b)) turns on the anti-theistic implications of the same doctrine. A candidate who has this verdict and its qualification has the spine of four answers.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say Buddhism denies rebirth; it denies a permanent self while affirming rebirth.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say Buddhism denies continuity; it denies substance.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use the flame analogy as a proof.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not report the doctrine without meeting the "who is reborn?" objection.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not claim the reply is conclusive; state the residual pressure on responsibility.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not describe final extinguishing (*parinirvāṇa*) as annihilation of a self; the tradition refuses both survival-language and annihilation-language here.

Revision notes

- No permanent self plus dependent origination equals rebirth without a transmigrating substance.
- Four steps: impermanence, no aggregate is self, craving and formations condition, continuity without owner.
- Denied: a permanent owner. Not denied: the conventional person, moral consequence, rebirth.
- The responsibility objection is answered by causal descent, not by identity.
- "Neither the same nor wholly other" is the operative formula.
- Flame-to-flame and milk-to-curd are illustrations, never proofs.
- The verdict: immortality is sufficient, not necessary, for rebirth.
- What rebirth requires is a continuity-bearer.
- Buddhism is a counter-example, not an exception.
- Four of the seventeen owned questions depend directly on this session.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - REBIRTH WITHOUT A PERMANENT SELF

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW REBIRTH WITHOUT A PERMANENT SELF: THE BUDDHIST COUNTER-EXAMPLE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS anātman/anattā · pratīyasamutpāda · punarbhava · skandha · santāna · neither the same nor wholly other · tṛṣṇā	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Impermanence and the non-selfhood of the aggregates, plus craving-conditioned formations, yield renewed becoming without an owner.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Substantialist systems make immortality necessary; Buddhism shows continuity alone suffices, so the necessity claim fails.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not equate no-self with no-continuity and do not treat the flame illustration as proof.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is the decisive counter-example in this clause because it holds together the two things the substantialist says cannot be held together — a denial of any permanent self, and a full doctrine of rebirth and moral consequence.			

SESSION 9 - THE LIBERATION PARITY BENCH: SEVEN DESTINATIONS, ONE WORD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: "Liberation" is one English word doing duty for at least seven different destinations, and the schools that use it do not agree about where you end up.

Technical definition: *Mokṣa* (Advaita), *mokṣa* (Viśiṣṭādvaita), *apavarga* (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika), *kaivalya* (Sāṃkhya-Yoga), Jain liberation or perfection (*mokṣa/siddhahood*), *nirvāṇa* (Buddhism) and **resurrection** (Semitic) differ in what ends, what remains, and whether consciousness is present at all.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Liberation is a family-resemblance term rather than the name of a state, and once *apavarga*, *kaivalya*, *mokṣa* and *nirvāṇa* are separated, the apparent Indian consensus turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering incompatible destinations.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- release (*mokṣa*)
- final cessation of pain (*apavarga*)
- aloneness (*kaivalya*)
- extinguishing (*nirvāṇa*)
- perfected omniscient individuality (Jain)
- resurrection
- family-resemblance term

How to use them: Whenever a stem names a liberation term, fix it against this bench in the opening lines, then answer only for that term.

EXAM-READY LINE: Half the marks in this clause are lost to term-merging, and the single most efficient defence is to state, in one sentence, what ends and what remains on the school's own account.

THE PARITY BENCH - THE HIGHEST-VALUE TABLE IN THE TOPIC

TERM	SCHOOL	WHAT ENDS	WHAT REMAINS	CONSCIOUS?
MOKṢA (release)	Advaita	ignorance (avidyā)	Brahman alone	YES, self-luminous
MOKṢA (release)	Viśiṣṭādvaita	karmic bondage	eternal jīva WITH God	YES, personal
APAVARGA (cessation)	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	pain AND its conditions	the self-substance	NO - no bliss, no awareness
KAIVALYA (aleness)	Sāṃkhya-Yoga	non-discrimination	puruṣa, isolated	YES, pure contentless
LIBERATION (siddhahood)	Jainism	karmic matter	perfected omniscient jīva	YES, four infinitudes
NIRVĀṆA (extinguish)	Buddhism	craving, ignorance, suffering	CAUTION: not stated as a self	ANALYSIS: neither 'survival' nor 'annihilation'
RESURRECTION (raising)	Semitic	death	the embodied person	YES, embodied, before God

1. The four structural questions the bench answers ANALYSIS:

- Is liberation identity, communion, cessation, isolation or perfection?** Advaita says identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita communion; Nyāya cessation; Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation; Jainism perfection; Buddhism refuses the question's substantialist form.
- Is individuality preserved?** Preserved in Viśiṣṭādvaita, Jainism, Nyāya and Sāṃkhya-Yoga; sublated in Advaita; not applicable in Buddhism.
- Is consciousness present?** Present everywhere except Nyāya *apavarga*, which is the position most often misstated in scripts.
- Is it attainable while alive?** Advaita and Sāṃkhya-Yoga say yes (embodied liberation); Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas locate release at or after the fall of the body.

2. Positive perfection versus mere cessation ANALYSIS:

FACT: Advaita and Jainism portray a fulfilment-rich liberation - non-dual bliss in the first, the four infinitudes (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*: infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy) in the second. Nyāya stresses cessation of pain. Buddhism resists both crude annihilation and hedonistic fulfilment models.

Objection. A cessation-only liberation seems unattractive or empty. **Reply.** Nyāya values final freedom *from suffering*, not experiential luxury; offering more would be dishonest about what the school's metaphysics allows, since consciousness is adventitious to the self. Sāṃkhya makes the same refusal explicitly: *kaivalya* is not bliss, it is the ending of the threefold suffering.

3. The two terminological traps in one place ANALYSIS:

Trap	Correct statement
Treating <i>kaivalya</i> as a synonym for <i>mokṣa</i>	<i>Kaivalya</i> is isolation of contentless consciousness in Sāṃkhya-Yoga; <i>mokṣa</i> is identity or communion in Vedānta
Treating Jain <i>kevala</i> as Sāṃkhya <i>kaivalya</i>	Jain <i>kevala-jñāna</i> is omniscience - the opposite content of Sāṃkhya's contentless isolation. Same syllable, opposite content

4. Why UPSC cares

FACT: Four owned questions name a liberation term directly - 2024 Q5(c) *apavarga*, 2025 Q5(d) *jīvanmukti*, 2021 Q6(b) Advaita liberation, 2022 Q7(b) Advaita versus Viśiṣṭādvaita - and two more turn on whether liberation is "robust" (2024 Q6(a)) or attainable by devotion (2018 Q7(c)). The bench is therefore load-bearing in six of seventeen answers.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not make all Indian liberation doctrines a merger with God; only some are theistic and none but Advaita is identity.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not describe Nyāya *apavarga* as positive bliss.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use *kaivalya* and *mokṣa* interchangeably.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse Jain *kevala* (omniscience) with Sāṃkhya *kaivalya* (isolation).
5. ANALYSIS: Do not describe *nirvāṇa* as the survival or the annihilation of a self.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not treat resurrection as a species of liberation; it is re-embodiment, not exit from a cycle.

Revision notes

- Seven destinations, one English word.
- Advaita: identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita: communion; Nyāya: cessation; Sāṃkhya-Yoga: isolation; Jainism: perfection; Buddhism: extinguishing of craving.
- Consciousness is absent only in Nyāya release.
- Individuality is sublated only in Advaita.
- Embodied liberation is available in Advaita and Sāṃkhya-Yoga.
- Four infinitudes belong to Jain liberation.
- *Kevala* in Jainism means omniscience; *kaivalya* in Sāṃkhya means isolation.
- Cessation-only liberation is defended as honest, not as attractive.
- Resurrection is on the bench as a contrast, not as an Indian variant.
- Fix the named term in the first two lines of any liberation answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE LIBERATION PARITY BENCH

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW THE LIBERATION PARITY BENCH: SEVEN DESTINATIONS, ONE WORD			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS mokṣa · apavarga · kaivalya · nirvāṇa · siddhahood · ananta-catuṣṭaya · resurrection	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT For each school, state what ends, what remains and whether consciousness is present; the differences then do the analytic work.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Identity, communion, cessation, isolation, perfection and extinguishing are not variants of one destination.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not merge terms, and never describe Nyāya release as blissful.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Liberation is a family-resemblance term rather than the name of a state, and once apavarga, kaivalya, mokṣa and nirvāṇa are separated, the apparent Indian consensus turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering incompatible destinations.			

SESSION 10 - VEDĀNTIC SELF, RELEASE AND EMBODIED LIBERATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Both Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita say the self is eternal and bound, but they disagree about whether liberation ends your individuality or perfects it.

Technical definition: Advaita locates bondage in **ignorance (avidyā)** and release in the knowledge that the self is non-different from Brahman, permitting **liberation while living (jīvanmukti)**; Viśiṣṭādvaita locates bondage in **karma and dependence** and release in eternal communion of an individual soul with God, reached through knowledge, devotion and grace.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Advaita-Viśiṣṭādvaita dispute is not about how liberation is reached but about what is left when it is: the removal of a mistaken individuality in the one, and the perfection of a real individual in the other.

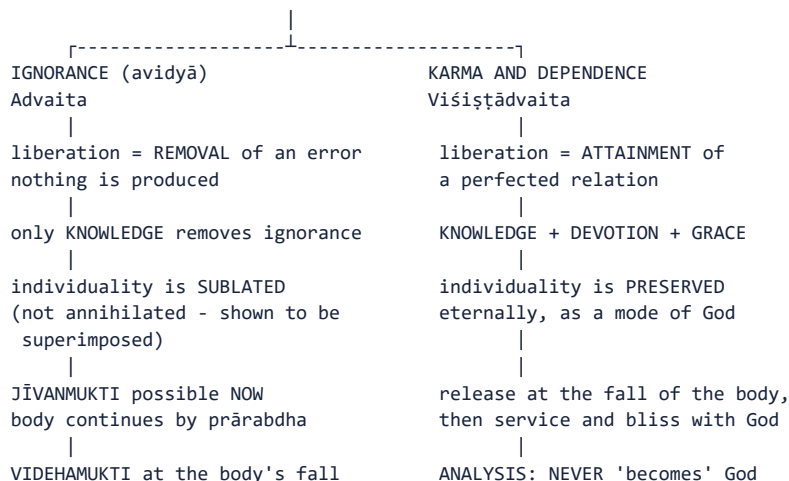
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- ignorance (avidyā) and its removal
- liberation while living (jīvanmukti)
- liberation at the fall of the body (videhamukti)
- already-fructifying karma (prārabdha)
- hearing, reflecting, meditating (śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana)
- mode of God (prakāra) and eternal soul (jīva)
- self-surrender (prapatti)

How to use them: Answer the "what remains?" question first, then derive the means from it; this is what makes the answer analytic rather than descriptive.

EXAM-READY LINE: If liberation is the *removal* of an error, only knowledge can remove it; if it is a *relation* to be attained, devotion and grace are intelligible as its means - and the whole dispute follows from that single fork.

ADVAITA versus VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA - ONE FORK, MANY CONSEQUENCES
WHAT IS BONDAGE?



1. Advaita: how knowledge liberates FACT:

1. **Diagnosis.** Bondage is not a real chain but a **cognitive error**: the self, which is non-different from Brahman, is taken to be a limited individual.
2. **Consequence.** Liberation cannot be a *product*. What is produced can be destroyed; the self's freedom is eternally accomplished (*siddha*) and merely obscured.
3. **Means.** Only knowledge removes ignorance, as light removes darkness. Ritual action and worship purify the mind (*citta-śuddhi*) and confer eligibility, but cannot produce what already is.
4. **Discipline.** The fourfold qualification (*sādhana-catustaya*: discrimination, dispassion, the six inner accomplishments, and the desire for release) precedes **hearing, reflecting and meditating** on the scriptural teaching.

2. Jīvanmukti, and the prārabdha problem FACT:

The doctrine. The knower of Brahman is free **now**; liberation is not postponed to death. The body persists because **already-fructifying karma (prārabdha)** has begun to ripen and is not cancelled by knowledge; at its exhaustion the body falls, and this is **videhamukti**.

FACT: The canonical image: the potter's wheel continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn - bodily momentum after ignorance is destroyed.

ANALYSIS: **The objection.** If ignorance is destroyed, why does the empirical person remain active at all? **Reply.** Advaita distinguishes the destruction of *bondage* - stored and future karma - from the residual momentum of an embodiment already under way. **Residue:** critics reply that a trace of ignorance seems to be smuggled back in to explain continued embodied experience; the school answers by locating the residue in the body-mind complex rather than in the knower.

3. Viśiṣṭādvaita: why an individual must remain FACT:

- The soul (*jīva*) is an **eternal individual**, a mode (*prakāra*) of God, real and never absorbed.
- Bondage is beginningless karma and the dependence it produces, not a mistake about identity.
- Liberation is **communion and service** in the bliss of God - the soul reaches God, and does not become God.
- The means culminate in **devotion (bhakti)** as steady loving recollection (*dhruvānusmṛti*), with **self-surrender (prapatti / śaraṇāgati)** as the equally efficacious and universally accessible alternative for those who lack the qualifications devotion requires. Liberation is finally by **grace**.

4. "Liberation without a real agent?" - the 2022 question, solved structurally ANALYSIS:

THE QUESTION: can liberation be conceived without a real agent?

ADVAITA'S ANSWER: YES, and it must be.

- agency belongs to the empirical individual, which is superimposed
- at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*) there is no agent, no bondage and hence no one who is literally liberated
- the tradition itself says bondage and release are 'from the standpoint of ignorance'

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA'S ANSWER: NO.

- an unreal agent cannot have real bondage, real striving, real devotion or a real reward
- liberation must happen TO someone, so the *jīva* is eternally real

THE HONEST VERDICT: each position pays a price.

Advaita must explain how an unreal individual undertakes a real discipline; Viśiṣṭādvaita must explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless wholly dependent on God.

5. The role of knowledge, stated for the 2021 stem ANALYSIS:

The 2021 15-marker has **two** obligations - the concept of liberation *and* the role of knowledge. The role must be stated in the removal-model vocabulary: knowledge is not one contributory cause among others but the **only** operative cause, because the obstacle is cognitive. Everything else is either qualification or purification.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say the individual soul is annihilated in Advaita; it is shown to have been superimposed.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say the soul becomes God in Viśiṣṭādvaita; it reaches and serves God.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *jīvanmukti* as a lower or partial liberation; it is full liberation with an embodiment still running.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not say knowledge destroys *prārabdha*; that is exactly what it does not do.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2021 stem with liberation alone; the role of knowledge is a second, equally weighted demand.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not present Advaita as denying the empirical world; it assigns it a level (*vyāvahārika*), which is a different claim.

Revision notes

- Advaita: bondage is ignorance; liberation is removal; only knowledge removes.
- Viśiṣṭādvaita: bondage is karma and dependence; liberation is attained communion.
- Advaita sublates individuality; Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves it eternally.
- *Jīvanmukti* is liberation while living; *videhamukti* at the body's fall.
- *Prārabdha* explains the continuing body; the potter's wheel is the image.
- Stored and future karma are destroyed by knowledge; fructifying karma is not.
- Viśiṣṭādvaita's means: knowledge, devotion, self-surrender, grace.

- The real-agent question exposes the price each side pays.
- Knowledge is the sole operative cause on the removal model.
- Ritual and worship are qualification and purification, never production.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - VEDĀNTIC SELF, RELEASE AND EMBODIED LIBERATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | VEDĀNTIC SELF, RELEASE AND EMBODIED LIBERATION

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

avidyā · jīvanmukti · videhamukti ·
prārabdha ·
śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana ·
prakāra · dhruvānusmṛti · prapatti

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Removal model yields knowledge as
sole means; attainment model yields
devotion and grace as means.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Sublated individuality and present
freedom in Advaita; preserved
individuality and communion in
Viśiṣṭādvaita.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not annihilate the soul in Advaita,
do not deify it in Viśiṣṭādvaita, and
never let knowledge destroy fructifying
karma.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Advaita–Viśiṣṭādvaita dispute is not about how liberation is reached but about what is left when it is: the removal of a mistaken individuality in the one, and the perfection of a real individual in the other.

SESSION 11 - JAIN SOUL AND BONDAGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: In Jainism every living thing is a conscious soul whose natural brightness is dimmed by a fine material residue that its own passions attract, and liberation is the complete removal of that residue.

Technical definition: The soul (*jīva*) is an eternal, conscious substance with intrinsic infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy; **inflow (āsrava)** of quasi-material karmic matter, driven by passions, produces **bondage (bandha)**; **stoppage (saṃvara)** and **shedding (nirjarā)** reverse it, yielding **omniscience (kevala-jñāna)** and finally disembodied perfection (*siddhahood*).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Jainism is the one major Indian system in which karma is not a metaphor and not a bookkeeping device but a quasi-material substance, and every distinctive feature of its soteriology - the ladder, the austerity, the non-violence - follows from taking that literally.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- soul (*jīva*) and non-soul (*ajīva*)
- inflow (*āsrava*)
- bondage (*bandha*)
- stoppage (*saṃvara*)
- shedding (*nirjarā*)
- omniscience (*kevala-jñāna*)
- four infinitudes (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*)
- passions (*kaṣāya*)

How to use them: The stem "soul **and** bondage" has two nouns; deliver the soul's metaphysics *and* the bondage mechanism, in that order, and finish with the ladder that reverses it.

EXAM-READY LINE: Because Jain karma is material, bondage is literally weight and liberation is literally lightening - which is why the tradition's ethics is an ethics of restraint rather than of knowledge alone.

THE JAIN LADDER - BONDAGE AND ITS REVERSAL

JĪVA (soul)	eternal · conscious · intrinsically omniscient extension varies with the body it occupies
PASSIONS (kaṣāya):	anger · pride · deceit · greed ↓ make the soul 'sticky'
ĀSRAVA	inflow of fine karmic matter ↓
BANDHA	bondage - karmic matter binds to the soul, obscuring knowledge, perception, bliss and energy
SAMVARA	STOPPAGE - restraint, vows, carefulness: no new inflow ↓
NIRJARĀ	SHEDDING - austerity burns off accumulated karma ↓
KEVALA-JÑĀNA	omniscience manifests while still embodied ↓
MOKṢA / SIDDHAHOOD	final disembodied perfection: ANANTA-CATUṢṬAYA - infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy

IMAGE: dust clings to an OILY body. The oil is passion;
without it the dust does not adhere.

1. The soul, stated exactly FACT:

- Every living being - including beings in earth, water, fire, air and plants on the Jain classification - is a **jīva**, and consciousness is its defining and inseparable characteristic.
- The soul is **eternal**, neither created nor destroyed, and there is **no creator God** administering the process.
- Its intrinsic nature is the **four infinitudes**; bondage obscures them but never destroys them, which is why liberation *manifests* rather than *produces* omniscience.
- ANALYSIS: Distinctively, the soul is **co-extensive with the body it occupies**, expanding and contracting like light filling a room - a doctrine that follows from taking embodiment as a mode of the soul during bondage.

2. The bondage mechanism, and why it is quasi-material FACT:

Karma in Jainism is not merely an unseen potency but **fine matter (karma-pudgala)**. Passions make the soul adhesive; matter flows in and binds. Bondage is analysed by **nature, duration, intensity and quantity** of the karmic matter bound, which is why the tradition can speak of karma being shortened, intensified or shed.

3. The reversal, stage by stage FACT:

Stage	Sanskrit	What happens	Practical form
Inflow	<i>āsrava</i>	karmic matter enters	passion-driven action of body, speech and mind
Bondage	<i>bandha</i>	matter binds to the soul	obscuration of the four infinitudes
Stoppage	<i>saṃvara</i>	inflow ceases	vows, carefulness, restraint, non-violence
Shedding	<i>nirjarā</i>	bound karma is destroyed	austerity (<i>tapas</i>), voluntary and mature
Liberation	<i>mokṣa</i>	all karma exhausted	omniscience manifest; final disembodied perfection

4. The objection Jainism must answer ANALYSIS:

Objection. How can non-material consciousness interact with material karma at all? A substance that is by nature conscious and a substance that is by nature material should not be able to bind.

Reply. Jainism treats extension and embodiment as **modes of the soul during bondage**: the soul is not a Cartesian unextended thinker, and its capacity to occupy and fill a body is precisely what makes karmic adhesion intelligible.

ANALYSIS: Residue: the reply purchases intelligibility by weakening the immateriality of the soul, and critics regard the resulting substance as neither cleanly material nor cleanly spiritual.

5. Where Jain liberation sits on the bench ANALYSIS:

FACT: It is **neither** Advaitic identity **nor** Buddhist cessation-without-self. It **perfects individuality**: the liberated soul is an individual, omniscient and blissful. That is why the Jain term *kevala* means **omniscience**, and not - as in Sāṃkhya - contentless isolation.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat Jain karma as a metaphor or a mere moral law; its quasi-materiality is the doctrine.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not omit stoppage and shedding; the 2022 stem is a mechanism question.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say liberation *creates* omniscience; it removes what obscured it.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not import a creator God; Jainism has none.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse Jain *kevala* with Sāṃkhya *kaivalya*.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not describe the liberated soul as merged with anything; individuality is perfected, not dissolved.

Revision notes

- Every living being is an eternal conscious soul with four infinitudes.
- Passions make the soul adhesive; karmic matter flows in and binds.
- Karma is quasi-material, analysed by nature, duration, intensity and quantity.
- Stoppage halts inflow; shedding destroys the accumulated store.
- Omniscience manifests while embodied; final perfection is disembodied.
- The soul is co-extensive with its body during bondage.
- The oily-body image explains adhesion through passion.
- The interaction objection is answered by treating extension as a mode of the soul.
- Jain liberation perfects individuality.
- Jain *kevala* is omniscience, not isolation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - JAIN SOUL AND BONDAGE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW JAIN SOUL AND BONDAGE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS jīva · ajīva · kaṣāya · āsrava · bandha · saṃvara · nirjarā · kevala-jñāna · ananta-catuṣṭaya	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Passion causes inflow, inflow causes bondage, restraint stops inflow, austerity sheds the store, and the soul's own infinitudes then manifest.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Liberation perfects individuality, unlike Advaitic identity or Buddhist cessation without a self.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not metaphorise Jain karma and do not confuse Jain omniscience with Sāṃkhya isolation.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jainism is the one major Indian system in which karma is not a metaphor and not a bookkeeping device but a quasi-material substance, and every distinctive feature of its soteriology follows from taking that literally.			

SESSION 12 - CESSATION AND ISOLATION: NYĀYA APAVARGA AND SĀṂKHYA-YOGA KAIVALYA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Two Indian schools describe the goal in deliberately austere terms - one as the total end of pain with no experience left over, the other as consciousness simply standing alone, owning nothing.

Technical definition: **Apavarga** in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika is the absolute cessation of pain together with the qualities that generate embodied experience, consciousness included. **Kaivalya** in Sāṃkhya-Yoga is the aloneness of *puruṣa* once discriminative discernment (*viveka-khyāti*) ends the misattribution of *prakṛti*'s states to consciousness.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Nyāya and Sāṃkhya-Yoga are the two schools honest enough to say what their metaphysics actually permits: liberation is the end of suffering, not the beginning of bliss, and neither school will purchase attractiveness at the cost of consistency.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- final cessation of pain (apavarga)

- false knowledge -> activity -> rebirth -> suffering chain
- consciousness as adventitious to the Nyāya self
- aloneness (kaivalya)
- non-discrimination (aviveka) and discriminative discernment (viveka-khyāti)
- restriction of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)
- counter-flow of the constituents (pratiprasava)

How to use them: State what each school takes suffering to be, derive the terminus from that, and then say explicitly what is *absent* in each terminus - the missing item is the mark-earning detail.

EXAM-READY LINE: Sāṃkhya gives the sharpest Indian statement that liberation is an epistemic correction rather than an ontological change: nothing is added, nothing is destroyed, and consciousness was free all along.

TWO AUSTERE TERMINI, TWO DIFFERENT REASONS	
NYĀYA-VAIŚEṢIKA	SĀMĀKHYA-YOGA
suffering arises through a chain: false knowledge -> defect -> activity -> birth -> suffering TRUE KNOWLEDGE reverses the chain link by link	suffering is THREEFOLD: ādhyaत्मika (self) ādhibhautika (others) ādhidaivika (cosmic) SK 1 its cause is AVIVEKA: failure to discriminate puruṣa from buddhi
APAVARGA = pain ends AND the qualities that sustain experience end -> NO consciousness -> NO bliss	KAIVALYA = puruṣa stands ALONE contentless, plural, witness only -> consciousness present but WITHOUT content
BOTH REFUSE TO CALL LIBERATION A REWARD.	

1. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika: release as cessation FACT:

The chain. Suffering is traced back through birth, activity, defect and finally **false knowledge**. Because the chain is causal, cutting it at the root ends everything downstream. **True knowledge of the categories and of the self** removes false knowledge; without false knowledge there is no defect, without defect no binding activity, without activity no rebirth, and without rebirth no suffering.

The terminus. *Apavarga* is the **absolute cessation of pain**. Because Nyāya treats **consciousness as an adventitious quality** of the self - arising only when the self is conjoined with mind, senses and body - the released self exists without consciousness, without pleasure and without bliss.

ANALYSIS: The famous objection. Such a state is indistinguishable from stone-like insentience; who would want it?

The reply: the school is not offering a reward but the end of a defect. Its value is negative and complete: no pain can arise again, because the conditions that generate any experience whatsoever have ended.

2. Sāṃkhya: two principles, one misattribution FACT:

- **Puruṣa** - plural, inactive, attributeless **pure consciousness**, mere witness (*sākṣin*), by nature already isolated (*kevala*).
- **Prakṛti** - one, unconscious, active, constituted by the three constituents (*guṇa*).
- **Bondage is not a real bond** but **non-discrimination (aviveka)**: prakṛti's states are misattributed to consciousness.

FACT: The doctrine that wins marks: *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63 states that, strictly, **no puruṣa is bound, released or transmigrating**; it is *prakṛti*, in her manifold forms, who binds herself, transmigrates and releases herself. Liberation is therefore the correction of a **misattribution**, not an event in consciousness.

The route. *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 1 begins from the threefold suffering - *ādhyaत्मika* (bodily and mental), *ādhibhautika* (from other beings), *ādhidaivika* (from natural and cosmic forces) - and the failure of ordinary and ritual means to end it permanently. Effects pre-exist in their cause (*satkāryavāda*), so evolution is transformation of prakṛti rather than

creation; consciousness cannot be a product of the unconscious, so *puruṣa* is distinct; and liberation is **discriminative discernment (viveka-khyāti)**, after which prakṛti ceases to display herself to that *puruṣa*.

FACT: **Embodied liberation in Sāṃkhya**: kārikā 67 uses the **potter's wheel that continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn** - the body persists on residual momentum after discriminative knowledge; kārikā 68 gives *videha-kaivalya* at the fall of the body. ANALYSIS: Note the parallel with Advaita's *prārabdha* image and the difference in metaphysics: for Advaita the residue is karmic, for Sāṃkhya it is the constituents' momentum.

3. Yoga: the same metaphysics, plus a practice and an Īśvara FACT:

Sūtra	Content	Exam use
YS 1.2	yoga is the restriction of the modifications of the mind (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)	the operational definition
YS 1.3	then the seer abides in its own nature	states the terminus in one line
YS 2.3	the five afflictions (<i>kleśa</i>): ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion, clinging to life - with ignorance as the field of the rest	shows the psychology behind bondage
YS 1.24	Īśvara is a special puruṣa* untouched by affliction, action, its fruition and its residue	FACT: proves Yoga's Īśvara is not a creator
YS 4.29	cloud-of-dharma absorption (<i>dharma-megha-samādhi</i>)	the penultimate stage
YS 4.34	kaivalya as the counter-flow (<i>pratiprasava</i>) of the constituents, now empty of purpose for <i>puruṣa</i> - equivalently, the power of consciousness (<i>citi-śakti</i>) established in its own nature	the definition to quote

FACT: The eightfold path (*aṣṭāṅga*: restraints, observances, posture, breath-regulation, withdrawal, concentration, meditation, absorption) moves from absorption-with-support to absorption-without-support and thence to aloneness.

ANALYSIS: **Why the non-creator Īśvara matters here**: it makes Yoga the decisive Indian case of **theism without creation**, and it is the reason a liberation-answer must not assume that an Indian theism implies a world-maker.

4. The three objections to Sāṃkhya, with replies ANALYSIS:

Objection	Reply	Cost
Plurality of puruṣas. If each is attributeless and inactive, nothing distinguishes them, so pluralism collapses into Advaita's one	difference is established by the observed difference of birth, death and experience	Advaitins call this question-begging, since the differences belong to prakṛti
Why does prakṛti act at all?	she acts "for the sake of <i>puruṣa</i> ", illustrated by milk flowing unconsciously for the calf	a purpose in the unconscious is exactly what Nyāya objects to
Is a contentless liberation desirable?	Sāṃkhya explicitly denies that <i>kaivalya</i> is bliss; it is the <i>ending</i> of the threefold suffering, and offering more would be dishonest	the school accepts an unattractive terminus for the sake of consistency

5. The terminological trap, stated once and remembered ANALYSIS:

Word	In Sāṃkhya-Yoga	In Jainism
<i>kevala</i> / <i>kaivalya</i>	isolation of contentless consciousness	omniscience (<i>kevala-jñāna</i>)

FACT: Same syllable, **opposite content**. This is the single most common terminological error in scripts on this clause.

UPSC traps

- ANALYSIS: Do not describe *apavarga* as blissful; consciousness itself is absent.
- ANALYSIS: Do not say *puruṣa* is bound and released; kārikā 62-63 says the opposite.
- ANALYSIS: Do not call Yoga's Īśvara a creator; sūtra 1.24 makes him a special *puruṣa*.

4. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *kaivalya* as a synonym for *mokṣa*.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse Sāṃkhya *kaivalya* with Jain *kevala-jñāna*.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not present the potter's-wheel image as identical in Advaita and Sāṃkhya; the image is shared, the metaphysics is not.

Revision notes

- Nyāya: false knowledge -> defect -> activity -> birth -> suffering; true knowledge reverses it.
- *Apavarga* ends pain and the qualities that sustain experience; consciousness is adventitious and absent.
- Sāṃkhya: *puruṣa* is plural, inactive, contentless witness; *prakṛti* is one, unconscious, active.
- Bondage is non-discrimination, not a real bond.
- Kārikā 62-63: no *puruṣa* is bound, released or transmigrating.
- Kārikā 1: threefold suffering; kārikā 67: potter's wheel; 68: *videha-kaivalya*.
- Yoga adds practice and a non-creator Īśvara (YS 1.24).
- YS 1.2, 1.3, 2.3, 4.29 and 4.34 are the citable spine.
- Three objections: plurality, prakṛti's purpose, desirability.
- *Kevala* is omniscience in Jainism and isolation in Sāṃkhya.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CESSATION AND ISOLATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW CESSATION AND ISOLATION: NYĀYA APAVARGA AND SĀMĀKHYA-YOGA KAIVALYA			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS apavarga · adventitious consciousness · aviveka · viveka-khyāti · kaivalya · citta-vṛtti-nirodha · pratīprasava · citi-śakti	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Nyāya cuts a causal chain at false knowledge; Sāṃkhya corrects a misattribution by discrimination.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Apavarga has no consciousness at all; kaivalya has consciousness with no content.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Never make apavarga blissful, never let puruṣa transmigrate, and never merge kevala with kaivalya.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Sāṃkhya gives the sharpest Indian statement that liberation is an epistemic correction rather than an ontological change: nothing is added, nothing is destroyed, and consciousness was free all along.			

SESSION 13 - PATHS TO LIBERATION: DEVOTION, AND THE THREE-MEANS DISPUTE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: If liberation is the goal, what actually gets you there - knowing, doing, or loving? Indian traditions give three answers, and they do not agree.

Technical definition: **Devotion (bhakti)** is loving attachment to a personal God, held in the theistic Vedāntas to be a **direct means (sākṣāt-sādhana)** of liberation; the three-means dispute asks whether **knowledge (jñāna)**, **action (karma)** and **devotion (bhakti)** are alternative, sequential or combined routes.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Devotion's philosophical contribution is not emotional but structural: it relocates liberation from achievement to reception, and thereby makes release a matter of grace rather than of qualification.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- devotion (bhakti) as direct means (sākṣāt-sādhana)
- auxiliary aid (ārād-upakāraka)
- nine limbs (navadhā bhakti)
- rule-governed and spontaneous devotion (vaidhī / rāgānugā)
- with-form and formless devotion (saguṇa / nirguṇa)
- self-surrender (prapatti)
- cat and monkey (mārjāra / markāṭa-nyāya)
- knowledge-and-action combination (jñāna-karma-samuccaya)

- **production versus removal model of liberation**

How to use them: State the criterion of a "pathway" - accessibility, sufficiency, terminus - before evaluating anything, and in the three-means question **name the disagreement** rather than harmonising it.

EXAM-READY LINE: All three are means, but not means of the same kind: action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes - and which is *direct* is settled by a prior question, whether liberation is produced or uncovered.

PART A - DEVOTION: THE FULL APPARATUS

TEXTUAL BASE -----

Gītā 18.66 (carama-śloka): abandon all dharmas, take refuge
 Gītā 9.22 : the Lord secures what the exclusively devoted lack
 Gītā 9.32 : accessibility of the path
 Bhāgavata 7.5.23 - NINE LIMBS, in order:
 śravaṇa • kīrtana • smaraṇa • pāda-sevana • arcana •
 vandana • dāsyā • sakhyā • ātma-nivedana
 Nārada Bhakti Sūtra / Śaṅḍilya Bhakti Sūtra: supreme love /
 supreme attachment to Īśvara

TYPOLGY -----

parā (higher, disinterested) <-> aparā / gauṇī (preliminary)
 vaidhī (scripturally ruled) <-> rāgānugā (spontaneous)
 sāguṇa (Tulsidās, Sūrdās, <-> nirguṇa (Kabīr, Nānak, Dādū)
 Mīrābāī) <- shows bhakti needs a personal
 five bhāvas: śānta • dāsyā • FOCUS, not an iconic form
 sakhyā • vātsalya • mādhyura

SYSTEMATIC POSITIONS -----

Rāmānuja : dhruvānusmṛti + prapatti; grace decisive
 Madhva : jñāna-pūrvaka-sneha; prasāda decisive; taratamya
 Vallabha : puṣṭi-mārga, the path of nourishing grace
 Caitanya : prema-bhakti as a FIFTH puruṣārtha
 Advaita : preparatory - citta-śuddhi, not a direct means

THE GRACE/EFFORT PROBLEM -----

MĀRJĀRA-NYĀYA the cat carries the kitten -> grace alone
 MARKAṬA-NYĀYA the young monkey must cling -> grace + effort

1. Devotion evaluated, not merely described ANALYSIS:

A "pathway" must be assessed on three criteria, and the 2018 stem says **evaluate**:

Criterion	Devotion's performance
Accessibility	FACT: Highest of the three. It dispenses with Sanskrit learning and ritual entitlement, which is why the movement is vernacular and socially open - Ājivārs and Nāyanārs, Basavaṇṇa's Vīraśaiva, Kabīr, Nānak, Mīrā, Tukārām
Sufficiency	FACT: Sufficient and direct in the theistic Vedāntas; ANALYSIS: only preparatory in Advaita
Terminus	Communion and service with God, not identity - so its sufficiency is relative to a Vaiṣṇava conception of the goal

The incapacity argument. If bondage is beginningless, the bound soul cannot lift itself by its own resources; only grace can, and devotion is the posture in which grace is received. This is devotion's strongest philosophical claim, and it is not an emotional claim at all.

2. The systematic positions, kept apart FACT:

- **Rāmānuja:** devotion is **steady, uninterrupted loving recollection (dhruvānusmṛti)**. Because it presupposes qualifications not everyone has, he admits **self-surrender (prapatti / śaraṇāgati)** as an equally efficacious and universally accessible means. Liberation is finally by **divine grace**.
- **FACT: The Śrīvaiṣṇava split** over how grace and effort combine - **cat (mārajāra-nyāya)**: grace alone carries, as the cat carries the kitten (Teṅkalai); **monkey (markaṭa-nyāya)**: the young monkey must cling, so grace plus effort (Vaḍakalai). This is the most efficient way to show mastery of the grace/effort problem.
- **Madhva:** devotion is **affection preceded by knowledge (jñāna-pūrvaka-sneha)** of the Lord's supremacy; it is both means and, in graded form, content of liberation; **grace (prasāda)** is decisive and **gradation (taratamya)** fixes the degree.
- **Vallabha:** the **path of nourishing grace (puṣṭi-mārga)**, with grace unearned by works.
- **Caitanya (Gauḍīya):** love (**prema-bhakti**) is not merely a means to release but a **fifth and higher human end (puruṣārtha)** - the devotee may even prefer service to liberation.

- **Advaita (Śaṅkara):** devotion and worship (*upāsana*) are **preparatory, not directly liberating** - they produce purification of mind (*citta-śuddhi*) and one-pointedness, qualifying one for knowledge, which alone removes ignorance. CAUTION: The often-quoted definition of devotion as *svasvarūpānusandhānam* ("investigation into one's own true nature") comes from the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi*, whose ascription to Śaṅkara is disputed - attribute it to the Advaita tradition, not to Śaṅkara personally.

3. Four objections to devotion, with replies ANALYSIS:

Objection	Reply
Love presupposes duality , so devotion cannot deliver Advaitic identity	Advaita agrees - and therefore classifies devotion as means, not end; the theistic Vedāntas simply deny that identity is the goal
Emotionalism: devotion without discernment degenerates into sentiment or fanaticism	the traditions build in rule-governed discipline (<i>vaidhī</i>), scriptural regulation and Madhva's knowledge-first requirement
If grace decides, effort is otiose	the cat/monkey dispute is the tradition's own recognition of the problem; neither side eliminates the other term
Devotion presupposes a with-form God , so it is unavailable to Buddhism, Jainism or Mīmāṃsā	formless devotion shows the requirement is a <i>personal focus</i> , not an iconic form - ANALYSIS: but the objection stands against strictly non-theistic systems

4. Part B - the three-means dispute, stated as a disagreement ANALYSIS:

The exact question: are knowledge, action and devotion **alternative** routes, **sequential** stages, or **combined**? Every school answers differently, and **naming the disagreement is the answer**.

The analytic apparatus - deploy it early:

- THREE DISTINCTIONS THAT SEPARATE A 7 FROM A 12
- (1) DIRECT MEANS (*sākṣāt-sādhana*) vs AUXILIARY AID (*ārād-upakāraka*)
 - (2) MEANS vs QUALIFICATION (*adhikāra*)
action may qualify one for knowledge without being a means to release
 - (3) PRODUCTION MODEL vs REMOVAL MODEL of liberation
if release is a RESULT to be produced -> action can produce it
if release is the REMOVAL of an error -> only knowledge removes it
<- Śaṅkara's entire case rests on the second

School	Position
Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā	action alone - the Veda is essentially injunctive and knowledge-passages are subordinate to ritual action. This is the position Śaṅkara argues against, and naming it shows why the dispute exists
Śaṅkara (Advaita)	knowledge alone liberates. Release is not a producible effect (<i>sādhya</i>) but the eternally accomplished nature of the self (<i>siddha</i>), obscured by ignorance; ignorance is destroyed only by knowledge, as darkness by light. He therefore rejects the knowledge-and-action combination (<i>jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda</i>). Action and worship remain indispensable <i>preparations</i>
Rāmānuja (Viśiṣṭādvaita)	sequential culmination - action purifies, knowledge discloses the self as a mode of God, and both flow into devotion, the direct means; self-surrender is the accessible alternative. He therefore accepts a graded combination Śaṅkara denies
Madhva (Dvaita)	knowledge of the Lord's supremacy is prior; devotion ripened from it is the means; grace is decisive

FACT: **The Gītā's own signal:** 5.4-5 states that only the immature (*bālāḥ*) declare Sāṃkhya (knowledge) and Yoga (action) to be different; one who reaches by one reaches by the other. The text thus supports **convergence**, which is why three great commentators could each claim it - **Śaṅkara for knowledge, Rāmānuja for devotion, and Tilak (Gītā-Rahasya) for action**.

FACT: **Vivekananda:** the four yogas (knowledge, devotion, action, *rāja*) are **temperament-matched** routes to the same realisation - a psychological, not a metaphysical, pluralism.

5. The objection to convergence, and the honest reply ANALYSIS:

Objection. The convergence reading is diplomatic mush: knowledge that dissolves individuality and devotion that preserves it cannot terminate in the same state.

Reply. They converge in **function** - the dismantling of egoic self-appropriation - while diverging in **terminus** - identity versus communion. The honest answer says exactly this instead of harmonising.

Second objection. If action cannot liberate, why does the *Gītā* command action? **Reply. Desireless action** (*niṣkāma-karma*) does not liberate *by producing* release; it liberates by dismantling the sense of agency that sustains bondage.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat devotion as mere emotion; its content is the shift from achievement to reception.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say "Advaita rejects devotion"; Advaita makes it preparatory - a difference of role, not of value.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the three-means question with "all three are equal"; name the disagreement.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* definition to Śaṅkara personally.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the cat/monkey illustration in any grace-and-effort discussion.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not describe *prema-bhakti* as a means only; for Caitanya it is a higher human end than release itself.

Revision notes

- Devotion is a direct means in the theistic Vedāntas, preparatory in Advaita.
- Evaluate on accessibility, sufficiency and terminus.
- Nine limbs from *Bhāgavata* 7.5.23, in order.
- Typology: higher/preliminary, rule-governed/spontaneous, with-form/formless, five moods.
- Rāmānuja: steady recollection plus self-surrender; grace decisive.
- Cat versus monkey states the grace/effort problem.
- Madhva: knowledge-preceded affection; Vallabha: nourishing grace; Caitanya: love as fifth end.
- Three-means apparatus: direct/auxiliary, means/qualification, production/removal.
- Mīmāṃsā: action alone. Śaṅkara: knowledge alone, rejecting combination. Rāmānuja: graded combination.
- *Gītā* 5.4-5 licenses convergence in function, not in terminus.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PATHS TO LIBERATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW PATHS TO LIBERATION: DEVOTION, AND THE THREE-MEANS DISPUTE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS sākṣāt-sādhana · ārād-upakāra · adhikāra · navadhā bhakti · vaidhī/rāgānugā · saguṇa/nirguṇa · prapatti · mārjāra/markaṭa-nyāya · jñāna-karma-samuccaya · niṣkāma-karma	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT The production/removal fork settles which means can be direct; devotion answers the incapacity of a beginninglessly bound soul by making release receivable.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Mīmāṃsā takes action alone, Śaṅkara knowledge alone, Rāmānuja a graded culmination in devotion, Madhva knowledge-grounded devotion.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not harmonise the three means and do not reduce devotion to feeling.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Devotion's philosophical contribution is not emotional but structural: it relocates liberation from achievement to reception, and thereby makes release a matter of grace rather than of qualification.			

SESSION 14 - RESURRECTION, REBIRTH AND REINCARNATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Semitic and Indian answers to death are not two versions of one idea. One says God will put the whole person back together once; the other says the moral momentum of action keeps producing new lives until you get out.

Technical definition: **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series; **reincarnation** is the substantialist reading of rebirth in which a soul re-enters flesh.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions: resurrection asks how a person can survive when the person is essentially embodied, while rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when a single life is too short.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- psychosomatic unity
- immortality of the soul versus resurrection of the dead (Cullmann)
- gap problem
- re-assembly ("cannibal") objection
- soul as form of the body (Aquinas)
- body-preservation and simulacrum (van Inwagen)
- replica theory (Hick)
- re-enfleshing (reincarnation) versus re-becoming (punarbhava)

How to use them: Give the two-strand distinction first, then the comparative grid, then the identity problem *on both sides*, and close by refusing to make either a version of the other.

EXAM-READY LINE: The identity problem is unresolved on both sides, but for opposite reasons - resurrection must explain how a re-constituted body is the same person, while rebirth must explain how a being with no memory of me is me.

TWO WESTERN STRANDS THAT ARE OFTEN WRONGLY MERGED	
IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL	RESURRECTION OF THE DEAD
Greek / Platonic	Hebrew-Christian-Islamic
the soul is naturally deathless	the person is a PSYCHOSOMATIC UNITY
death RELEASES it from the body	death is REAL; only a divine act can reverse it
+---- Oscar CULLMANN (1955): these are OPPOSED, not complementary - 'Immortality of the Soul OR Resurrection of the Dead?'	

1. The comparative grid FACT:

Axis	Resurrection	Rebirth (Indian)
Number of lives	one earthly life	a beginningless series
Mechanism	divine act at the end of history	karma maturing through the wandering-on
Judge	God, in a final judgement	the karmic law itself; in Nyāya and Rāmānuja God <i>ratifies</i> rather than decrees
Telos	restored embodied life in communion with God	exit from the series - <i>mokṣa</i> , <i>nirvāṇa</i> , <i>kaivalya</i> , <i>apavarga</i>
Identity-bearer	the person re-constituted by God (soul as form, or replica)	the self or individual soul - or, in Buddhism, a causal stream
Body	essential; a "spiritual body" is still a body	discarded like clothing (<i>Gītā</i> 2.22); the subtle body carries dispositions
Direction of time	linear, eschatological	cyclical, with a linear exit
Moral function	accountability before a personal God	self-regulating desert without an external prosecutor

2. The identity problem for resurrection, and the three standard replies ANALYSIS:

- **The gap problem.** What exists between death and resurrection? If nothing does, the raised person seems to be a new creation rather than a continuation.
- **The re-assembly ("cannibal") objection.** If matter is shared between bodies over time, whose atoms are raised?

Reply	Claim	Cost
Aquinas	the rational soul is the form of the body and secures continuity across the gap	requires a hylomorphic metaphysics and a soul that can exist, incompletely, apart from matter
van Inwagen	God preserves the body , or a core of it, and leaves a simulacrum behind	the position is deliberately austere and looks <i>ad hoc</i> to critics
Hick's replica theory	an exact psychophysical replica, with continuity of memory and character, appearing in a different space, is the same person for all purposes that matter	the duplication objection: if one replica, why not two?

Hick's restriction and the rejoinder. Hick restricts the case to a *unique* replica and argues that in the absence of a rival claimant our ordinary criteria are satisfied. Critics answer that the mere **possibility** of duplication already shows the criterion is not identity.

3. The identity problem for rebirth ANALYSIS:

The memory objection. There is no recollection of prior lives. **The reply** distinguishes psychological memory from metaphysical continuity, and appeals to latent dispositions (*saṃskāra* / *vāsanā*). CAUTION: The reply preserves coherence; it does not supply evidence.

4. Rebirth versus reincarnation - what the 2019 stem demands FACT:

- **Reincarnation** (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes a **substantial soul** that re-enters a new body. It is apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism.
- **Rebirth** is the **wider, more neutral term**, and is the only correct term for **Buddhism**, which affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) without any transmigrating substance.
- FACT: Sanskrit registers the same range: *punarjanma* (rebirth), *punarāvṛtti* (return), *saṃsāra* (the wandering itself).
- FACT: The *Gītā*'s teaching at **9.21** - those who exhaust their merit return to the world of mortals - shows that even heaven is a **within-saṃsāra** stage, not resurrection.

5. The two objections, symmetrically ANALYSIS:

Objection to resurrection	Objection to rebirth
a replica is a duplicate, not a survivor; and if God could make one, he could make two	it is empirically untestable and morally hazardous
Reply: restrict to a unique replica; ordinary criteria are then satisfied	Reply: untestability is shared with resurrection, and explanatory karma does not license social judgement of the sufferer

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present resurrection as rebirth in heaven; it is one life, a bodily re-constitution and a final judgement.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Greek immortality with Hebrew resurrection; Cullmann's point is that they are opposed.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not use "reincarnation" for Buddhism.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the gap and re-assembly problems when discussing resurrection identity.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not treat Hick's replica as a proof of resurrection; it defends coherence.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not answer "state and explain the doctrines of karma, rebirth and reincarnation" by defining only two of the three.

Revision notes

- Resurrection: one life, divine act, judgement, embodied person.
- Rebirth: beginningless series, karmic mechanism, exit as telos.
- Cullmann (1955): Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are opposed.
- Gap problem and re-assembly objection press resurrection identity.
- Aquinas: soul as form. Van Inwagen: body preserved, simulacrum left. Hick: unique replica.

- Duplication objection undermines replica identity.
- Memory objection presses rebirth; reply distinguishes memory from continuity.
- Reincarnation presupposes substance; rebirth does not.
- *Punarjanma*, *punarāvṛtti*, *punarbhava*, *saṃsāra* register the range.
- Neither doctrine is a version of the other, and both leave identity unresolved.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - RESURRECTION, REBIRTH AND REINCARNATION

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | RESURRECTION, REBIRTH AND REINCARNATION

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

psychosomatic unity · Cullmann · gap problem · re-assembly objection · Aquinas · van Inwagen · Hick's replica · punarbhava versus re-enfleshing

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Resurrection re-constitutes an essentially embodied person by divine act; rebirth extends the field of karmic maturation across a series.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

One life, judge and telos of restored embodiment against a beginningless series, self-regulating law and telos of exit.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Do not make either a version of the other, and never apply 'reincarnation' to Buddhism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions: resurrection asks how a person can survive when the person is essentially embodied, while rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when a single life is too short.

SESSION 15 - ANTI-THEISTIC REBIRTH: KARMA WITHOUT A DIVINE JUDGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Buddhism and Jainism run the whole machinery of moral consequence, rebirth and liberation without a creator God - and that is a philosophically interesting fact, not merely a doctrinal difference.

Technical definition: In the Veda-rejecting (*nāstika*) traditions, karma operates as a **self-regulating law**, rebirth requires no divine dispensation, and liberation requires neither grace nor union with a deity.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The significance of the anti-theistic stand on rebirth is structural rather than polemical: it demonstrates that the Indian moral cosmos is not logically wedded either to a divine judge or to an immortal soul-substance.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Veda-rejecting (*nāstika*) is not the same as atheist
- self-regulating karmic law
- no karma-superintendent (*karmādhyakṣa*) required
- no permanent self (*anātman*) with rebirth
- liberation without grace
- detachability thesis

How to use them: Read "significant" as a **modal/structural claim** - what karma-rebirth-liberation does *not* require - rather than as praise, and give three separable detachments.

EXAM-READY LINE: What these traditions establish is a series of detachments: karma detached from a judge, rebirth detached from a soul, and liberation detached from grace.

THREE DETACHMENTS - THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE ANSWER

(1) KARMA WITHOUT A JUDGE

desert is discharged by an impersonal law

-> answers the distribution problem without theodicy

(2) REBIRTH WITHOUT A SOUL

continuity, not substance, suffices (Buddhism)

-> defeats the necessity claim

(3) LIBERATION WITHOUT GRACE

nirvāṇa and Jain perfection need no deity

-> shows soteriology is not intrinsically theistic

|

ANALYSIS: CAUTION: 'nāstika' means VEDA-REJECTING, not atheist.

Jainism has an eternal soul; Buddhism denies one.

Do not merge the two anti-theisms.

1. The two systems are not one position ANALYSIS:

	Buddhism	Jainism
Permanent self?	WRONG: denied (<i>anātman</i>)	FACT: affirmed (eternal <i>jīva</i>)
Creator God?	WRONG: no creator; a creator adds no necessary explanatory work	WRONG: no creator; the world and souls are eternal
Karma	causal conditioning of a stream	quasi-material matter adhering to the soul
Liberation	extinguishing of craving (<i>nirvāṇa</i>)	perfected omniscient individuality
What it proves for this clause	rebirth needs no soul	rebirth and liberation need no God

ANALYSIS: **Together** they establish more than either does alone: Jainism removes the God without removing the soul, and Buddhism removes the soul without removing rebirth. The two together show that the *whole* structure is separable.

2. Why this counts as philosophical significance ANALYSIS:

1. **It isolates the explanatory work.** If the same moral phenomena are explained without a judge and without a substance, then neither is doing indispensable explanatory work.
2. **It answers the distribution question differently from theism.** Impersonal law explains why *this* person suffers without requiring a divine reason for the allocation - a route unavailable to classical theism.
3. **It relocates the burden.** The theist must now show what a divine judge *adds*; the substantialist must show what a permanent soul *adds*.

3. The counter-pressures, stated fairly ANALYSIS:

Counter-pressure	Force	Reply
An impersonal law with no legislator is metaphysically odd	real; laws normally have a source	the schools treat moral causation as a basic feature of the world, as natural regularities are treated
Without a self, moral ownership of the fruit is unclear	the strongest objection	causal descent, "neither the same nor wholly other"
Without grace, liberation may be unattainable for most	practical, not logical	both traditions supply graded paths and lay-adherent routes

4. What must not be claimed ANALYSIS:

WRONG: Do not say the anti-theistic schools "refute" theism; the owner's discipline is that they show a **structure is detachable**, not that a God does not exist. WRONG: Do not say Buddhism is "atheistic" without the qualification that its denial concerns a **creator** and a **permanent self**, and that the *nāstika* label concerns Vedic authority.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *nāstika* as meaning atheist.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not merge Buddhist and Jain anti-theism; they differ precisely on the soul.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not read "significance" as approval; read it as a claim about what is or is not required.

4. ANALYSIS: Do not overstate the conclusion into a disproof of theism.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not forget that Jainism's karma is material while Buddhism's is causal conditioning.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the ownership objection; it is the pressure the answer must survive.

Revision notes

- Three detachments: karma from a judge, rebirth from a soul, liberation from grace.
- *Nāstika* means Veda-rejecting, not atheist.
- Buddhism denies the permanent self; Jainism affirms it.
- Neither admits a creator.
- Together they show the whole structure is separable.
- Impersonal law answers distribution without theodicy.
- The burden shifts to showing what a judge or a substance adds.
- Counter-pressures: law without legislator, ownership of the fruit, attainability.
- The conclusion is detachability, never a disproof of theism.
- This is the 2018 Q5(b) owner-module.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANTI-THEISTIC REBIRTH

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ANTI-THEISTIC REBIRTH: KARMA WITHOUT A DIVINE JUDGE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS nāstika · self-regulating law · karmādhyaṅsa · anātman · detachability	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Jainism removes the God while keeping the soul; Buddhism removes the soul while keeping rebirth; together they separate the whole structure from both.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Distribution is explained by impersonal law rather than by a divine reason for allocation.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not equate nāstika with atheist and do not turn detachability into a disproof of theism.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The significance of the anti-theistic stand on rebirth is structural rather than polemical: it demonstrates that the Indian moral cosmos is not logically wedded either to a divine judge or to an immortal soul-substance.			

SESSION 16 - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THIS CLAUSE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This session converts everything above into a way of writing - what to open with, what to compare, what to concede, and how to end.

Technical definition: The clause's answer architecture consists of a **directive decoder**, a **graded verdict ladder**, mark-banded structures for 10, 15 and 20 marks, and a **quotation discipline** that keeps every citation defensible.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

In this clause the marks are not in what you know about the soul but in what you refuse to merge, so the opening move of every answer should be a distinction and the closing move should be a graded verdict.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **directive fidelity**
- **modal verdict (necessary / sufficient / neither)**
- **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**
- **falsification statement**
- **quotation discipline**

How to use them: Decode the directive first, choose the structure it demands, and give the verdict in the vocabulary the stem used.

EXAM-READY LINE: A top script states not only its conclusion but what would count against it - and in this clause that is usually one clean counter-example.

1. The inter-school grid - one table, all seven positions FACT:

School	Continuity claim	Rebirth	Liberation	Personal identity after liberation
Plato	simple, rational soul	ANALYSIS: includes transmigration themes	purification and contemplation	persists
Advaita	empirical subtle-body continuity; ultimately the self	yes	knowledge of Brahman	separate individuality sublated
Viśiṣṭādvaita	enduring individual soul	yes	communion and service to God	persists
Nyāya	eternal self-substance	yes	cessation of pain and its qualities	persists, without consciousness
Jainism	eternal individual soul	yes	karmic matter removed	perfected individuality
Buddhism	causal stream, no substance	yes	cessation of craving and suffering	no permanent self
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	<i>puruṣa</i> as witness; <i>prakṛti</i> carries the subtle body	yes - but strictly <i>prakṛti</i> transmigrates (kārikā 62-63)	aloneness: isolation of consciousness	<i>puruṣa</i> persists, contentless, plural
Semitic resurrection	the psychosomatic person, re-constituted by God	WRONG: no - one life	resurrection and judgement	persists, embodied

2. The four criticisms and their replies, kept together FACT:

- Memory objection.** Lack of past-life memory challenges identity. **Reply:** memory is neither necessary nor sufficient for metaphysical continuity; unconscious dispositions may connect lives.
- Duplication objection.** If psychological continuity branches, identity becomes indeterminate. **Reply:** substance theories invoke one bearer; Buddhist theory accepts continuity without numerical identity.
- Moral-desert objection.** Rebirth can assign suffering to unverifiable past fault. **Reply:** karmic explanation need not legitimise social punishment; compassion remains obligatory.
- Liberation paradox.** Who seeks liberation if Advaita denies individuality or Buddhism denies a self? **Reply:** conventional agency operates until insight removes the misconception sustaining bondage.

3. The directive decoder FACT:

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Is X a necessary condition for Y?	a modal verdict - necessary / sufficient / neither	give the substantialist "yes", then the Buddhist counter-example, then the exact modal claim	2022 Q5(c); 2025 Q7(c); 2024 Q6(a)
Discuss with reference to [named text or school]	fidelity to <i>that</i> source	the <i>Gītā</i> question must cite <i>Gītā</i> verses, not generic Vedānta	2025 Q7(c)
Critically examine [thinker]'s proofs	each argument assessed separately	four Platonic arguments equal four mini-assessments, not one summary	2023 Q6(a)
Elucidate... and explain the role of...	two obligations - obey both	half the answer on the concept, half on the specified role	2021 Q6(b)
Do you accept that...? Discuss	an explicit acceptance or rejection with reasons	position first; then evidence; then the strongest contrary case	2020 Q8(c)
Evaluate the concept of X as a pathway	assessment of <i>efficacy</i> , not description	state the criterion of a "pathway" - accessibility, sufficiency, terminus	2018 Q7(c)
State and explain the doctrines of A, B and C	three defined doctrines and their relations	define each separately, then show how they interlock	2019 Q8(a)
Discuss the nature of A and B according to [school]	two nouns, both delivered	Jain "soul and bondage" needs the soul's metaphysics and the inflow-bondage mechanism	2022 Q8(b)
Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of X as an essential postulate	why removing it would break other commitments	argue postulate-status, then price the costs	2021 Q8(b)
How far is it plausible to argue...?	a graded plausibility verdict	state the strongest case, the strongest counter-pressure, then the degree	2018 Q5(b)

MEMORY: **Rule:** the moment a question names a **term of liberation** - *mokṣa*, *apavarga*, *kaivalya*, *nirvāṇa*, *jīvanmukti* - the first job is to fix that term against the Session 9 bench.

4. The graded verdict ladder FACT:

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"The soul is eternal and is reborn until liberated"	all schools merged; liberation terms used as synonyms
Average (≈50%)	correct school-wise definitions	no argument reconstruction; Buddhism handled as an exception, not a counter-example
Good (≈60%)	continuity-bearer identified per school; one objection answered	necessary/sufficient distinction unstated
Strong (≈65-70%)	modal verdict precise; parity-bench distinctions live; Western comparator used	devotion or the three-means dispute reduced to a list
Top (≈70%+)	all the above, plus a discriminating distinction (production versus removal; direct versus auxiliary means; <i>kārikā</i> 62-63; replica theory) and a statement of what would falsify the position	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *Necessity stem*: "Immortality of a substantial soul is **sufficient** for rebirth but not **necessary**: Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone. What rebirth actually requires is a **continuity-bearer**, and schools disagree only about whether that bearer must be a substance."

- ANALYSIS: *Means stem*: "All three are means of different kinds. Which is the *direct* means is settled by a prior metaphysical question - whether liberation is produced or uncovered - and every school's answer follows from its answer to that."
- ANALYSIS: *Liberation-concept stem*: "The term names a family, not a state. Once *apavarga*, *kaivalya*, *mokṣa* and *nirvāṇa* are separated, the apparent Indian consensus on liberation turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering four incompatible destinations."

5. Mark-banded construction FACT:

10 MARKS (≈150 words)

Define the disputed necessity -> give the substantialist position -> Buddhist / Jain / Nyāya discriminator as required -> objection -> precise verdict on necessary versus sufficient.

15 MARKS (≈250 words)

State the doctrine and its continuity-bearer -> causal sequence -> canonical example -> nearest school contrast -> objection and reply -> identify the exact conception of liberation involved.

20 MARKS (≈300 words)

Separate immortality, rebirth and liberation -> reconstruct two rival models -> personal-identity and moral-responsibility objections -> school replies -> graded conclusion on continuity without conflation.

6. How to write the paragraph - the demonstrated pattern ANALYSIS:

Claim. Buddhism shows that an immortal soul is not necessary for rebirth. **Named evidence.** It affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*), explaining continuity by dependent origination and illustrating it by the flame lit from a flame. **Analysis.** Since one working counter-example is sufficient to defeat a necessity claim, the substantialist thesis fails as stated, and what rebirth requires is shown to be a continuity-bearer rather than a substance. **Qualification.** This does not settle whether causal descent is sufficient for moral ownership of the fruit, which remains the strongest pressure on the Buddhist account.

7. Quotation discipline FACT:

Item	Status	Safe use
Plato's four arguments	FACT: <i>Phaedo</i> - cyclical, recollection, affinity, final (Form of Life)	assess each separately; Simmias' harmony objection is in the same dialogue
<i>Gītā</i> 2.22, 2.23, 9.21, 18.66	FACT: verified chapter and verse	translations vary - paraphrase, or quote a named translation
<i>Gītā</i> 5.4-5 (<i>bālāḥ</i> , not <i>paṇḍitāḥ</i>)	FACT:	the single best warrant for the convergence reading
<i>Bhāgavata Purāṇa</i> 7.5.23 (nine limbs)	FACT:	give all nine limbs, in order
<i>Nārada / Śaṇḍilya Bhakti Sūtra</i>	FACT: texts exist and define devotion as supreme love or attachment	CAUTION: do not attribute a date or an author-identification
<i>Vivekacūḍāmaṇi</i> 's definition of devotion	CAUTION: ascription to Śaṃkara disputed	say "the Advaita tradition", not "Śaṃkara wrote"
Cat and monkey illustrations	FACT: standard Śrīvaiṣṇava Teṅkalai/Vaḍakalai illustration	use for the grace-effort problem
<i>Sāṃkhya-kārikā</i> 1, 62-63, 67-68	FACT: verified kārikā numbers	62-63 is the highest-value item in the module
<i>Yoga-sūtra</i> 1.2, 1.3, 1.24, 2.3, 4.29, 4.34	FACT: verified sūtra numbers	1.24 proves Yoga's Īśvara is not a creator
Flame-to-flame / milk-to-curd	FACT: standard Buddhist illustrations; the <i>Milindapañha</i> uses the lamp	illustration, never proof
Replica theory	FACT: John Hick, <i>Philosophy of Religion / Death and Eternal Life</i>	present as a thought-experiment defence, and give the duplication objection
<i>Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?</i>	FACT: Oscar Cullmann (1955)	the canonical statement that the two are opposed
"Potter's wheel" for fructifying karma	FACT: used in both Advaita and Sāṃkhya	note that the metaphysics differs though the image is shared

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write a survey when the directive asks for a verdict.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not answer a two-obligation stem with one obligation.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not quote scripture in invented English.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* to Śaṃkara personally.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude without saying what would count against your position.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not exceed the word band; in this clause, precision is worth more than volume.

Revision notes

- Decode the directive before planning the answer.
- Modal stems need the words necessary, sufficient or neither.
- Named-text stems need that text's verses.
- "Critically examine" a set of proofs means separate assessments.
- Two-verb stems carry two equally weighted demands.
- Fix any named liberation term against the parity bench first.
- Use claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification in every paragraph.
- State a falsification condition to reach the top band.
- Keep quotations inside the discipline table.
- Precision about what you refuse to merge is the clause's whole examination logic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THIS CLAUSE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW ANSWER ARCHITECTURE FOR THIS CLAUSE			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS directive fidelity · modal verdict · claim-evidence-analysis-qualification · falsification statement · quotation discipline	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Decode the directive, choose the banded structure, open with a distinction and close with a graded verdict.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Surveys cap at the average band; verdicts with counter-examples reach the top band.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Do not survey when asked to judge and do not leave a two-obligation stem half answered.
ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: In this clause the marks are not in what you know about the soul but in what you refuse to merge, so the opening move of every answer should be a distinction and the closing move should be a graded verdict.			

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Soul : Immortality; Rebirth and Liberation* - covering the six survival terms and the modal question, the models of the person and the four identity criteria, Hick's replica and the duplication objection, Plato's four arguments with Simmias and Kant, the five argument families and body/brain dependence, Hindu immortality with its verse base and school differences, karma as act-plus-potency with the threefold ledger and the superintendent question, rebirth as the widened field of maturation, the Buddhist argument with its illustrations and the responsibility objection, the seven-destination parity bench, Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita with embodied liberation and the real-agent question, the Jain inflow-to-shedding ladder, Nyāya cessation and Sāṃkhya-Yoga aloneness, devotion with the grace-effort dispute, the three-means disagreement, and the resurrection comparator. The eight remedial drills attack the confluences that cost marks on this clause every year.

MCQ 1. Which survival term the stem is actually using

A stem asks whether the anti-theistic traditions can consistently maintain "rebirth". Which preliminary move earns the first marks and controls the rest of the answer?

- A. Establishing at once that rebirth, reincarnation and resurrection name a single doctrine that different religious cultures happen to express in different idioms.
- B. Establishing that the question must be about heaven, since any post-mortem continuation of a person is by definition a religious reward for merit.
- C. Establishing that rebirth is the wider term and that reincarnation, which presupposes a substantial soul re-entering flesh, is only one reading of it.
- D. Establishing that the term is too vague for philosophical use, so the answer should replace it with the neutral vocabulary of psychological continuity.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the terms differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge and identity-bearer, and merging them is the standing error this clause is designed to detect.
- **B:** Incorrect: the *Bhagavad Gītā* at 9.21 returns the meritorious to the world of mortals, so heaven is a stage inside the wandering-on rather than its terminus.
- **C:** Correct: reincarnation carries a substantialist commitment that Buddhism refuses, so only the wider term "rebirth" covers re-becoming (*punarbhava*) as well.

- **D:** Incorrect: the vocabulary is precise once the terms are separated, and abandoning it would discard the very distinction the examiner is testing.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates open with a definition of the soul; the examiner awards the opening marks to whoever separates the six survival terms in the first two lines instead.

MCQ 2. The modal shape of the necessity question

"Immortality of the soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Which verdict states the position defended by this owner most exactly?

- A. It is necessary and sufficient, because every school that accepts rebirth also accepts a deathless soul that carries the moral residue forward.
- B. It is neither necessary nor sufficient, because rebirth is a cultural doctrine that stands entirely independent of any claim about what persists.
- C. It is necessary but not sufficient, because a deathless soul is required for rebirth but karmic desert must be added before re-embodiment follows.
- D. It is sufficient but not necessary, because a persisting soul would guarantee rebirth while Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self, and one working counter-example is enough to defeat a necessity claim.
- **B:** Incorrect: rebirth is not independent of continuity; it requires a continuity-bearer, and the schools dispute only whether that bearer must be a substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: this inverts the verdict, since the Buddhist case shows precisely that the soul-condition is dispensable rather than indispensable.
- **D:** Correct: sufficiency is granted to the substantialist systems while the Buddhist counter-example defeats necessity, which is the modal claim the examiner buys.

Examiner trap 2: A script that surveys school opinions without ever writing the words "necessary" or "sufficient" has answered a different question from the one set.

MCQ 3. What the identity criteria are severally for

Which statement about the four criteria of personal identity is correct as this owner presents them?

- A. Bodily and psychological criteria tell us how identity is recognised, while soul-substance and causal continuity are proposals about what constitutes it.
- B. Memory is the definition of personal identity, so any account of survival that cannot deliver recollection of a previous life is thereby refuted outright.
- C. The bodily criterion is decisive in every case, so resurrection succeeds as a theory of survival while rebirth necessarily fails as a theory of survival.
- D. The four criteria are rival answers to one question, so exactly one of them must be correct and the philosophical task is to eliminate the other three.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the first pair answers how we tell and the second answers what makes it so, and noticing the difference is what lifts a script into the top band.
- **B:** Incorrect: memory presupposes identity rather than defining it, and forgetfulness within one life already shows it to be a poor criterion.
- **C:** Incorrect: bodily continuity fails outright at death, which is why resurrection accounts must invoke form, preservation or replica rather than the body alone.

- **D:** Incorrect: the criteria answer different questions, so treating them as exclusive rivals mistakes a division of labour for a contradiction.

Examiner trap 3: Treating memory as the definition of identity turns the memory objection to rebirth into a refutation, when the owner treats it only as a pressure.

MCQ 4. Hick's replica and what the duplication objection shows

Hick's replica thought experiment is best described, together with its standard objection, as which of the following?

- A. A proof that souls are naturally immortal, undermined by the fact that no replica has ever been observed to appear in any resurrection world.
- B. A description of Indian rebirth in Western vocabulary, undermined by the absence of karmic conditioning in the way the replica is produced.
- C. A defence of the coherence of resurrection identity, undermined by the point that if God can make one replica he can make two, which identity forbids.
- D. An argument that memory is unnecessary for survival, undermined by the fact that the replica is stipulated to possess complete memory and character.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the experiment defends resurrection identity, and it is expressly not an argument for a naturally deathless soul in the Platonic sense.
- **B:** Incorrect: the replica addresses divine re-constitution of an embodied person, which is structurally different from karmically conditioned re-embodiment.
- **C:** Correct: Hick restricts the case to a unique replica, and critics answer that the bare possibility of duplication shows the criterion tracks similarity.
- **D:** Incorrect: memory continuity is central to the case rather than dispensable, and the objection concerns numerical identity rather than memory.

Examiner trap 4: Presenting the replica as evidence for survival converts a coherence argument into an evidential one and invites the objection that no such case is observed.

MCQ 5. What the recollection argument actually establishes

In the *Phaedo*, the argument from recollection (*anamnesis*), taken by itself, establishes which conclusion?

- A. That the soul existed before embodiment, since the standard by which sensible things are judged deficient is not supplied by sense-experience.
- B. That the soul survives the death of the body, since knowledge once acquired by a simple substance cannot afterwards be destroyed by decomposition.
- C. That the soul is immaterial and simple, since only a partless subject could retain a standard of comparison through a change of embodiment.
- D. That learning is impossible without teaching, since a standard of equality must be transmitted to the soul by instruction from another knower.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: recollection infers pre-existence from our grasp of a standard that deficient sensible instances cannot supply, and it establishes only that direction.
- **B:** Incorrect: survival is a separate conclusion, which is why Plato pairs recollection with the cyclical argument to close the post-mortem direction too.
- **C:** Incorrect: simplicity belongs to the affinity argument, which reasons from the soul's likeness to invisible and stable reality rather than from learning.

- **D:** Incorrect: the argument's point is the opposite, namely that instruction elicits what the soul already possesses rather than transmitting it afresh.

Examiner trap 5: Letting recollection do the work of survival collapses two of Plato's four arguments and forfeits the marks reserved for assessing each separately.

MCQ 6. The final argument and its weak joint

Plato's final argument holds that the soul, essentially bringing Life, cannot admit death. Which criticism identifies the argument's real weak point?

- A. That fire and snow are inanimate, so no analogy drawn from them can establish anything at all about a subject that is by nature living.
- B. That Forms cannot be brought by anything, since participation runs in the opposite direction, from particulars upward to the Forms they resemble.
- C. That the soul does not bring Life but merely accompanies it, so the essential predication on which the whole argument depends is simply false.
- D. That "cannot admit death" secures only that a soul cannot be a dead soul, and a further step is needed to show that it cannot simply cease to exist.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the analogy is used to display essential predication, and its inanimacy is irrelevant to whether that pattern of reasoning transfers.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument's participation language is standard in the dialogue, and rejecting it wholesale attacks Platonism rather than this argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: this simply denies the premise without argument, whereas the recognised difficulty concerns the inference drawn from that premise.
- **D:** Correct: fire does not become cold, yet fire goes out, so exclusion of the contrary does not by itself yield indestructibility.

Examiner trap 6: Scripts summarise the four arguments as one proof; "critically examine" demands four separate assessments, each with the objection that fits it.

MCQ 7. Simmias, Kant, and the two kinds of criticism

Which pairing correctly matches each critic to the criticism this owner attributes to him?

- A. Simmias holds that the soul is a knowable substance, while Kant holds that the soul is an attunement whose existence depends on bodily elements.
- B. Simmias holds that recollection is circular, while Kant holds that the cyclical argument confuses qualitative opposites with existence and non-existence.
- C. Simmias holds that the soul is an attunement of the body, while Kant holds that the unity of consciousness is not knowledge of a persisting substance.
- D. Simmias holds that immortality is a postulate of practical reason, while Kant holds that the soul rules the body and therefore cannot be its harmony.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two positions are swapped, and Kant's paralogism argues precisely that the soul is *not* a knowable substance.
- **B:** Incorrect: neither criticism is stated in these terms, and the difficulty about qualitative opposites belongs to the assessment of the cyclical argument.
- **C:** Correct: the harmony objection is Simmias' in the same dialogue, and Kant's paralogism denies that formal unity of apperception yields a substance.

- **D:** Incorrect: the postulate belongs to Kant's practical philosophy, and the rule-over-the-body point is Plato's reply to Simmias rather than Kant's thesis.

Examiner trap 7: Omitting Simmias loses the objection Plato himself answers inside the *Phaedo*, which examiners treat as the test of whether the dialogue was read.

MCQ 8. What body/brain dependence does to the debate

The systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions has which effect on the survival debate, as this owner states it?

- A. It shifts the burden onto the survivalist to supply accounts of interaction, individuation and identity, without deductively proving that no subject survives.
- B. It deductively refutes every theory of survival, since a mind that depends on a brain cannot by definition continue when that brain has ceased to function.
- C. It leaves the debate untouched, since dependence during embodied life is fully compatible with, and gives no evidence about, any post-mortem condition.
- D. It establishes the hylomorphic account, since only a soul that is the form of a living body can explain why mental life varies with cerebral states.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the owner treats the objection as burden-shifting rather than demonstrative, and lists exactly those three debts the survivalist then owes.
- **B:** Incorrect: dependence during embodiment does not entail impossibility afterwards, and stating it as a refutation overreaches the evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: this understates the objection, since a systematic dependence is evidentially relevant even where it is not conclusive.
- **D:** Incorrect: hylomorphism is one response among several, and the dependence data underdetermine the choice between the available models of the person.

Examiner trap 8: Treating brain-dependence as a disproof produces an unbalanced answer that cannot then explain why the survival debate continues at all.

MCQ 9. The verse base of Hindu immortality

Which mapping of *Bhagavad Gītā* references to their exam use is correct?

- A. 2.22 for indestructibility, 2.23 for the exhaustion of merit, and 9.21 for the discarding of worn-out garments at the moment of re-embodiment.
- B. 2.22 for the discarding of worn-out garments, 2.23 for indestructibility by weapons and elements, and 9.21 for return when merit is exhausted.
- C. 2.22 for the convergence of knowledge and action, 2.23 for the nine limbs of devotion, and 9.21 for the final instruction to take refuge alone.
- D. 2.22 for the injunction to desireless action, 2.23 for the plurality of pure consciousnesses, and 9.21 for the definition of embodied liberation.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first two references are interchanged, and 9.21 concerns return from the heavenly world rather than the change of garments.
- **B:** Correct: garments at 2.22, indestructibility at 2.23, and return on the exhaustion of merit at 9.21 is the owner's verified mapping.
- **C:** Incorrect: convergence belongs to 5.4-5, the nine limbs to *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.23, and the refuge verse to 18.66.

- **D:** Incorrect: none of these attributions is correct, and the plurality of consciousnesses belongs to Sāṃkhya rather than to any *Gītā* verse.

Examiner trap 9: A stem that says "with reference to the *Bhagavad Gītā*" is testing verse fidelity, and generic Vedānta without citation will not satisfy the directive.

MCQ 10. Where freedom operates in the threefold karma ledger

Given the classification of karma into stored (*sañcita*), already-fructifying (*prārabdha*) and future (*āgāmi*), where does present effort operate?

- A. On already-fructifying karma alone, since only what is currently maturing is close enough to present action to be altered by any effort at all.
- B. On none of the three, since the classification is precisely what shows karma to be a doctrine of fate in which present effort can change nothing.
- C. On future karma directly and on stored karma through liberating knowledge, but never on the portion that has already begun to fructify in this life.
- D. On stored karma alone, since the accumulated store is the only portion that has not yet been assigned to a particular embodiment or lifespan.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: fructifying karma is precisely the portion that runs its course, which is why the embodiment of a liberated knower continues at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: the classification exists to defeat the fatalist reading by locating exactly where effort still has purchase.
- **C:** Correct: effort generates and shapes future karma, liberating knowledge destroys the stored portion, and the fructifying portion is untouched.
- **D:** Incorrect: this ignores future karma, which is the portion present action is generating at every moment.

Examiner trap 10: Saying that liberating knowledge destroys all karma makes embodied liberation unintelligible and contradicts the potter's-wheel image the tradition uses.

MCQ 11. Who administers the law of karma

Which statement correctly represents the division between theistic and non-theistic accounts of karmic administration?

- A. Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā treat the law as self-regulating, while Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas make God the superintendent who dispenses the fruits.
- B. All Indian schools require a divine judge, since an impersonal law could not by itself match a particular fruit to a particular agent at a particular time.
- C. Only Advaita dispenses with a judge, since its non-dualism leaves no room for a distinct divine person capable of allocating results to individuals.
- D. Buddhism requires a judge but conceals the fact, while Jainism and Mīmāṃsā openly assign the administrative role to a creator who oversees the whole series.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's fork, with the theistic schools making God the ratifier of desert rather than its author.
- **B:** Incorrect: the anti-theistic schools explicitly deny any judge, and their doing so is precisely what makes their position philosophically significant.
- **C:** Incorrect: the self-regulating accounts are the Buddhist, Jain and Mīmāṃsā ones, and Advaita is not the school that defines this contrast.
- **D:** Incorrect: Buddhism has no divine judge at all, and Jainism explicitly has no creator God administering the karmic process.

Examiner trap 11: Making God the author of desert rather than its superintendent turns a Nyāya answer into a theodicy and misstates the school's own position.

MCQ 12. What rebirth contributes to karma theory

A 15-mark stem asks for the *significance* of rebirth in the theory of karma. Which formulation answers the question asked?

- A. Rebirth describes the passage of the subtle body from one embodiment to another, carrying the mind, the senses and the vital breath across the interval.
- B. Rebirth is a devotional teaching whose function is consolatory, offering the bereaved the assurance that a further meeting is possible in a later life.
- C. Rebirth is a cosmological doctrine about the cyclical structure of time, which the karmic law then borrows in order to describe the fate of individuals.
- D. Rebirth widens the temporal field in which karmic consequences mature, which is what allows the moral law to remain exceptionless without being visibly false.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this describes the mechanism when the stem asks for the function, and description is the standard way marks are lost on this question.
- **B:** Incorrect: consolation is not the philosophical role assigned by the owner, and treating it as such abandons the argumentative reading.
- **C:** Incorrect: the direction of dependence is reversed, since rebirth is required by the karmic claim rather than borrowed from cosmology.
- **D:** Correct: rebirth is the exit that preserves an exceptionless law against the evident fact that many acts do not mature within one lifetime.

Examiner trap 12: Describing rebirth when the stem asks for its significance converts an analytic question into a narrative one and caps the script well below the top band.

MCQ 13. The Buddhist argument, step by step

Which sequence states the Buddhist route from impermanence to rebirth without a permanent self?

- A. All aggregates are permanent; the self is one of them; craving is therefore eternal; and rebirth follows as the eternal self takes successive bodies.
- B. All conditioned factors are impermanent; no aggregate is a self; craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; so continuity occurs without an owner.
- C. All conditioned factors are impermanent; the self is therefore unknowable; rebirth is accordingly a conventional fiction; and moral responsibility is abandoned.
- D. All aggregates are momentary; a permanent self is inferred to explain their unity; and rebirth is that self's passage from one aggregate-series to the next.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first premise is reversed, and the conclusion reinstates the very transmigrating self the doctrine of no-self denies.
- **B:** Correct: these are the owner's four steps, and they yield continuity through conditioning rather than through a persisting substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: rebirth is affirmed rather than treated as a fiction, and moral responsibility is retained on the basis of causal descent.
- **D:** Incorrect: no permanent self is inferred; the unity of experience is explained by conditioning among the aggregates themselves.

Examiner trap 13: Writing that Buddhism "denies continuity" misstates the doctrine; what is denied is a permanent, independent substance-self, not the conditioned stream.

MCQ 14. Who receives the fruit if nothing persists

The objection that no one remains to receive the karmic fruit is answered by the Buddhist tradition in which way, and with what residue?

- A. By denying that karmic fruit exists at all, with the residue that the tradition's extensive teaching on merit and demerit becomes wholly unintelligible.
- B. By invoking a subtle body that carries dispositions, with the residue that the doctrine of no-self is quietly abandoned at the point where it matters most.
- C. By appealing to divine record-keeping, with the residue that a creator is reintroduced into a system whose whole interest lies in dispensing with one.
- D. By locating responsibility in causal descent rather than substantial identity, with the residue that critics doubt descent alone makes the fruit genuinely one's own.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: karmic consequence is affirmed throughout, and denying it would dissolve the moral teaching the doctrine is designed to support.
- **B:** Incorrect: the subtle-body vehicle belongs to the Vedāntic and Sāṃkhya accounts rather than to the Buddhist explanation of continuity.
- **C:** Incorrect: no divine record-keeper is invoked, and the absence of one is part of what makes the position philosophically distinctive.
- **D:** Correct: the reply is the "neither the same nor wholly other" formula, and the owner records the ownership worry as a genuine remaining pressure.

Examiner trap 14: Reporting the doctrine without meeting the "who is reborn?" objection reads as evasion, and examiners withhold the evaluative marks accordingly.

MCQ 15. The one liberation without consciousness

On the parity bench of liberation-termini, which school's terminus is characterised by the absence of consciousness itself?

- A. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, whose *apavarga* ends pain together with the qualities that sustain experience, consciousness being adventitious to the self-substance.
- B. Sāṃkhya-Yoga, whose *kaivalya* is the aloneness of a witness that has never possessed consciousness and acquires none at the moment of discrimination.
- C. Advaita Vedānta, whose *mokṣa* extinguishes the individual knower, leaving an impersonal ground in which no awareness of any kind can be present.
- D. Jainism, whose liberated soul sheds karmic matter and with it the four infinitudes, since perfection consists in the absence of all determinate qualities.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Nyāya treats consciousness as adventitious, arising only on conjunction with mind, senses and body, so release leaves the substance without it.
- **B:** Incorrect: *puruṣa* is pure consciousness by nature; what *kaivalya* removes is content and association, never awareness itself.
- **C:** Incorrect: Advaitic release is self-luminous and non-dual, and describing it as unconscious inverts the school's central claim.

- **D:** Incorrect: the four infinitudes - knowledge, perception, bliss and energy - are manifested at liberation rather than shed with the karmic matter.

Examiner trap 15: Describing *apavarga* as blissful is the most frequent error on the 2024 stem, and it contradicts the Nyāya account of consciousness outright.

MCQ 16. One syllable, two opposite contents

The terms *kaivalya* in Sāṃkhya-Yoga and *kevala-jñāna* in Jainism stand in which relation?

- A. They are synonyms drawn from a shared classical vocabulary, both denoting the isolation of a conscious principle from all material association.
- B. They are opposites in content: one names contentless isolation of consciousness, the other names omniscience, the fullest possible cognitive content.
- C. They are stages of a single path, the Sāṃkhya term naming the penultimate condition and the Jain term naming the final condition that follows it.
- D. They are the same doctrine under different school names, differing only in whether the liberated principle is described as one or as numerically many.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the shared syllable conceals opposite contents, and treating them as synonyms is the terminological trap the owner flags explicitly.
- **B:** Correct: Sāṃkhya aloneness is contentless while Jain *kevala* is omniscience, so the same syllable carries opposite doctrinal weight.
- **C:** Incorrect: they belong to different systems with incompatible metaphysics and are not stages of any single path.
- **D:** Incorrect: the difference is one of content rather than of number, and Sāṃkhya's plurality of consciousnesses is a separate doctrine.

Examiner trap 16: The shared syllable invites merger; an answer that separates omniscience from isolation in one sentence demonstrates control of the whole bench.

MCQ 17. Embodied liberation and the karma that remains

In Advaita, the continuing embodiment of one who has realised Brahman is explained by which doctrine, and with what consequence?

- A. By already-fructifying karma, which liberating knowledge does not cancel, so the body continues on residual momentum until it falls at *videhamukti*.
- B. By stored karma, which liberating knowledge preserves intact, so the liberated knower must exhaust the whole accumulated store before release occurs.
- C. By future karma, which the liberated knower continues to accumulate, so embodiment persists as long as further action generates further binding results.
- D. By divine decree, which sustains the liberated body for the benefit of others, so embodiment is a commission rather than a residue of prior action.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: knowledge destroys the stored and future portions while the fructifying portion runs its course, which the potter's-wheel image illustrates.
- **B:** Incorrect: the stored portion is precisely what knowledge destroys, and retaining it would make liberation while living impossible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the liberated knower accumulates no binding future karma, since the agency-sense that binds has been dismantled.

- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita explains the residual body by karmic momentum rather than by a commission, and no such decree is part of the doctrine.

Examiner trap 17: Saying knowledge destroys *prārabdha* makes embodied liberation self-contradictory and forfeits the central distinction of the 2025 stem.

MCQ 18. Liberation without a real agent

Consider the following statements about the Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita answers to whether liberation can be conceived without a real agent.

1. Advaita locates agency in the empirical individual and treats bondage and release as stated from the standpoint of ignorance.
2. Viśiṣṭādvaita holds that an unreal agent could not undertake real striving, real devotion or receive a real reward.
3. Advaita must explain how a superimposed individual undertakes a genuine discipline.
4. Viśiṣṭādvaita avoids all difficulty, since a really distinct soul raises no further question about its dependence on God.

Which of the statements are correct?

- A. Statements 1 and 4 only, since Advaita's level-distinction and the untroubled realism of Viśiṣṭādvaita exhaust the philosophical situation.
- B. Statements 2 and 4 only, since the objection to Advaita is decisive and the theistic school pays no corresponding price for its realism.
- C. Statements 1, 2 and 3 only, since each school states its position clearly and Advaita's cost is the intelligibility of discipline for a superimposed self.
- D. Statements 1, 3 and 4 only, since Viśiṣṭādvaita's objection is not to the reality of the agent but only to the possibility of embodied liberation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 4 is false, because Viśiṣṭādvaita must still explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless wholly dependent on God.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is correct but statement 4 is not, and the owner is explicit that each position pays a price.
- **C:** Correct: the first three statements are the owner's, and the honest verdict is that both schools carry a cost rather than one being unscathed.
- **D:** Incorrect: statement 4 remains false, and the Viśiṣṭādvaita objection concerns the reality of the agent rather than embodied liberation.

Examiner trap 18: Answering this stem by praising one school and dismissing the other loses the evaluative marks, which are reserved for pricing both positions.

MCQ 19. The Jain ladder from bondage to release

Which sequence states the Jain analysis of bondage and its reversal in the correct order?

- A. Passions produce inflow, inflow produces bondage, restraint produces stoppage, austerity produces shedding, and the soul's own infinitudes then manifest.
- B. Bondage produces passions, passions produce austerity, austerity produces inflow, stoppage produces omniscience, and the soul acquires its infinitudes.
- C. Inflow produces passions, passions produce stoppage, stoppage produces bondage, shedding produces embodiment, and the soul is absorbed into the whole.
- D. Austerity produces inflow, inflow produces stoppage, stoppage produces passions, bondage produces omniscience, and the soul is created anew at release.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the owner's ladder from *āsrava* through *bandha* to *saṃvara* and *nirjarā*, ending in manifested rather than acquired perfection.
- **B:** Incorrect: the order is scrambled, and it makes bondage prior to the passions that in fact cause the soul to become adhesive.
- **C:** Incorrect: stoppage cannot produce bondage, and the Jain liberated soul is never absorbed into any larger whole.
- **D:** Incorrect: austerity sheds rather than attracts karmic matter, and the soul is eternal rather than created at any point.

Examiner trap 19: A stem asking for "soul **and** bondage" carries two obligations, and delivering the metaphysics without the four-stage mechanism answers only half of it.

MCQ 20. What Sāṃkhya says about who is bound

Sāṃkhya-kārikā 62-63 makes which claim, and why does it matter for this clause?

- A. That *puruṣa* alone is bound and released, which matters because it makes Sāṃkhya the clearest Indian statement of a substantial transmigrating soul.
- B. That *prakṛti* alone is conscious, which matters because it removes the need for a second principle and reduces the system to a single-substance view.
- C. That strictly no *puruṣa* is bound, released or transmigrating, since it is *prakṛti* who binds, transmigrates and releases herself; liberation corrects a misattribution.
- D. That liberation is impossible before death, which matters because it distinguishes Sāṃkhya from Advaita's doctrine of liberation while the body persists.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the *kārikās* assert precisely the opposite, and this reading is the error the owner marks as the module's most costly.
- **B:** Incorrect: *prakṛti* is unconscious by definition, and the distinctness of consciousness from it is the argument for *puruṣa*.
- **C:** Correct: liberation is an epistemic correction rather than an ontological change, which is the highest-value item in the Sāṃkhya module.
- **D:** Incorrect: *kārikās* 67-68 grant embodied aloneness on the potter's-wheel model, with disembodied aloneness at the fall of the body.

Examiner trap 20: Writing that *puruṣa* is bound and then released contradicts the school's own text and undoes the distinction between correction and change.

MCQ 21. The Nyāya route to release

Which reconstruction of the Nyāya path from suffering to release is correct?

- A. Suffering arises from divine decree; petition removes the decree; petition ends activity; and release is the reward of a life of properly directed worship.
- B. Suffering arises from matter; austerity destroys matter; destruction of matter ends birth; and release is the manifestation of the soul's infinite knowledge.
- C. Suffering arises from craving; the eightfold path ends craving; ending craving ends formations; and release is the extinguishing of the conditioned stream.
- D. Suffering arises through birth, activity, defect and false knowledge; true knowledge removes false knowledge; and the chain unwinds to absolute cessation of pain.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Nyāya's God ratifies karmic desert rather than decreeing suffering, and release comes through knowledge rather than petition.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the Jain account, in which karma is quasi-material and austerity performs the shedding.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the Buddhist account, and its terminus is the extinguishing of craving rather than the cessation of pain in a self-substance.
- **D:** Correct: cutting the chain at false knowledge unwinds everything downstream, which is exactly why *apavarga* is stated negatively.

Examiner trap 21: Blending the Nyāya chain with the Buddhist one produces a hybrid that belongs to neither school and is penalised as school-confusion.

MCQ 22. Devotion, grace and effort

The cat and monkey illustrations (*mānjāra*- and *markaṭa-nyāya*) are used in the Śrīvaiṣṇava tradition to state which problem?

- A. The problem of whether devotion is superior to knowledge, the cat standing for effortless insight and the monkey for the laborious study of scripture.
- B. The problem of how grace and effort combine, the cat carrying the kitten standing for grace alone and the clinging young monkey for grace with effort.
- C. The problem of whether devotion may be directed to a formless ultimate, the cat standing for image-worship and the monkey for interior contemplation.
- D. The problem of whether liberation preserves individuality, the cat standing for absorption into God and the monkey for eternal service in communion.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the illustrations concern the grace-effort relation and not the relative rank of devotion and knowledge.
- **B:** Correct: the Teṅkalai and Vaḍakalai positions are stated by these two images, which is the most efficient way to display the problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the with-form and formless distinction is a separate typological matter and is not what these images encode.
- **D:** Incorrect: the persistence of individuality is settled by Viśiṣṭādvaita's metaphysics rather than by either illustration.

Examiner trap 22: Treating devotion as mere emotion loses the structural point that its contribution is the shift from achievement to reception through grace.

MCQ 23. The three-means dispute, correctly located

Which statement best captures how this owner wants the knowledge-action-devotion question answered?

- A. All three are equally direct means, so the correct answer harmonises the schools and treats the apparent disagreement as verbal rather than substantive.
- B. Only action is a means, since the Vedic corpus is essentially injunctive and knowledge-passages exist to supply the results that ritual action secures.
- C. Only devotion is a means, since the beginninglessly bound soul cannot lift itself and every school ultimately concedes that grace alone can liberate.
- D. All three are means of different kinds - action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes - and which is direct follows from whether release is produced or uncovered.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: harmonising is exactly what the owner forbids, since the schools disagree substantively about which means is direct.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the Mīmāṃsā position, which the owner presents as one party to the dispute rather than as its resolution.
- **C:** Incorrect: Advaita denies that devotion is directly liberating, so the claim that every school concedes this is false.
- **D:** Correct: naming the disagreement and grounding it in the production-versus-removal fork is the owner's stated verdict formula.

Examiner trap 23: "All three are equal" is the single most common closing sentence on this stem, and it forfeits every mark reserved for naming the disagreement.

MCQ 24. Resurrection and rebirth compared

Which row of the resurrection-rebirth comparison is stated correctly?

- A. Number of lives: resurrection posits a beginningless series, while rebirth concentrates all moral settlement into one earthly life and a final judgement.
- B. Telos: resurrection aims at restored embodied life in communion with God, while rebirth aims at exit from the series into release or extinguishing.
- C. Judge: resurrection leaves desert to an impersonal law, while rebirth requires a personal God to allocate each fruit to its appropriate recipient.
- D. Body: resurrection discards the body as a worn-out garment, while rebirth treats the raised body as essential to the identity of the person restored.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two columns are reversed, since resurrection posits one life and rebirth a beginningless series.
- **B:** Correct: restored embodiment before God against exit from the series is the clearest structural contrast on the owner's grid.
- **C:** Incorrect: this also reverses the columns, since it is rebirth that operates by self-regulating law and resurrection that involves a judge.
- **D:** Incorrect: the body is discarded in rebirth and essential in resurrection, so the attributions are again the wrong way round.

Examiner trap 24: Presenting resurrection as rebirth in heaven merges two structurally opposed doctrines and destroys the comparison the 2019 stem requires.

Remedial drills - the eight errors that cost marks on this clause

MCQ 25. Remedial: is resurrection a variety of rebirth?

A candidate writes that resurrection is simply rebirth into a heavenly world. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The correction is unnecessary, since both doctrines describe a post-mortem continuation and the difference between them is one of religious idiom only.
- B. Resurrection is indeed rebirth in heaven, but the term should be avoided because Christian writers prefer to speak of the raising of the whole person.
- C. Resurrection is one life, a divine re-constitution of an embodied person and a final judgement, whereas rebirth is renewed embodiment within a series.
- D. Resurrection differs only in lacking karma, so once a divine judge replaces the impersonal law the two doctrines become structurally indistinguishable.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the doctrines differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos, identity-bearer, treatment of the body and direction of time.
- **B:** Incorrect: this concedes the substantive error while objecting only to vocabulary, which leaves the misunderstanding in place.
- **C:** Correct: this is the owner's contrast, and Cullmann's title makes the opposition of the two frameworks explicit.
- **D:** Incorrect: replacing the law with a judge leaves untouched the difference between one life and a beginningless series.

Examiner trap 25: Because both doctrines are "life after death", candidates assimilate them; the examiner is testing whether the two structures are kept apart.

MCQ 26. Remedial: what *nāstika* means

A candidate glosses *nāstika* as "atheist" and concludes that Jainism must deny the soul. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The gloss is acceptable, since rejecting Vedic authority and rejecting a creator amount in practice to the same philosophical commitment.
- B. *Nāstika* marks rejection of Vedic authority rather than atheism, and Jainism denies a creator while affirming an eternal individual soul.
- C. *Nāstika* marks rejection of the soul rather than of the Veda, so the conclusion about Jainism follows correctly from the classification.
- D. *Nāstika* marks rejection of rebirth, so both Buddhism and Jainism are misclassified by the term and should be described as orthodox systems.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two rejections are logically independent, and Mīmāṃsā accepts the Veda while assigning no role to a creator.
- **B:** Correct: the label concerns scriptural authority, and Jainism's eternal soul coexists with its denial of a creator God.
- **C:** Incorrect: the term has never meant denial of the soul, and Jainism's soul-realism refutes the inference drawn from it.
- **D:** Incorrect: both traditions affirm rebirth, so the proposed gloss fails on its own terms as well as historically.

Examiner trap 26: The mistranslation of *nāstika* generates a chain of errors, most damagingly the claim that Jainism must deny the soul it in fact makes eternal.

MCQ 27. Remedial: how far the anti-theistic case goes

A candidate concludes that Buddhism and Jainism refute theism because they explain karma and liberation without a God. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The conclusion holds, since an explanation that dispenses with a God shows that the God-hypothesis is false rather than merely unnecessary.
- B. The conclusion holds for Jainism only, since its eternal souls exclude a creator, while Buddhism leaves the question of a creator entirely open.
- C. The conclusion fails because both traditions in fact presuppose a divine ordering principle under a different name, so no genuine detachment occurs.
- D. The conclusion overreaches: what is shown is detachability - that karma needs no judge, rebirth no soul and liberation no grace - not that no God exists.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: dispensability is not falsity, and the owner's discipline restricts the claim to what the structure does not require.
- **B:** Incorrect: Buddhism's denial of a creator is explicit, so the restriction to Jainism misreports both traditions.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such ordering principle is smuggled in; the moral law is treated as a basic feature of how things work.
- **D:** Correct: the three detachments are the significance-claim, and stating them as such is what the 2018 stem rewards.

Examiner trap 27: Reading "philosophically significant" as "successful refutation" turns a structural observation into a polemic the sources do not support.

MCQ 28. Remedial: two-obligation stems

A stem reads: "Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation." What does the directive require?

- A. A single continuous account of Advaita metaphysics, since the second sentence merely restates the first in the vocabulary of epistemology.
- B. Two equally weighted parts - the concept of release, then the specific role of knowledge as the sole operative cause on the removal model.
- C. A comparison with Viśiṣṭādvaita, since the role of knowledge can only be exhibited against a school that assigns knowledge a different function.
- D. An account of the fourfold qualification alone, since the disciplines that precede knowledge are what the phrase "role of knowledge" refers to.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the two sentences impose distinct obligations, and collapsing them leaves half the demand unaddressed.
- **B:** Correct: the directive decoder treats "elucidate... and explain the role of..." as two obligations that must both be delivered.
- **C:** Incorrect: comparison may enrich the answer but is not what the stem demands, and it cannot substitute for the second obligation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the fourfold qualification is preparatory, whereas the role of knowledge concerns its function as the cause that removes ignorance.

Examiner trap 28: Two-verb stems are the commonest silent mark-loss in this clause, because a strong answer to half the question still scores as half an answer.

MCQ 29. Remedial: does no-self mean no continuity?

A candidate writes that Buddhism, by denying the self, thereby denies personal continuity and moral responsibility. Which correction is accurate?

- A. Buddhism denies a permanent, independent substance-self while retaining the conventional person, causal continuity, rebirth and moral consequence.
- B. Buddhism denies continuity as well as the self, and accepts the consequence that moral responsibility is a useful fiction with no ultimate standing.
- C. Buddhism denies the self only in meditation contexts, and restores a substantial self whenever questions of rebirth or responsibility arise.
- D. Buddhism denies the body rather than the self, so continuity is preserved by a mental substance that passes intact from one embodiment to the next.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the position is a middle course between an eternal self and annihilation, and it retains everything the objection assumes it discards.
- **B:** Incorrect: responsibility is grounded in causal descent rather than abandoned, and the tradition argues the point explicitly.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such contextual restoration occurs; the denial is systematic and is precisely what the rebirth account is built to accommodate.
- **D:** Incorrect: this substitutes a mental substance for the self, which is the very transmigrating entity the doctrine denies.

Examiner trap 29: "No self, therefore no continuity" is the error that makes Buddhism look self-refuting; the counter-example only works once the distinction is stated.

MCQ 30. Remedial: is apavarga a state of bliss?

A candidate describes Nyāya release as eternal bliss enjoyed by the liberated self. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The description is correct, since every Indian school characterises its terminus as blissful and Nyāya is no exception to this general pattern.
- B. The description is correct for Vaiśeṣika but not for Nyāya, since the two systems diverge on whether release retains any experiential content.
- C. The description should be softened to "peace", since Nyāya allows a residual positive feeling once all painful qualities have finally ceased.
- D. The description is wrong: consciousness is adventitious to the Nyāya self, so release ends pain together with the qualities that sustain any experience.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sāṃkhya likewise refuses to call its terminus blissful, so the supposed general pattern does not hold.
- **B:** Incorrect: the allied systems agree on this point, and no such divergence is recorded in the owner.
- **C:** Incorrect: no residual positive feeling is admitted, since the conditions for any experience whatsoever have ended.
- **D:** Correct: the negative characterisation follows directly from treating consciousness as a quality arising only on conjunction with body and mind.

Examiner trap 30: Adding bliss to *apavarga* makes the Nyāya answer internally inconsistent and simultaneously erases the contrast with Advaitic release.

MCQ 31. Remedial: what liberating knowledge destroys

A candidate writes that liberating knowledge in Advaita destroys all karma, including the portion already fructifying. Which correction is accurate?

- A. The claim is correct, and the continuing body of the liberated knower is therefore explained by the compassionate will of God rather than by karma.
- B. The claim is wrong: knowledge destroys stored and future karma, while already-fructifying karma runs its course, which is why embodied liberation is possible.
- C. The claim is wrong: knowledge destroys only future karma, so the liberated knower must still exhaust the entire accumulated store before release.
- D. The claim is correct for Sāṃkhya but not for Advaita, since only the former allows aloneness to be reached while the body continues to function.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Advaita explains the residual body by karmic momentum, and no divine sustaining will is invoked at this point.
- **B:** Correct: the distinction between the destroyed portions and the fructifying remainder is what makes liberation while living intelligible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the stored portion is destroyed by knowledge, and requiring its exhaustion would make embodied liberation impossible.
- **D:** Incorrect: both traditions allow embodied liberation, and both use the potter's-wheel image for the residual momentum.

Examiner trap 31: Erasing the fructifying remainder removes the only mechanism the school has for explaining why a liberated knower still has a body.

MCQ 32. Remedial: the kevala trap and who transmigrates

A candidate writes that Sāṃkhya's *kaivalya* is the omniscience of a liberated *puruṣa* that has transmigrated through many bodies. How many distinct errors does this contain, and what are they?

- A. One error only: *kaivalya* should be described as bliss rather than omniscience, while the account of transmigration is accurate as it stands.
- B. One error only: *puruṣa* does not transmigrate, while omniscience is an accurate description of the content of Sāṃkhya's liberated state.
- C. Two errors: *kaivalya* is contentless isolation rather than omniscience, and it is *prakṛti* rather than *puruṣa* that binds and transmigrates.
- D. Three errors: *kaivalya* is annihilation, *puruṣa* is one rather than many, and transmigration belongs to the Vedāntic rather than the Sāṃkhya system.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sāṃkhya explicitly denies that aloneness is bliss, and the transmigration claim is the module's flagged error.
- **B:** Incorrect: the transmigration point is right but omniscience is wrong, since *kevala-jñāna* belongs to Jainism rather than to Sāṃkhya.
- **C:** Correct: kārikās 62-63 assign binding and transmigration to *prakṛti*, and aloneness is contentless rather than omniscient.
- **D:** Incorrect: aloneness is not annihilation, *puruṣa* is plural in Sāṃkhya, and transmigration is affirmed within the system.

Examiner trap 32: Two flagged traps combine in one sentence here, which is why examiners treat this formulation as diagnostic of an unread Sāṃkhya module.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved previous-year questions - all 17 verified owner parts, 2018-2025

Ledger discipline. Exact wording, year and marks are reproduced from the audited local Philosophy of Religion Paper II bank for 2018-2025. This clause owns exactly **17** primary parts out of 112 - 2018:2, 2019:1, 2020:2, 2021:3, 2022:3, 2023:2, 2024:2, 2025:2. Paper I questions that merely mention release or the soul are **not** counted here. UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II; every model below is independent learner practice.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): How far is it plausible to argue that the anti-theistic religions' stand on the concept of rebirth is philosophically significant?

Demand decoding. "How far is it plausible" asks for a **graded verdict**, not a description. "Anti-theistic religions" means the Veda-rejecting traditions, principally Buddhism and Jainism. "Philosophically significant" must be read structurally - what their position shows about what rebirth *requires* - and not as praise.

Model answer (≈150 words). The anti-theistic traditions are philosophically significant because they demonstrate three detachments. **First, karma without a judge:** in Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā the moral law is self-regulating, so desert is discharged without a divine allocator, answering the distribution question by structure rather than by theodicy. **Second, rebirth without a soul:** Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*), so continuity, not substance, is what rebirth requires. **Third, liberation without grace:** extinguishing (*nirvāṇa*) and Jain perfected omniscience need neither deity nor divine favour. Jainism removes the God while keeping the soul; Buddhism removes the soul while keeping rebirth - together they show the whole structure separable from both. **Verdict:** the significance is high but strictly structural. It establishes detachability and shifts the burden onto those who claim a judge or a substance adds explanatory work; it does not amount to a refutation of theism.

Marks rationale. The examiner is buying (i) the reading of "significant" as a modal claim, (ii) three named detachments rather than a survey, (iii) the Jain/Buddhist asymmetry, and (iv) an explicit limit on the conclusion.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 1 min thesis · 5 min three detachments with named schools · 2 min asymmetry · 1 min bounded verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Glossing *nāstika* as "atheist"; merging the Buddhist and Jain positions; converting detachability into a disproof of theism.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation.

Demand decoding. "Evaluate... as a pathway" demands assessment of **efficacy**, which requires a stated criterion. Description of devotional practice earns almost nothing; the marks are in accessibility, sufficiency and terminus.

Model answer (≈250 words). Criterion first. A pathway must be judged on accessibility, sufficiency and terminus.

Textual base. *Bhagavad Gītā* 18.66 makes surrender the text's final instruction; 9.22 and 9.32 state the Lord's securing and the path's openness. *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.23 lists the nine limbs (*navadhā bhakti*): hearing, praising, remembering, service at the feet, worship, salutation, servitude, friendship and self-offering. The *Nārada* and *Śaṇḍilya Bhakti Sūtras* define devotion as supreme love or attachment to the Lord.

Typology. Higher and preliminary (*parā/aparā*); rule-governed and spontaneous (*vaidhī/rāgānugā*); with-form (Tulsīdās, Sūrdās, Mīrābāī) and formless (Kabīr, Nānak, Dādū) - the last showing devotion requires a *personal focus*, not an iconic form.

Systematic positions. Rāmānuja treats devotion as steady loving recollection (*dhruvānusmṛti*), with self-surrender (*prapatti*) as the universally accessible alternative and grace as decisive; the cat and monkey illustrations (*mānjāra/markaṭa-nyāya*) state the grace-effort problem exactly. Madhva requires knowledge-preceded affection; Vallabha teaches nourishing grace; Caitanya makes love a fifth human end. Advaita makes devotion preparatory - purification of mind (*citta-suddhi*) - not directly liberating.

Assessment. Accessibility is its greatest strength, dispensing with Sanskrit learning and ritual entitlement, which explains the vernacular Bhakti movement. Its strongest philosophical claim is the incapacity argument: a beginninglessly bound soul cannot lift itself, and devotion is the posture in which grace is received. Against it: love presupposes duality, so it cannot deliver Advaitic identity; emotionalism is a real risk; and it presupposes a personal focus unavailable to strictly non-theistic systems.

Verdict. Devotion is a complete path in the theistic Vedāntas and a preparatory discipline in Advaita. Its significance is not emotional but structural: it relocates liberation from achievement to reception.

Marks rationale. Criterion-first evaluation, precise verse citation in order, the grace-effort dispute named, the achievement-to-reception thesis stated explicitly, and the school-relative sufficiency verdict.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 1 min criterion · 4 min textual base and typology · 4 min systematic positions · 3 min assessment · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Describing devotional practice instead of evaluating it; saying "Advaita rejects bhakti"; attributing the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* definition to Śaṅkara personally.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): State and explain the doctrines of Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism.

Demand decoding. "State and explain" imposes two obligations; "A, B and C" requires all three defined **separately** and then related. The examiner's hidden test is whether rebirth and reincarnation are distinguished.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. Karma, rebirth and reincarnation are linked but non-identical: karma supplies the mechanism, rebirth the field, and "reincarnation" a school-specific substantialist reading of that field.

Karma. Act together with its unseen potency (*adṛṣṭa*; in Mīmāṃsā *apūrva*), which persists until it matures. It is classified as stored (*sañcita*), already-fructifying (*prārabdha*) and future (*āgāmi*). It is moral causation, not fatalism: human effort (*puruṣakāra*) operates within inherited destiny (*daiva*), acting on future karma and, through liberating knowledge, on the stored portion. Administration divides - self-regulating in the anti-theistic schools, superintended by God (*karmādhyakṣa*) in Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas, where God ratifies desert rather than authoring it.

Rebirth. Re-embodiment (*punarjanma*) within a beginningless wandering-on (*saṃsāra*). The subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*) carries latent dispositions (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*). *Gītā* 2.22 gives the image of worn-out garments; 9.21 shows that even heaven is a within-*saṃsāra* stage, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. Its function is to widen the temporal field in which karmic consequence can mature, so that an exceptionless moral law is not falsified by a single life.

Reincarnation. In careful usage, *re-enfleshing* presupposes a **substantial soul** re-entering a body - apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism. Rebirth is the wider, neutral term and the only correct one for Buddhism's re-becoming (*punarbhava*) without a transmigrating substance. Sanskrit registers the range: *punarjanma*, *punarāvṛtti*, *saṃsāra*.

Contrast and criticism. Resurrection is the structural opposite - one life, divine re-constitution, final judgement; Cullmann (1955) argues Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are opposed rather than complementary. Against rebirth: the memory objection, unverifiability, and the risk of victim-blaming. Replies: memory is not continuity; unverifiability is shared with eschatology; explanation licenses no social judgement.

Conclusion. Karma is the mechanism, rebirth the field, and reincarnation a substantialist reading of that field which Buddhism refuses.

Marks rationale. Three separate definitions, then their interlocking; the reincarnation/rebirth distinction the stem is built to test; a named Western comparator; and criticisms with replies.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 2 min thesis · 5 min karma · 4 min rebirth · 3 min reincarnation distinction · 2 min contrast and criticism · 1 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Defining only two of the three; using "reincarnation" for Buddhism; omitting the threefold karma classification.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): The concept of 'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion. Elaborate your answer.

Demand decoding. A quoted thesis with "elaborate your answer" - the candidate must take a position and defend it. The strongest answer accepts the thesis in a qualified form and states the counter-cases.

Model answer (≈150 words). Immortality functions as a **presupposition** in several religious frameworks, but not as a universal one. It is presupposed wherever (i) moral desert must be completed beyond the visible life, (ii) worship is directed to a relation that death cannot terminate, and (iii) liberation or salvation is offered as an ultimate good. Kant's practical postulate is the sharpest philosophical statement of (i): the moral law demands a completion no single life supplies, so immortality is postulated rather than proved. In the Indian frameworks, the deathlessness of the self is presupposed by rebirth and by release alike. **But the thesis is not universal.** Early Hebrew religion is largely this-worldly, and Buddhism reaches liberation with no deathless soul at all, affirming re-becoming through causal continuity. **Verdict:** immortality is a widespread and often load-bearing presupposition, but the correct claim is that religions presuppose a *continuity-bearer* adequate to their soteriology - not always an immortal soul.

Marks rationale. A qualified acceptance, the presupposition analysed into three functions, Kant named, and two decisive counter-cases that convert a slogan into a thesis.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 2 min three functions · 3 min Kant and the Indian case · 3 min counter-cases · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Agreeing without qualification; omitting the Buddhist counter-case; treating immortality as identical with resurrection.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Do you accept that Knowledge, Action and Devotion are the means to attain liberation in Indian tradition? Discuss.

Demand decoding. "Do you accept...? Discuss" requires an explicit position first, then reasons, then the strongest contrary case. The examiner's test is whether the candidate **names the disagreement** rather than harmonising.

Model answer (≈250 words). Position. I accept that all three are means, but deny that they are means of the same kind - and the real question is which is *direct*.

Apparatus. Three distinctions decide everything: direct means (*sākṣāt-sādhana*) versus auxiliary aid (*ārād-upakāra*); means versus qualification (*adhikāra*); and the **production** versus **removal** model of liberation. If release is a result to be produced, action can produce it; if it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it.

The positions. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā: action alone, since the Veda is essentially injunctive. Śaṅkara: knowledge alone liberates, because release is not a producible effect (*sādhya*) but the eternally accomplished nature of the self (*siddha*) obscured by ignorance; he therefore rejects the knowledge-and-action combination (*jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda*), while retaining action and worship as preparation producing purity of mind and the fourfold qualification, matured through hearing, reflecting and meditating. Rāmānuja: sequential culmination - action purifies, knowledge discloses the self as a mode of God, both flow into devotion as the direct means, with self-surrender as the accessible alternative. Madhva: knowledge-grounded devotion, with grace decisive.

The text's own signal. *Gītā* 5.4-5 says only the immature (*bālāḥ*) declare knowledge and action different - which is why Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Tilak could each claim the text. Vivekananda's four yogas are temperament-matched, a psychological rather than metaphysical pluralism.

Objection and reply. Objection: convergence is diplomatic mush, since knowledge dissolving individuality and devotion preserving it cannot terminate in one state. Reply: they converge in *function* - dismantling egoic appropriation - and diverge in *terminus*.

Conclusion. Action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes. Which is direct follows from a prior question: is liberation produced or uncovered?

Marks rationale. Position stated first; the three-distinction apparatus deployed early; four schools named with their exact claims; the *Gītā* signal; and a verdict that names the disagreement instead of dissolving it.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 1 min position · 3 min apparatus · 5 min four positions · 2 min *Gītā* and objection · 2 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Concluding "all three are equal"; omitting *Mīmāṃsā*, which is why the dispute exists; describing devotion without its direct-means claim.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the concept of immortality of soul with special reference to Hindu tradition.

Demand decoding. "With special reference to" fixes the evidence base; "Hindu tradition" is not one position, so the answer must be **school-differentiated**. A generic account of an eternal soul will score in the average band.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. In the Hindu traditions immortality is not a reward that follows death but the standing nature of the self; the schools then differ sharply on what that deathless thing is.

The shared frame. The self (*ātman*) is beginningless and indestructible. *Gītā* 2.23 states that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy it; 2.22 gives re-embodiment as the changing of worn-out garments; 9.21 shows that heaven is a stage inside the wandering-on, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. The subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*), carrying latent dispositions, is the **vehicle** of continuity and must not be mistaken for the continuant.

The supports offered. (i) Continuity of the knower: waking, dream and deep sleep vary and are known as varying, so the witness of their variation is not one of them. (ii) Moral bookkeeping: act and fruit are separated by more time than a life provides. (iii) Scriptural testimony (*śabda*) as a valid means in supersensible matters - a presupposition to be named, not smuggled. (iv) Beginninglessness (*anādi*), which blocks the question when the soul first fell.

The schools. Advaita: the self is non-dual awareness identical with Brahman; bondage is ignorance, and individuality is sublated at release. Viśiṣṭādvaita: the soul is an eternal individual, a mode (*prakāra*) of God, which reaches God without becoming God. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika: an eternal self-substance to which consciousness is *adventitious*, so release (*apavarga*) is existence without consciousness or bliss. Sāṃkhya-Yoga: *puruṣa* is plural contentless consciousness, and strictly it neither transmigrates nor is bound (*Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63).

Objection and reply. The memory objection asks why nothing of earlier lives is recalled; the reply distinguishes episodic memory from dispositional continuity, though empirical warrant remains contested.

Conclusion. "Hindu immortality" names a shared conviction of the self's deathlessness housing at least four incompatible accounts of what is deathless - and the marks lie in the differentiation.

Marks rationale. Verse fidelity, the vehicle/continuant distinction, four named schools with their exact commitments, an objection with a qualified reply, and a differentiating conclusion.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 2 min thesis · 4 min shared frame with verses · 4 min supports · 5 min four schools · 2 min objection and conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Writing "Hinduism believes"; confusing the subtle body with the self; making Nyāya release blissful.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation.

Demand decoding. Two obligations, equally weighted. Half the answer elucidates release; half explains the role of knowledge. Delivering only the first is the standard silent mark-loss.

Model answer (≈250 words). Part 1 - the concept. In Advaita, bondage is not a real chain but a **cognitive error**: the self, non-different from Brahman, is taken to be a limited individual. Release (*mokṣa*) is therefore not produced. What is produced can be destroyed, whereas the self's freedom is eternally accomplished (*siddha*) and merely obscured by ignorance (*avidyā*). Release is available **while living** (*jīvanmukti*): the knower of Brahman is free now, the body continuing on already-fructifying karma (*prārabdha*) - the potter's wheel still turning after the hand is withdrawn - until *videhamukti* at its fall. Individuality is not annihilated but **sublated**: shown to have been superimposed.

Part 2 - the role of knowledge. On the removal model, knowledge is not one contributory cause among several but the **sole operative cause**, because the obstacle is cognitive: ignorance is destroyed by knowledge as darkness by light. Ritual action and worship (*upāsana*) are indispensable but only as **qualification and purification** - they generate purity of mind (*citta-śuddhi*) and the fourfold qualification (*sādhana-catuṣṭaya*: discrimination, dispassion, the six accomplishments, the desire for release). Knowledge then matures through **hearing, reflecting and meditating** (*śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*). Śaṅkara accordingly rejects the knowledge-and-action combination (*jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda*).

Objection and reply. If ignorance is destroyed, why does embodied life continue? Advaita distinguishes the destruction of stored and future karma from the momentum of an embodiment already under way; critics reply that a residue seems reintroduced, and the school locates it in the body-mind complex rather than in the knower.

Conclusion. Release is the removal of an error, and knowledge is its only remover; everything else qualifies the candidate rather than producing the result.

Marks rationale. Both obligations delivered in balance, the removal model named as the reason for knowledge's monopoly, the embodied-liberation mechanism stated exactly, and the combination doctrine explicitly rejected.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 5 min concept · 5 min role of knowledge · 2 min objection · 1 min conclusion.

Penalties to avoid. Answering only the concept; saying knowledge destroys fructifying karma; describing sublation as annihilation.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.

Demand decoding. "Discuss and evaluate" plus "essential postulate" - the candidate must show what would break if karma were removed, and then price the doctrine's costs.

Model answer (≈250 words). Statement. Karma is act together with its unseen potency (*adr̥ṣṭa/apūrva*), classified as stored, already-fructifying and future, operating within a beginningless series.

Why it is essential, not merely held. Remove karma and four commitments fail. (i) The **distribution** of fortune becomes arbitrary, and the tradition loses its answer to unequal suffering. (ii) **Rebirth loses its rationale**, since nothing would require a further life. (iii) **Liberation loses its content**, since there would be no bondage to be freed from. (iv) In Mīmāṃsā, **ritual injunction loses its efficacy**, since *apūrva* is what links sacrifice to distant result. That is the test of a postulate: not that it is believed, but that its removal disables the rest of the system.

It is not fatalism. The threefold classification exists precisely to locate freedom: effort (*puruṣakāra*) generates future karma and, through liberating knowledge, destroys the stored portion; only the fructifying portion runs its course. Desireless action (*niṣkāma-karma*) uses the law rather than escaping it.

Evaluation - the costs. (a) **Unverifiability:** the postulated links are not observable. (b) **Moral hazard:** present suffering may be read as evidence of past fault. (c) **The God-and-law problem:** either God is redundant, or subordinate to the law. **Replies:** unverifiability is shared with every eschatology; explanatory karma licenses no social judgement, and the duty of compassion is untouched; and the theistic schools answer (c) by making God the **superintendent** (*karmādhyaṣṭa*) who ratifies desert rather than authoring it.

Verdict. Karma is genuinely a postulate - system-enabling rather than merely traditional - but a postulate whose price is unverifiability and whose misuse is socially dangerous, and both must be stated.

Marks rationale. Postulate-status argued by removal test; fatalism refuted from the classification; three costs with replies; and a verdict that concedes the price.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 2 min statement · 5 min removal test · 2 min anti-fatalism · 3 min costs and replies · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Describing karma rather than arguing its postulate-status; omitting the victim-blaming control; making God the author of desert.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): "Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Critically examine with reference to Buddhism.

Demand decoding. A quoted necessity claim, with the school of examination **named**. The answer must be modal and must run through the Buddhist account specifically.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. Substantialist systems - Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism - do assert it: a persisting self (*ātman/jīva*) is what transmigrates, so on their metaphysics immortality is what makes rebirth possible.

The Buddhist counter-case. Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*). Its argument runs: all conditioned factors are impermanent; no aggregate (*skandha*) is a self; craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; therefore continuity occurs without an unchanging owner. The flame lit from a flame, and milk becoming curd, illustrate a stream that is **neither the same nor wholly other**.

Objection and reply. If nothing persists, who receives the fruit? Responsibility rests on **causal descent**, not substantial identity - though critics rightly press whether descent alone makes the fruit genuinely one's own.

Verdict. A deathless soul is **sufficient** for rebirth but not **necessary**. What rebirth requires is a continuity-bearer; the schools differ only on whether that bearer must be a substance.

Marks rationale. Substantialist case granted, the four-step Buddhist argument reconstructed, the ownership objection met, and the modal verdict stated in the stem's own vocabulary.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 2 min substantialist case · 4 min Buddhist argument · 2 min objection · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Saying Buddhism denies continuity; using the flame as proof; ending without the necessary/sufficient verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is it possible to have an idea of Liberation without the conception of a real agent? In this context, discuss the difference between Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita systems of thought.

Demand decoding. A conceptual question **plus** a named comparison. Both must be delivered, and the comparison must be organised by the question rather than appended to it.

Model answer (≈250 words). The question. Liberation appears to require someone who is bound, who strives and who is freed. The dispute is whether that "someone" must be *ultimately* real.

Advaita: yes, it is possible - and necessary. Agency belongs to the empirical individual, which is itself superimposed by ignorance (*avidyā*). At the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*) there is no agent, no bondage and therefore no one who is literally liberated; the tradition itself states that bondage and release are described from the standpoint of ignorance. Release is the removal of an error, and what is removed is precisely the mistaken individuality. Liberation while living (*jīvanmukti*) is intelligible on this model because nothing needs to be *acquired*.

Viśiṣṭādvaita: no, it is not possible. An unreal agent could not undertake real striving, real devotion, or receive a real reward. The soul (*jīva*) is an eternal individual, a mode (*prakāra*) of God - real, distinct and never absorbed. Bondage is beginningless karma and dependence; release is communion and service, reached through knowledge, devotion (*dhruvānusmṛti*) and self-surrender (*prapatti*), and given finally by grace. The soul reaches God; it never becomes God.

The honest evaluation. Each position pays a price. Advaita must explain how a superimposed individual undertakes a genuine discipline over a genuine period. Viśiṣṭādvaita must explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless *wholly* dependent on God without collapsing into the very non-duality it rejects.

Verdict. The idea of liberation without a real agent is coherent, but only within a metaphysics that also makes bondage unreal. Whether that price is acceptable is exactly what divides the two Vedāntas.

Marks rationale. The conceptual question answered directly, the comparison organised by that answer, the level-distinction used precisely, and both costs priced.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 2 min the question · 4 min Advaita · 4 min Viśiṣṭādvaita · 2 min costs · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Appending a generic comparison; saying the soul is annihilated in Advaita or deified in Viśiṣṭādvaita; leaving one side unpriced.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the nature of Soul and Bondage according to Jainism.

Demand decoding. Two nouns, both to be delivered: the soul's metaphysics *and* the bondage mechanism. The mechanism is the four-stage ladder, and omitting it halves the answer.

Model answer (≈250 words). The soul (jīva). Every living being is an eternal, conscious substance; consciousness is its defining and inseparable characteristic. It is uncreated and indestructible, and Jainism admits **no creator God**. Its intrinsic nature is the four infinitudes (*ananta-catuṣṭaya*): infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy. Distinctively, during bondage the soul is **co-extensive with the body it occupies**, expanding and contracting like light filling a room - a doctrine that follows from treating embodiment as a mode of the soul.

Bondage (bandha). Karma in Jainism is not merely an unseen potency but **fine matter** (*karma-pudgala*). The passions (*kaṣāya*) - anger, pride, deceit and greed - make the soul adhesive; karmic matter then flows in (*āsrava*) and binds, obscuring the four infinitudes. Bondage is analysed by **nature, duration, intensity and quantity** of the matter bound. The classical image is dust adhering to an **oily body**: the oil is passion, and without it the dust does not stick.

The reversal. Restraint, vows and carefulness stop the inflow (*saṃvara*); austerity (*tapas*) sheds accumulated karma (*nirjarā*); omniscience (*kevala-jñāna*) then manifests while the body still lives, and final disembodied perfection (*siddhahood*) follows.

Objection and reply. How can non-material consciousness interact with material karma? Jainism replies that extension and embodiment are **modes of the soul during bondage**, so the soul is not an unextended Cartesian thinker. The cost is that the soul becomes neither cleanly material nor cleanly spiritual.

Placement. Jain liberation therefore **perfects individuality** - neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without a self - and its *kevala* means omniscience, not Sāṃkhya's contentless isolation.

Marks rationale. Both nouns delivered; the quasi-materiality of karma stated as doctrine rather than metaphor; the four-stage ladder complete; the interaction objection met; and the comparative placement.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 4 min soul · 4 min bondage · 2 min reversal · 2 min objection · 1 min placement.

Penalties to avoid. Treating Jain karma as metaphor; omitting stoppage and shedding; confusing Jain *kevala* with Sāṃkhya *kaivalya*.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Critically examine Plato's apriori proofs for the immortality of the soul.

Demand decoding. "Critically examine... proofs" (plural) means **four separate assessments**, each with the objection that fits it - not one summary followed by one general complaint.

Model answer (≈300 words). Frame. In the *Phaedo* Plato argues from reason alone, and each argument must be asked what it separately establishes: pre-existence, indestructibility, or only likeness to the indestructible.

1. Opposites (cyclical). Opposites arise from opposites - larger from smaller, waking from sleeping - so the living arise from the dead and souls persist between deaths. *Assessment:* the pattern fits qualities admitting degree far better than existence and non-existence, and it yields a cosmic balance rather than the survival of *this* soul.

2. Recollection (anamnesis). We judge equal sticks *deficiently* equal, so we possess a standard sense-experience cannot supply; learning is recollection. *Assessment:* even if sound, it establishes **pre-existence only** - which is why Plato must pair it with the cyclical argument to close the post-mortem direction.

3. Affinity. The composite, visible and changing perishes; the non-composite, invisible and stable does not; the soul resembles the second. *Assessment:* Plato presents this as likeness, not proof; resemblance to the imperishable does not entail imperishability, and simplicity is assumed.

4. The Form of Life. What essentially brings a Form cannot admit its opposite: snow cannot admit heat, and soul, essentially bringing Life, cannot admit death. *Assessment:* the inference from "cannot admit death" to "cannot cease" needs a bridge - fire does not become cold, but fire goes out.

The internal objection. Simmias: the soul is an attunement (*harmonia*) of bodily elements and perishes with the instrument. Plato replies twice: an attunement cannot pre-exist its instrument, whereas recollection shows the soul did; and the soul **rules** the body, opposing appetite, which no attunement does.

The external critique. Kant's paralogism: the unity of apperception is a formal condition of thought, not knowledge of a persisting substance. Immortality survives only as a postulate of practical reason.

Verdict. Taken singly the arguments establish at most pre-existence and a resemblance to the indestructible; taken together they display a coherent picture whose weakest joint is the step from essential predication to indestructibility.

Marks rationale. Four separate assessments, the internal objection with Plato's twofold reply, a named external critic, and a graded verdict rather than a blanket rejection.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 10 min four arguments with assessments · 3 min Simmias and reply · 2 min Kant · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Summarising the four as one proof; omitting Simmias; treating Kant as denying the soul's existence.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Examine the significance of the concept of rebirth in the theory of Karma.

Demand decoding. A **function** question. Describing rebirth answers a different stem; the marks are in what rebirth does *for* karma theory.

Model answer (≈250 words). The problem rebirth solves. Karma claims that every morally weighted act matures into its result. But many acts plainly do not mature within a lifetime: the good suffer, the cruel prosper, and infants suffer before they can have acted. Three exits are available - abandon the exceptionless claim; concentrate settlement into one post-mortem judgement, which is the Semitic route; or **widen the field of maturation across many lives**. Rebirth is the third exit, and that is its significance.

What it thereby contributes. (i) It preserves an **exceptionless** moral law against the evidence, without appeal to a divine reason for each allocation. (ii) It explains **initial inequality**: the conditions of birth are consequences rather than impositions. (iii) It secures **beginninglessness** (*anādī*), so no "first fault" must be explained, as it must in a Fall narrative. (iv) It makes **liberation intelligible** by supplying something to be liberated *from*.

The mechanism, briefly. Latent dispositions (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*) persist; the gross body is discarded (*Gītā* 2.22); the subtle body or, in Buddhism, causal conditioning determines the next embodiment. *Gītā* 9.21 shows even heaven is within the series.

The costs. The regress explains each birth by an earlier one and never the series as a whole; there is no past-life memory; and the doctrine risks reading present suffering as evidence of past fault. **Replies:** beginninglessness is a positive doctrine, not an oversight; memory is not the criterion of continuity; explanation licenses no social blame.

Verdict. Rebirth is not an ornament on karma theory but its enabling condition - the widened temporal field without which the law would have to be abandoned or heavily qualified.

Marks rationale. The fit-problem stated first, three rival exits named, four contributions listed, mechanism kept subordinate, and costs answered without over-claiming.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 4 min fit-problem and exits · 4 min contributions · 2 min mechanism · 2 min costs · 1 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Narrating rebirth; omitting the Semitic alternative that shows why the Indian exit is a choice; claiming rebirth solves the problem of evil outright.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the concept of liberation (*Apavarga*) according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

Demand decoding. A **named term**. Fix it against the parity bench in the opening lines, then derive it from the school's own metaphysics. The single decisive detail is the absence of consciousness.

Model answer (≈150 words). The chain. Nyāya traces suffering back through birth, activity and defect to **false knowledge**. Because the chain is causal, cutting it at the root unwinds everything downstream: true knowledge of the categories and of the self removes false knowledge; without false knowledge there is no defect, without defect no binding activity, without activity no rebirth, and without rebirth no suffering.

The terminus. *Apavarga* is the **absolute cessation of pain** together with the qualities that sustain embodied experience. Because Nyāya treats consciousness as an **adventitious** quality - arising only when the self is conjoined with mind, senses and body - the released self exists **without consciousness, pleasure or bliss**.

Objection and reply. Such a state seems indistinguishable from insentience, and undesirable. The reply is that the school offers not a reward but the end of a defect: its value is negative and complete, since no experience of any kind can arise again.

Placement. It is therefore unlike Advaitic self-luminous release, Viśiṣṭādvaitic communion and Jain omniscient perfection.

Marks rationale. The causal chain reconstructed, the adventitious-consciousness doctrine named as the reason for the negative terminus, the objection met, and the comparative placement supplied.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 3 min chain · 3 min terminus · 2 min objection · 1 min placement.

Penalties to avoid. Calling *apavarga* blissful; omitting the adventitious-consciousness doctrine; blending the Nyāya chain with the Buddhist one.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is it necessary to adhere to the notions of immortality of soul and rebirth in order to have a robust conception of liberation? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Demand decoding. A **compound modal** question: two notions, one conception, and an explicit demand for reasons. The answer must define "robust" before deciding whether the notions are required.

Model answer (≈300 words). Fixing the terms. A conception of liberation is *robust* if it identifies (i) what bondage is, (ii) what is liberated, (iii) what the terminus is, and (iv) why the terminus is final. The question is whether (ii) requires an immortal soul and whether bondage requires rebirth.

The substantialist case for "yes". Advaita, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Nyāya and Jainism all answer affirmatively. Liberation presupposes bondage-across-lives, and something that is liberated. Nyāya's *apavarga* is the release of an eternal self-substance; Jain perfection is the manifestation of an eternal soul's infinitudes; Viśiṣṭādvaita's communion presupposes an eternal individual. Without a continuant, they argue, "liberation" has no subject and "bondage" no history.

The counter-case. Buddhism satisfies all four robustness conditions **without** an immortal soul: bondage is craving and ignorance; what is liberated is a conditioned stream, not an owner; the terminus is the extinguishing of craving (*nirvāṇa*); and finality is secured because the conditions for renewed becoming have ceased. Sāṃkhya presses from the other side: by *kārikās* 62-63 **no puruṣa is bound, released or transmigrating** - it is *prakṛti* who binds and releases herself - so even a school with an eternal consciousness denies that *it* is what undergoes liberation.

What each notion actually supplies. Rebirth supplies the *history* that makes bondage more than a present episode, and immortality supplies a *subject*. Buddhism replaces the subject with a stream while retaining the history; and no school dispenses with the history altogether.

Objection and reply. If nothing persists, is liberation anyone's? The Buddhist reply grounds ownership in causal descent; critics answer that descent is thinner than ownership. The pressure is real and should be conceded.

Verdict. Rebirth, or some equivalent account of bondage-history, is effectively necessary for robustness. Immortality of a **substantial** soul is not: what is necessary is a continuity-bearer, and whether that bearer is a substance remains the live dispute.

Marks rationale. "Robust" defined before use; the two notions separated and answered differently; two counter-cases rather than one; the objection conceded; and a two-part verdict.

Timing skeleton (20 minutes). 3 min plan · 3 min defining robustness · 5 min substantialist case · 5 min counter-cases · 2 min objection · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Giving one verdict for both notions; omitting the Sāṃkhya kārikās; leaving "robust" undefined.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Discuss the nature of embodied liberation (*jīvanmukti*) with reference to Advaita Vedānta.

Demand decoding. A **named doctrine within a named school**. The whole answer turns on why liberation can be present while a body continues - which requires the karma distinction.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. In Advaita, release (*mokṣa*) is the removal of ignorance (*avidyā*), not the production of a new state. Since ignorance is destroyed the moment liberating knowledge arises, the knower of Brahman is free **now**: *jīvanmukti* is liberation while embodied life continues.

Why the body remains. Knowledge destroys stored (*sañcita*) and future (*āgāmi*) karma, but **already-fructifying karma (prārabdha)** has begun to ripen and runs its course. The canonical image is the **potter's wheel**, which continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn. At its exhaustion the body falls, and this is *videhamukti*.

Objection and reply. If ignorance is destroyed, why does empirical activity continue? Advaita distinguishes destroyed bondage from residual embodied momentum, locating the residue in the body-mind complex rather than in the knower; critics regard this as reintroducing a trace of ignorance.

Significance. Liberation is thus a cognitive-existential transformation, not a post-mortem reward - freedom is present realisation, not a future place.

Marks rationale. The removal model stated as the ground of present freedom, the karma distinction delivered exactly, the objection met, and a significance line that converts doctrine into evaluation.

Timing skeleton (10 minutes). 1 min plan · 3 min the claim · 3 min the karma distinction · 2 min objection · 1 min significance.

Penalties to avoid. Saying knowledge destroys fructifying karma; treating *jīvanmukti* as partial liberation; omitting *videhamukti*.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2025 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question (exact ledger wording): Is the concept of immortality of soul a necessary condition for Rebirth? Discuss with reference to the Bhagavad Gītā.

Demand decoding. A modal question **plus** a named text. Verse fidelity is compulsory: generic Vedānta will not satisfy "with reference to the *Bhagavad Gītā*".

Model answer (≈250 words). The Gītā's own position. The text presupposes a deathless self and derives rebirth from it. *Gītā* 2.23 states that weapons do not cut it, fire does not burn it, water does not wet it and wind does not wither it. 2.22 gives the canonical image: as worn-out garments are discarded for new ones, so the embodied self lays aside worn-out bodies and enters others. 9.21 completes the picture by showing that even heaven is a stage *inside* the wandering-on, since the meritorious return when merit is exhausted. On the *Gītā*'s own terms, therefore, immortality is not merely compatible with rebirth: it is the premise from which rebirth follows.

But is it necessary? A premise sufficient for a conclusion need not be necessary for it. Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anātman*): impermanence of all conditioned factors, non-selfhood of the aggregates, and conditioning by craving and karmic formations together yield continuity **without an owner** - flame lit from flame, milk becoming curd, neither the same nor wholly other. Sāṃkhya adds a second pressure from within the substantialist camp: by kārikās 62-63 it is *prakṛti*, not *puruṣa*, who binds, transmigrates and releases herself.

Objection and reply. Without a persisting self, who receives the fruit? Responsibility rests on causal descent rather than substantial identity - a reply that preserves the doctrine while leaving the ownership worry live.

Verdict. Within the *Gītā*'s metaphysics, immortality is the ground of rebirth. Across the traditions it is **sufficient but not necessary**: what rebirth requires is a continuity-bearer, and the *Gītā* simply takes that bearer to be a deathless self.

Marks rationale. Text-fidelity discharged with three verses used for three distinct purposes, then the modal question answered across traditions, with a second counter-pressure and a conclusion that respects both demands.

Timing skeleton (15 minutes). 2 min plan · 5 min *Gītā* verses · 4 min Buddhist counter-case · 2 min Sāṃkhya pressure · 2 min verdict.

Penalties to avoid. Answering without *Gītā* verses; quoting invented English translations; giving the Buddhist case without first honouring the named text.

Original Mains practice with model solutions - six questions

These are original UPSC-style questions written against this owner. Word bands: **10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 300 words.**

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between rebirth and reincarnation, and explain why the distinction matters for a comparative account of Indian soteriology.

Model answer (≈150 words). The distinction. *Reincarnation* - literally re-enfleshing - presupposes a **substantial soul** that re-enters a new body. *Rebirth* is the wider and more neutral term for renewed becoming within a beginningless series, and it commits the user to a *continuity-bearer* without specifying that the bearer is a substance.

Why it matters. (i) It fixes school-attribution: reincarnation is apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism, and **incorrect for Buddhism**, whose re-becoming (*punarbhava*) has no transmigrating self. (ii) It prevents a false consensus: writing "all Indian schools accept reincarnation" silently imports a substance-metaphysics into a school that denies it. (iii) It shapes the modal verdict on necessity questions, since the counter-example only exists once the wider term is available. (iv) Sanskrit registers the range - *punarjanma*, *punarāvṛtti*, *punarbhava*, *saṃsāra* - so the distinction is lexical as well as doctrinal.

Conclusion. The distinction is not terminological fastidiousness: it is what keeps a comparative account from begging the central metaphysical question.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks

Question: "Liberation is a family-resemblance term, not the name of a single state." Examine this claim with reference to at least four Indian schools.

Model answer (≈150 words). The claim. One English word covers destinations that differ in what ends, what remains and whether consciousness is present.

Four schools. *Advaita*: ignorance ends, Brahman alone remains, and awareness is self-luminous - liberation as **identity**. *Viśiṣṭādvaita*: karmic bondage ends, the eternal individual soul remains in communion with God - liberation as **communion**, never absorption. *Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika*: pain and the qualities sustaining experience end, the self-substance remains **without consciousness** - liberation as **cessation**. *Sāṃkhya-Yoga*: non-discrimination ends, *puruṣa* stands alone, conscious but contentless - liberation as **isolation**. Add Jainism, where karmic matter ends and a **perfected omniscient individual** remains, and Buddhism, where craving ends and no self is asserted at all.

Assessment. These are not degrees of one state; identity and communion are mutually exclusive, and cessation excludes the very awareness that identity requires.

Conclusion. The shared vocabulary conceals incompatible destinations, and the first task in any liberation answer is to say which one is meant.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that personal identity, rather than immortality, is the real philosophical issue in the survival debate. Illustrate with both Western and Indian material.

Model answer (≈250 words). The claim. Whether something survives is less contested than *what would make the survivor me*. Immortality answers a question about duration; identity answers a question about sameness, and the second is prior.

The criteria. Four rivals: bodily continuity, psychological or memory continuity, soul-substance, and causal continuity. The first two tell us how identity is recognised; the last two propose what constitutes it. Memory cannot define identity, since it presupposes it and is fallible and branchable.

Western illustration. Resurrection faces the **gap problem** and the **re-assembly objection**. Aquinas secures continuity by treating the rational soul as the *form* of the body; van Inwagen has God preserve the body or a core of it; Hick's **replica theory** holds that a unique psychophysical duplicate with continuous memory and character, appearing in another space, is the same person for every purpose that matters. The **duplication objection** answers that if God can make one replica he can make two, and identity is one-to-one - so the criterion tracks similarity.

Indian illustration. Vedānta and Nyāya answer with a substance; Jainism with an eternal individual soul; Sāṃkhya distinctively denies that the witness migrates at all (*Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63); and Buddhism replaces the owner with a causal stream, defending responsibility by **causal descent** - "neither the same nor wholly other". The **memory objection** to rebirth is the mirror-image of the duplication objection to resurrection.

Assessment. Both traditions can secure duration and struggle to secure sameness, which is precisely the claim under examination.

Conclusion. Immortality is the headline; identity is the argument - and every serious position in this clause is finally a choice of continuity-bearer.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks

Question: "Karma explains the distribution of suffering, but the explanation carries a moral cost." Discuss with reference to the theistic and non-theistic schools.

Model answer (≈250 words). The explanatory claim. Karma answers a question theism finds hard: not why suffering exists, but why *this* person suffers. Act and its unseen potency (*adṛṣṭa/apūrva*) mature as stored, fructifying and future karma within a beginningless series, so present condition is consequence rather than allocation.

The two administrations. In Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā the law is **self-regulating**: no judge is required, and the moral order is a basic feature of how things work. In Nyāya and the theistic Vedāntas God is the **superintendent** (*karmādhyaṅkṣa*) who ratifies and dispenses desert rather than authoring it. The fork matters: the first purchases economy at the price of a law without a legislator; the second retains a personal God at the price of subordinating him to a law he did not make.

The moral cost. Because present suffering is read as the maturation of past action, the doctrine can be turned into an inference from suffering to fault. That inference is (i) epistemically unwarranted, since no one has access to the ledger, and (ii) practically corrosive, since it converts a metaphysical explanation into a social verdict.

The replies. The traditions themselves block the inference: explanatory karma does not license social judgement, and the duty of compassion and relief is untouched by any account of desert. Beginninglessness also removes the "original fault" framing that most easily supports blame.

Assessment. The explanatory gain is real and distinctive; the cost is not intrinsic to the doctrine but is easily produced by careless use.

Conclusion. Karma should be presented as an account of *why the world is orderly*, never as an instrument for reading a sufferer's past.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks

Question: Critically compare the Semitic doctrine of resurrection with the Indian doctrine of rebirth, and assess whether either succeeds in securing the identity of the person who survives.

Model answer (≈300 words). Frame. These are not variants of one idea. They differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos, identity-bearer, treatment of the body and direction of time. Cullmann (1955) argues that Greek immortality of the soul and Hebrew resurrection of the dead are **opposed** rather than complementary - the first releases the soul from the body, the second treats the person as a psychosomatic unity that only a divine act can restore.

The grid. Resurrection: one earthly life; a divine act at the end of history; God as judge; restored embodied life in communion; the body essential, a "spiritual body" still a body; linear time. Rebirth: a beginningless series; karma maturing through the wandering-on; the karmic law itself, with God ratifying in Nyāya and Rāmānuja; **exit** from the series as telos; the body discarded like clothing (*Gītā* 2.22) while the subtle body carries dispositions; cyclical time with a linear exit.

Identity under resurrection. Two problems: the **gap** between death and raising, and the **re-assembly** objection where matter is shared between bodies. Three replies: Aquinas (the rational soul as form secures continuity); van Inwagen (God preserves the body or a core, leaving a simulacrum); Hick (a unique psychophysical replica with memory and character *is* the person). The **duplication objection** is decisive against the third as stated: if one replica, why not two?

Identity under rebirth. The **memory objection**: nothing of prior lives is recalled. The reply distinguishes episodic memory from metaphysical continuity and appeals to latent dispositions - coherent, but evidentially empty. Buddhism avoids the problem by abandoning strict identity for causal descent, at the cost of the ownership worry.

Assessment. Neither secures identity, but for opposite reasons: resurrection must show that a re-constituted person is numerically the same; rebirth must show that a being with no memory of me is me.

Conclusion. They answer different questions - how an essentially embodied person can survive, and how moral desert can be discharged when one life is too short - and both leave the identity question open.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks

Question: "Every Indian conception of liberation is determined by its account of bondage." Examine this thesis across the major schools, and state what follows for the means of liberation.

Model answer (≈300 words). Thesis. The terminus is fixed by the diagnosis. Tell me what a school takes bondage to be, and its conception of release - and its permitted means - follow.

School by school. *Advaita*: bondage is **ignorance** (*avidyā*), so release is the removal of an error; individuality is sublated, and only **knowledge** can remove it; liberation while living (*jīvanmukti*) is possible because nothing must be acquired, the body continuing on already-fructifying karma. *Viśiṣṭādvaita*: bondage is **karma and dependence**, so release is an attained relation - communion and service - reached by knowledge, devotion (*dhruvānusrīti*) and self-surrender (*prapatti*), with grace decisive. *Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika*: bondage is the conjunction that generates pain, traced back to **false knowledge**, so release is the cessation of pain *and* of the qualities sustaining experience, reached by true knowledge of the categories. *Sāṃkhya-Yoga*: bondage is **non-discrimination** (*aviveka*), not a real bond, so release is discriminative discernment (*viveka-khyāti*) and the terminus is contentless aloneness; *kārikās* 62-63 add that strictly no *puruṣa* was ever bound. *Jainism*: bondage is **quasi-material karmic matter** attracted by passion, so release requires stoppage (*saṃvara*) and shedding (*nirjarā*) - an ethics of restraint and austerity rather than of knowledge alone. *Buddhism*: bondage is **craving and ignorance**, so release is their extinguishing, reached by the path, with no self to be freed.

What follows for the means. The **production versus removal** fork governs everything: if release is a result to be produced, action can produce it (*Mīmāṃsā*); if it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it (*Śaṅkara*); if it is an attained relation, devotion and grace are intelligible as direct means (*Rāmānuja*). Action qualifies, devotion receives, knowledge removes.

Qualification. The thesis is strong but not absolute: Jainism's material diagnosis makes practice, not cognition, the primary means, showing that the diagnosis fixes the *kind* of means as much as the terminus.

Conclusion. Conceptions of liberation are not free-standing ideals; they are the exact inverse of each school's account of what has gone wrong.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Status. Everything below is **enrichment**. The Basic sessions already contain every doctrine, distinction, objection and verdict required by the seventeen owner PYQs and by a complete core answer. Nothing here repairs a missing core point, and no answer needs this block to reach the top band. **FACT:** The dossier's own core prerequisite - complete Plato, Hindu, Buddhist, Jain, Nyāya, Advaita, Viśiṣṭādvaita, embodied liberation, cessation, karma-rebirth continuity, and all owner distinctions between immortality, rebirth and liberation - is taught in Sessions 1-16 above.

ADVANCED MODULE A1 - Substance-self, psychological continuity and causal continuity as three rival theories

ANALYSIS: The three positions, stated as competitors rather than as school labels.

Theory	Persistence condition	Handles responsibility by	Characteristic difficulty
Substance-self	one and the same enduring subject exists at both times	identity of the bearer	individuation of substances; unobservability
Psychological continuity	overlapping chains of memory, character and intention	continuity of the psychological profile	branching, duplication and the circularity of memory
Buddhist causal continuity	the later state is causally descended from the earlier through karmic conditioning	causal descent, without identity	whether descent can make the fruit genuinely <i>one's own</i>

The advanced objection. Without identity, responsibility appears to collapse: the later being is punished or rewarded for what a numerically different being did.

The advanced reply. Buddhists argue that causal descent is sufficient for responsibility even where strict sameness fails, and that ordinary practice already relies on this - the adult answers for the youth despite near-total psychological and material replacement. **ANALYSIS: Where to use it:** as an evaluative line inside a "is immortality necessary for rebirth?" answer, in **one or two sentences**, after the core verdict has been stated.

ADVANCED MODULE A2 - The memory objection, pressed and answered at full strength

ANALYSIS: The strengthened objection. It is not merely that we happen not to remember previous lives. It is that what cannot in principle be remembered can scarcely count as *my* survival: survival is supposed to matter to me prospectively, and a future being with no experiential access to my life gives me no more prospect than a stranger does.

The strengthened reply. (i) Memory is unreliable even within one life, and large tracts of childhood are unrecoverable without our doubting identity across them. (ii) What the schools claim to persist is **dispositional** rather than episodic - latent tendencies (*saṃskāra/vāsanā*) shaping temperament and inclination. (iii) The prospective concern may itself be an artefact of psychological continuity, and the metaphysical question of *who exists* need not track it.

CAUTION: The unresolved residue. The reply preserves the coherence of rebirth without supplying positive evidence for it. **ANALYSIS: Discipline:** one careful sentence is enough in an answer; do not turn a philosophy script into paranormal reportage, and do not cite case literature as evidence.

ADVANCED MODULE A3 - Positive perfection versus mere cessation as competing ideals of liberation

ANALYSIS: **The debate.** Advaita and Jainism portray a **fulfilment-rich** liberation: self-luminous non-dual awareness in the first, the four infinitudes in the second. Nyāya stresses **cessation** of pain and of the conditions of experience. Buddhism resists **both** crude annihilation and hedonistic fulfilment models, refusing the substantialist form of the question.

The objection. A cessation-only liberation seems unattractive or empty - a terminus no one could rationally desire.

The reply. Nyāya values final freedom *from suffering* rather than experiential luxury, and its metaphysics (consciousness as adventitious) forbids promising more. Sāṃkhya makes the same refusal explicit: aloneness is not bliss, it is the ending of threefold suffering. ANALYSIS: **The evaluative point worth making:** a school that promises less may be more honest, and "attractiveness" is not a criterion of philosophical adequacy.

ANALYSIS: **Use:** excellent for comparing Indian schools without flattening them into "liberation equals bliss".

ADVANCED MODULE A4 - Embodied liberation and the fructifying-karma problem, pressed further

ANALYSIS: **The sharpened objection.** If liberating knowledge destroys ignorance *completely*, then the liberated knower has no ignorance at all. But embodied experience - appearing as an individual with a body, a location and a history - looks like precisely what ignorance produced. So either ignorance is not completely destroyed, or embodied experience does not require ignorance.

The Advaita answer. The distinction is between **bondage** and **momentum**: what is destroyed is the stored and future karma that would generate further embodiments, while the already-fructifying portion continues, and the residue is located in the **body-mind complex** rather than in the knower. The traditional image is the potter's wheel still turning after the hand withdraws.

The critic's rejoinder. This appears to reintroduce a trace - some residual appearance-generating condition - under a different name.

The cross-school control. ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya faces the same phenomenon and gives a **different** explanation: kārikā 67 attributes the continuing body to the momentum of the constituents (*guṇa*), not to karma, and kārikā 68 gives disembodied aloneness at the body's fall. The shared image conceals two different metaphysics, and noticing this is the advanced move.

ANALYSIS: **Use:** strong in Advaita 10- and 15-markers, but keep it brief and subordinate to the core exposition of *jīvanmukti*.

ADVANCED MODULE A5 - The individuation problem for plural pure consciousnesses

ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya asserts a **plurality** of *puruṣas*, each attributeless, inactive and contentless. **The objection:** if they share every intrinsic property and none has any qualitative content, nothing distinguishes them, and the pluralism collapses into a monism of consciousness - precisely Advaita's position.

The Sāṃkhya reply. Difference is established by the observed difference of birth, death, activity and experience across individuals: if there were one consciousness, the liberation of one would be the liberation of all.

The Advaitin rejoinder. Those differences belong to *prakṛti*, not to *puruṣa*, so the argument appeals to exactly the features Sāṃkhya has declared irrelevant to consciousness - which is question-begging.

CAUTION: The dispute is genuinely unresolved and should be presented as such. ANALYSIS: **Use:** one sentence in a 20-marker comparing Sāṃkhya with Advaita; never as a core exposition.

ADVANCED MODULE A6 - Grace and effort as a structural problem, beyond the Śrīvaiṣṇava illustration

ANALYSIS: The cat and monkey illustrations state a problem they do not solve. Pressed further:

1. **If grace is unconditioned**, then effort is not merely unnecessary but irrelevant, and the tradition's extensive prescriptions become inexplicable.
2. **If grace responds to effort**, then it is earned, and the incapacity argument - that a beginninglessly bound soul cannot lift itself - is abandoned.
3. **The mediating positions** treat effort not as a cause of grace but as the **removal of an obstacle to its reception**, or as itself already grace-enabled.

ANALYSIS: **The comparative note**: the same structure appears wherever a soteriology combines an incapacity diagnosis with a prescribed discipline, and stating it structurally rather than confessionally is what keeps the answer philosophical.

ADVANCED MODULE A7 - What must not be over-studied

WRONG: The dossier's own restriction is explicit: **do not get lost in modern thought experiments about teleportation, brain splits or fringe reincarnation case literature**. They are absent from the seventeen owner questions, and importing them displaces material that is actually examined.

ANALYSIS: **Promotion trigger**. Should UPSC directly ask about memory and identity criteria, or should Nyāya and Buddhist continuity require stronger core clarification, Modules A1 and A2 would be promoted into the Basic sessions. Until then they remain enrichment.

ADVANCED MODULE A8 - Credible source trail for this block

FACT: Plato, *Phaedo*; FACT: *Bhagavad Gītā* ch. 2; FACT: Buddhist sources on dependent origination and no-self; FACT: Jain discussions of the soul (*jīva*), stoppage (*saṃvara*) and shedding (*nirjarā*); FACT: Śaṅkara on liberation while living; FACT: standard Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika discussions of *apavarga*. CAUTION: No page, edition or invented quotation is attached to any of them.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision notes for the complete topic. Topic-specific headings, not a template. Every subtopic taught above appears here in recall form; the Basic and Optional-Advanced distinction is preserved.

R1. The six survival terms - the bench that must be fixed first

Term	Claim	Owner	Fatal merge
Immortality	a subject is deathless	Plato, Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism	with resurrection
Survival	something continues after death	the weaker neutral claim	with immortality
Rebirth (<i>punarjanma/punarbhava</i>)	karmically renewed becoming in a series	the wider term; the only one correct for Buddhism	with reincarnation
Reincarnation	a substantial soul re-enters flesh	Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism	applied to Buddhism
Resurrection	God re-constitutes the embodied person, one life	Judaism, Christianity, Islam	called "rebirth in heaven"
Liberation	exit from the series; seven destinations	every Indian school	treated as one state

R2. Person-models and identity criteria

- Five models: substance dualism · hylomorphism · bundle/no-self · embodied person · Indian substantial self.
- Four criteria: bodily · psychological/memory · soul-substance · causal.
- Bodily and psychological answer *how we tell*; substance and causal answer *what makes it so*.
- Memory presupposes identity; it cannot define it.
- Hick's replica defends the **coherence** of resurrection identity; the duplication objection shows similarity is not numerical identity.
- The organising question throughout: **what is the continuity-bearer?**

R3. Plato's four arguments - and their two critics

#	Argument	Yield	Fitted objection
1	Opposites (cyclical)	souls persist through the transition	opposites-in-degree ≠ being/non-being; gives a cosmic balance
2	Recollection (<i>anamnesis</i>)	pre-existence only	needs a further step to reach survival
3	Affinity	likeness to the invisible and stable	resemblance ≠ identity; simplicity assumed
4	Form of Life	soul cannot admit death	"cannot admit death" ≠ "cannot cease"; fire goes out

- **Simmiias**: soul as attunement (*harmonia*) of the body. **Plato's twofold reply**: an attunement cannot pre-exist its instrument (recollection); and the soul **rules** the body, which no attunement does.
- **Kant**: paralogism - the unity of apperception is a formal condition of thought, not knowledge of a substance. Immortality returns as a **postulate of practical reason**.

R4. The five argument families, and the burden-shift

- Simplicity · identity/continuity · moral order · desire/fulfilment · religious experience.
- Each fails in its own way: unproved simplicity · continuity accounts suffice · hope not demonstration · longing ≠ existence · interpretation and diversity.
- **Body/brain dependence** shifts the burden; the survivalist owes accounts of **interaction, individuation and identity**.
- Achievable claim-levels: coherence, presupposition, postulate. **Not** demonstration.

R5. Hindu immortality - verse spine and school split

- **2.22** garments (rebirth) · **2.23** indestructibility · **9.21** return when merit is exhausted (heaven is inside *saṃsāra*) · **5.4-5** convergence · **18.66** surrender.
- Subtle body (*sūkṣma-śarīra*) is the **vehicle**, never the continuant.
- Supports: continuity of the knower · moral bookkeeping · scriptural testimony (*śabda*) · beginninglessness (*anādi*).
- Four accounts of what is deathless: Advaita (non-dual awareness) · Viśiṣṭādvaita (eternal individual, mode of God) · Nyāya (substance, consciousness adventitious) · Sāṃkhya (plural contentless witness).

R6. Karma - mechanism, ledger, administration, costs

- Act **plus** unseen potency: *adr̥ṣṭa* (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika) / *apūrva* (Mīmāṃsā).
- **Sañcita** (stored, destroyed by knowledge) · **prārabdha** (fructifying, runs its course) · **āgāmi** (future, where effort acts).
- Effort (*puṛuṣakāra*) within destiny (*daiva*); desireless action (*niṣkāma-karma*) uses the law.
- **Administration fork**: self-regulating (Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā) versus superintendent God (*karmādhyakṣa*: Nyāya, theistic Vedāntas) who **ratifies**, never authors, desert.
- **Postulate test**: remove karma and distribution, rebirth, liberation and ritual efficacy all fail.
- **Costs**: unverifiability · victim-blaming risk · the God-and-law problem. **Replies**: shared unverifiability · no licence for social judgement · God as administrator.

R7. Rebirth - the fit-problem and its three exits

- Claim: exceptionless maturation. Fact: many acts do not mature in one life.
- Exits: (a) abandon the claim · (b) one judgement - **the Semitic route** · (c) **widen the field** - rebirth.
- Contributions: exceptionless law preserved · initial inequality explained · beginninglessness secured · liberation given content.
- Costs: regress explains each birth, never the series · no memory · moral hazard.

R8. Buddhist continuity - the counter-example

- Four steps: impermanence -> no aggregate is self -> craving and formations condition -> continuity without an owner.
- Denied: permanent independent self. **Not** denied: conventional person, moral consequence, rebirth.
- **Neither the same nor wholly other**; responsibility on causal descent.
- Flame-to-flame, milk-to-curd: **illustrations, never proofs**.
- **Verdict**: immortality is **sufficient, not necessary**, for rebirth.

R9. The liberation parity bench - seven destinations

Term	School	Ends	Remains	Consciousness
<i>Mokṣa</i>	Advaita	ignorance	Brahman alone	FACT: self-luminous, non-dual
<i>Mokṣa</i>	Viśiṣṭādvaita	karmic bondage	eternal soul with God	FACT: personal, in communion
<i>Apavarga</i>	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	pain and its conditions	the self-substance	WRONG: none, and no bliss
<i>Kaivalya</i>	Sāṃkhya-Yoga	non-discrimination	<i>puruṣa</i> , isolated	FACT: pure, contentless
Liberation / siddhahood	Jainism	karmic matter	perfected omniscient soul	FACT: four infinitudes
<i>Nirvāṇa</i>	Buddhism	craving, ignorance, suffering	CAUTION: not stated as a self	ANALYSIS: neither survival- nor annihilation-language
Resurrection	Semitic	death	the embodied person	FACT: embodied, before God

R10. Vedānta - the fork and its consequences

- **Advaita**: bondage = ignorance -> removal model -> **knowledge alone** -> individuality **sublated** -> *jīvanmukti* now, *videhamukti* at the body's fall, body sustained by *prārabdha* (potter's wheel).
- Preparation: purity of mind (*citta-śuddhi*), fourfold qualification (*sādhana-catustaya*), then hearing-reflecting-meditating. Śaṅkara **rejects** *jñāna-karma-samuccaya*.
- **Viśiṣṭādvaita**: bondage = karma and dependence -> attainment model -> knowledge, devotion (*dhruvānusmṛti*), self-surrender (*prapatti*), grace -> individuality **preserved**; the soul reaches God, never becomes God.
- **Real-agent question**: Advaita says liberation without a real agent is possible and necessary; Viśiṣṭādvaita says an unreal agent cannot strive or be rewarded. Both pay a price.

R11. Jain soul and bondage ladder

- Soul (*jīva*): eternal, conscious, no creator, four infinitudes (*ananta-catustaya*), **co-extensive with its body** during bondage.
- Karma is **quasi-material** (*karma-pudgala*), analysed by nature, duration, intensity, quantity.
- Ladder: passions (*kaṣāya*) -> inflow (*āsrava*) -> bondage (*bandha*) -> stoppage (*saṃvara*) -> shedding (*nirjarā*) -> omniscience (*kevala-jñāna*) -> siddhahood.
- Image: dust on an **oily** body - the oil is passion.
- Interaction objection answered by treating extension as a **mode** of the soul; cost: a substance neither cleanly material nor cleanly spiritual.

R12. Nyāya cessation and Sāṃkhya-Yoga isolation

- **Nyāya chain:** false knowledge -> defect -> activity -> birth -> suffering; true knowledge unwinds it. *Apavarga* = pain **and** the qualities of experience end; consciousness **adventitious**, hence absent.
- **Sāṃkhya:** *puruṣa* (plural, inactive, contentless witness) versus *prakṛti* (one, unconscious, active, three constituents). Bondage = non-discrimination (*aviveka*).
- **SK 1** threefold suffering (*ādhyātmika*, *ādhibhautika*, *ādhidaivika*) · **SK 62-63** no *puruṣa* is bound, released or transmigrating · **SK 67** potter's wheel · **SK 68** *videha-kaivalya*.
- **Yoga:** YS 1.2 *citta-vṛtti-nirodha* · 1.3 the seer abides in its own nature · 2.3 five afflictions · **1.24 Īśvara a special puruṣa, not a creator** · 4.29 cloud-of-dharma absorption · 4.34 aloneness as counter-flow (*pratiprasava*) / *citi-śakti*.
- Objections: individuation of plural *puruṣas* · why *prakṛti* acts · desirability of a contentless terminus.
- **Trap:** *kevala* = omniscience (Jainism) ≠ *kaivalya* = isolation (Sāṃkhya).

R13. Paths - devotion and the three means

- Texts: *Gītā* 18.66, 9.22, 9.32; *Bhāgavata* 7.5.23 (nine limbs in order: hearing, praising, remembering, service at the feet, worship, salutation, servitude, friendship, self-offering); *Nārada* and *Śaṅḍilya Bhakti Sūtras*.
- Typology: *parā/aparā* · *vaidhī/rāgānugā* · with-form/formless · five moods (*śānta*, *dāsyā*, *sakhya*, *vātsalya*, *mādhurya*).
- Rāmānuja (*dhruvānusmṛti* + *prapatti*, grace) · **cat/monkey** grace-effort split · Madhva (*jñāna-pūrvaka-sneha*, *prasāda*, *taratamya*) · Vallabha (*puṣṭi-mārga*) · Caitanya (*prema* as fifth end) · Advaita (preparatory only). CAUTION: *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* ascription disputed.
- Three-means apparatus: direct (*sākṣāt-sādhana*) vs auxiliary (*ārād-upakāra*) · means vs qualification (*adhikāra*) · **production vs removal**.
- Positions: Mīmāṃsā (action alone) · Śaṃkara (knowledge alone; rejects combination) · Rāmānuja (graded culmination in devotion) · Madhva (knowledge-grounded devotion).
- *Gītā* **5.4-5** licenses convergence in **function**, not terminus; Śaṃkara, Rāmānuja and Tilak each claim the text; Vivekananda's four yogas are temperament-matched.
- **Formula:** action qualifies · devotion receives · knowledge removes.

R14. Resurrection versus rebirth - grid and identity failures

Axis	Resurrection	Rebirth
Lives	one	beginningless series
Mechanism	divine act at history's end	karma maturing in <i>saṃsāra</i>
Judge	God, final judgement	the law itself; God ratifies in Nyāya/Rāmānuja
Telos	restored embodied communion	exit - <i>mokṣa/nirvāṇa/kaivalya/apavarga</i>
Bearer	person re-constituted by God	self or soul; in Buddhism a causal stream
Body	essential; a spiritual body is still a body	discarded (<i>Gītā</i> 2.22); subtle body carries dispositions
Time	linear, eschatological	cyclical with a linear exit
Moral function	accountability before a person	self-regulating desert

- Resurrection identity: **gap problem** · **re-assembly ("cannibal") objection** · replies from **Aquinas** (soul as form), **van Inwagen** (body preserved, simulacrum), **Hick** (unique replica) · **duplication objection**.
- Rebirth identity: **memory objection** · reply from dispositional continuity · CAUTION: no positive evidence.
- **Cullmann (1955):** Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are **opposed**.

R15. Anti-theistic rebirth - three detachments

- Karma without a judge · rebirth without a soul · liberation without grace.
- ANALYSIS: *Nāstika* = **Veda-rejecting**, not atheist.
- Jainism removes the God, keeps the soul; Buddhism removes the soul, keeps rebirth; together the whole structure is shown separable.
- Counter-pressures: law without a legislator · ownership of the fruit · attainability without grace.
- **Limit**: detachability, never a disproof of theism.

R16. Answer architecture - decoder, ladder, bands

- **Directives**: necessity stems -> modal verdict · named-text stems -> that text's verses · "critically examine proofs" -> separate assessments · two-verb stems -> two obligations · "evaluate as a pathway" -> criterion first · "state and explain A, B and C" -> three definitions then relations · "essential postulate" -> removal test · "how far plausible" -> graded verdict.
- **Ladder**: merged schools ≈40% · school-wise definitions ≈50% · continuity-bearer named ≈60% · modal verdict plus parity bench ≈65-70% · discriminating distinction plus falsification statement ≈70%+.
- **Bands**: 10 ≈150 words · 15 ≈250 words · 20 ≈300 words.
- **Paragraph pattern**: claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification.
- **Quotation discipline**: *Gītā* 2.22/2.23/9.21/5.4-5/18.66 · *Bhāgavata* 7.5.23 · SK 1/62-63/67-68 · YS 1.2/1.3/1.24/2.3/4.29/4.34 · Cullmann 1955 · Hick's replica · CAUTION: *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* ascription disputed · flame and milk-to-curd as illustration only.

R17. The fourteen standing traps, one line each

1. Do not equate immortality, resurrection and rebirth.
2. Do not say Buddhism denies continuity; it denies a permanent substance-self.
3. Do not describe Nyāya *apavarga* as positive bliss.
4. Do not make all Indian liberation doctrines a merger with God.
5. Do not use the flame analogy as proof; it illustrates a causal-continuity model.
6. In embodied liberation, distinguish knowledge destroying ignorance from *prārabdha* sustaining the body.
7. Do not treat devotion as mere emotion; its content is the shift from achievement to reception.
8. Do not say "Advaita rejects bhakti"; Advaita makes it **preparatory**.
9. Do not answer the three-means question with "all three are equal"; name the disagreement.
10. Do not conflate rebirth with reincarnation.
11. Do not present resurrection as rebirth in heaven.
12. Do not treat *kaivalya* as a synonym for *mokṣa*, or Jain *kevala* as Sāṃkhya *kaivalya*.
13. Do not call Yoga's Īśvara a creator (YS 1.24).
14. Do not say Sāṃkhya's *puruṣa* is bound and released (SK 62-63).

R18. Answer spine - objection to reply, in one screen

Objection	Reply	Residue to concede
No past-life memory	memory is neither necessary nor sufficient for continuity; dispositions persist	no positive evidence
Duplication / branching	substance theories invoke one bearer; Buddhism accepts continuity without numerical identity	identity talk is strained either way
Moral desert and victim-blaming	karma explains without licensing social judgement; compassion remains obligatory	the misuse is easy and must be blocked explicitly

Objection	Reply	Residue to concede
Who seeks liberation if there is no individual or no self?	conventional agency operates until insight removes the misconception	Advaita must explain a real discipline for a superimposed agent
Body/brain dependence	dependence in embodiment does not entail impossibility afterwards	the burden has shifted to the survivalist
Ownership of karmic fruit without a self	causal descent grounds responsibility	descent may be thinner than ownership

R19. Seventeen-part PYQ routing, 2018-2025

Year	Part	Marks	Demand	Register anchor
2018	Q5(b)	10	anti-theistic rebirth, plausibility of its significance	R15
2018	Q7(c)	15	evaluate devotion as a pathway	R13
2019	Q8(a)	20	karma, rebirth and reincarnation stated and explained	R6, R7, R14
2020	Q5(b)	10	immortality as a basic presupposition of religion	R4, R5
2020	Q8(c)	15	knowledge, action and devotion as means	R13
2021	Q6(a)	20	immortality of soul, Hindu tradition	R5
2021	Q6(b)	15	Advaita liberation and the role of knowledge	R10
2021	Q8(b)	15	karma as an essential postulate	R6
2022	Q5(c)	10	necessity of immortality for rebirth, w.r.t. Buddhism	R8
2022	Q7(b)	15	liberation without a real agent; Advaita vs Viśiṣṭādvaita	R10
2022	Q8(b)	15	Jain soul and bondage	R11
2023	Q6(a)	20	Plato's <i>a priori</i> proofs, critically examined	R3
2023	Q7(b)	15	significance of rebirth in karma theory	R7
2024	Q5(c)	10	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika <i>apavarga</i>	R12
2024	Q6(a)	20	are immortality and rebirth necessary for robust liberation	R8, R9
2025	Q5(d)	10	embodied liberation in Advaita	R10
2025	Q7(c)	15	necessity of immortality for rebirth, w.r.t. the <i>Gītā</i>	R5, R8

R20. Keyword and safe-formulation bank

Keywords: immortality · pre-existence · recollection · affinity · Form of Life · *harmonia* · paralogism · resurrection · psychosomatic unity · replica theory · gap problem · re-assembly objection · *ātman* · *jīva* · subtle body (*sūkṣmalliṅga-śarīra*) · karma · *adṛṣṭa/apūrva* · *sañcīta/prārabdha/āgāmi* · *puruṣakāra/daiva* · *karmādhyaṁśa* · *saṁsāra* · *punarjanma* · *punarbhava* · *punarāvṛtti* · reincarnation vs rebirth · *anātman/anattā* · *skandha* · *santāna* · causal descent · *pratītyasamutpāda* · *saṁskāra/vāsanā* · *apavarga* · *mokṣa* · *nirvāṇa* · *kaivalya* · *kevala-jñāna* · *ananta-catustaya* · *jīvanmukti* · *videhamukti* · *videha-kaivalya* · *prārabdha* · *āsrava* · *bandha* · *saṁvara* · *nirjarā* · *kaṣāya* · *karma-pudgala* · *bhakti* · *navadhā bhakti* · *vaidhīrāgānugā* · *saguṇa/nirguṇa* devotion · *prapatti/śaraṇāgati* · *mārjāra/markaṭa-nyāya* · *puṣṭi-mārga* · *prema-bhakti* · *citta-śuddhi* · *upāsana* · *sādhana-catustaya* · *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana* · *jñāna-karma-samuccaya* · *sākṣāt-sādhana/ārād-upakāra* · *adhikāra* · *niṣkāma-karma* · *aviveka* · *viveka-khyāti* · *satkāryavāda* · threefold *duḥkha* · *citta-vṛtti-nirodha* · *kleśa* · *aṣṭāṅga* · *dharma-megha-samādhi* · *pratiprasava* · *citi-śakti* · *Īśvara-praṇidhāna* · *prakāra* · *pāramāthika/vyāvahārika*.

Safe formulations:

- ANALYSIS: "Rebirth requires an account of continuity, not necessarily an immortal substance."
- ANALYSIS: "Liberation is a family-resemblance term: cessation, isolation, identity-realisation and perfected individuality must not be conflated."

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/32: Six survival terms that are not synonyms

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/32: Six survival terms that are not synonyms

TERM	CLAIM MADE	OWNER / FATAL MERGE
IMMORTALITY	a subject is deathless	Plato, Vedanta, Nyaya, Jainism / with resurrection
SURVIVAL	something of the person continues after death	the weaker neutral claim / with immortality
REBIRTH punarjanma / punarbhava	karmically renewed becoming in a beginningless series	the WIDER term; the only correct one for Buddhism / with reincarnation
REINCARNATION (re-enfleshed)	a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-enters flesh	Vedanta, Nyaya, Jainism / applied to Buddhism
RESURRECTION	God re-constitutes the whole embodied person; ONE life	Judaism, Christianity, Islam / "rebirth in heaven"
LIBERATION	exit from the series; SEVEN non-identical destinations	every Indian school / treated as one state

MERGE ANY TWO AND THE SCRIPT CAPS AT ABOUT 50%.

Sanskrit registers the range: punarjanma (rebirth) · punarahvrtti (return) · punarbhava (re-becoming) · samsara (the wandering itself).

THE THREE STEMS BUILT ON THIS BENCH:

- necessity for REBIRTH -> 2022 Q5(c); 2025 Q7(c)
- necessity for LIBERATION -> 2024 Q6(a)
- presupposition of RELIGION -> 2020 Q5(b)

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/32: Five models of the person, five kinds of survival

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/32: Five models of the person, five kinds of survival

MODEL	SURVIVAL IT ALLOWS	ITS OWN PRESSURE
SUBSTANCE DUALISM immaterial thinker	disembodied soul persists	interaction; what individuates souls
HYLOMORPHISM soul = form of body	resurrection of the embodied person	how the SAME person is re-constituted
BUNDLE / NO-SELF series without owner	causal or psycho-logical continuity	who is responsible; who is reborn
EMBODIED PERSON psychophysical unity	re-creation or resurrection only	replica and duplication problems
INDIAN SUBSTANTIAL SELF (atman / jiva)	transmigration of an enduring self	no past-life memory; evidence

FOUR CRITERIA OF PERSONAL IDENTITY – THEY ANSWER DIFFERENT QUESTIONS

BODILY CONTINUITY same living organism ... fails outright at death

PSYCHOLOGICAL / MEMORY memory, character circular, fallible, branchable

SOUL-SUBSTANCE one enduring subject ... unobservable; individuation hard

CAUSAL CONTINUITY causal descent "neither same nor wholly other"

HOW WE TELL = bodily + psychological WHAT MAKES IT SO = substance + causal

Noticing this division of labour is a top-band move.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/32: Hick's replica and the duplication objection

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/32: Hick's replica and the duplication objection

STAGE 1 a person disappears here and an exact psychophysical replica –
same body-pattern, same memories, same character – appears elsewhere
| ordinary criteria would in practice treat this as the same person
STAGE 2 the same thing happens at the moment of death
|
STAGE 3 the replica appears not elsewhere on earth but in a DIFFERENT SPACE,
a resurrection world

HICK'S CLAIM: for every purpose that matters – memory, character, recognition,
responsibility – this IS the same person.

DUPLICATION OBJECTION

if God can make ONE replica, God can make TWO
two replicas cannot both be numerically identical with the original
therefore either the criterion is not identity, or identity depends on the
accident that no rival was produced

HICK'S REPLY : restrict the case to a UNIQUE replica; ordinary criteria are then met

REJOINDER : the bare POSSIBILITY of duplication shows the criterion tracks
QUALITATIVE SIMILARITY, not NUMERICAL IDENTITY

STATUS CONTROL: the replica is a THOUGHT-EXPERIMENT DEFENCE of the coherence of
resurrection identity. It is NOT evidence that anyone survives.

Source: John Hick, Philosophy of Religion / Death and Eternal Life.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/32: Plato in the Phaedo, arguments 1 and 2

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/32: Plato in the Phaedo, arguments 1 and 2

ARGUMENT 1 – FROM OPPOSITES (CYCLICAL)

PREMISE opposites come to be from opposites: larger from smaller,
weaker from stronger, waking from sleeping

APPLY being dead comes from being alive; by symmetry being alive
must come from being dead

CONCLUDE souls exist in some state between deaths, or the supply of
the living would exhaust itself

ASSESS the pattern fits qualities admitting DEGREE, not existence and
non-existence; and it yields a cosmic balance-sheet, not the
survival of THIS soul

|
ARGUMENT 2 – FROM RECOLLECTION (ANAMNESIS)

PREMISE we judge sensible things – two sticks – to be DEFICIENTLY equal

STEP to judge a deficiency one must already possess the standard,
Equality itself, which no sense-experience supplies

CONCLUDE the soul acquired that standard before embodiment;
learning is recollection

EXAMPLE equal sticks never perfectly instantiate Equality, yet we judge
their shortfall by a standard not derived from them alone

ASSESS establishes PRE-EXISTENCE ONLY – which is why Plato must pair it
with the cyclical argument to close the post-mortem direction

DIRECTIVE CONTROL: "critically examine Plato's a priori proofs" (2023 Q6(a), 20m)

= FOUR SEPARATE MINI-ASSESSMENTS, never one summary with one general complaint.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/32: Plato in the Phaedo, arguments 3 and 4

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/32: Plato in the Phaedo, arguments 3 and 4

ARGUMENT 3 – FROM AFFINITY

PREMISE two kinds of thing: composite, visible, changing, perishable;
and non-composite, invisible, stable, imperishable
STEP the body resembles the first, the soul the second
CONCLUDE the soul is akin to the indissoluble, hence itself indissoluble
ASSESS Plato presents this as LIKENESS, with more caution than summaries
suggest; resemblance to the imperishable does not entail
imperishability, and simplicity is assumed rather than proved

|
ARGUMENT 4 – THE FINAL ARGUMENT: THE FORM OF LIFE

PREMISE some things bring a Form with them wherever they go:
fire brings heat, snow brings cold
STEP soul brings LIFE wherever it is
STEP what essentially brings a Form cannot admit that Form's opposite
CONCLUDE soul cannot admit death; it is deathless and indestructible
ASSESS the inference from "cannot admit the opposite" to "cannot cease"
needs a bridge: fire does not become cold, but fire GOES OUT.
The argument shows a soul cannot be a DEAD soul; the critic asks
why it may not simply cease to exist

WHAT EACH ARGUMENT ACTUALLY BUYS

- 1 persistence through the transition, both directions (weak analogy)
- 2 PRE-EXISTENCE only
- 3 likeness to the indissoluble
- 4 essential predication, with an unbridged step to indestructibility

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/32: Simmias inside the dialogue, Kant outside it

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/32: Simmias inside the dialogue, Kant outside it

SIMMIAS' OBJECTION – THE SOUL AS ATTUNEMENT (HARMONIA)

the soul is an attunement of bodily elements, as the tuning of a lyre is
of its strings; when the instrument is destroyed the attunement perishes,
however "divine and beautiful" it was

|
PLATO'S TWOFOLD REPLY

- (1) recollection shows the soul existed BEFORE the body – but an attunement
cannot precede the instrument it tunes; so the two doctrines are
incompatible and Simmias must give one up
- (2) attunements admit of degree and never oppose their own components;
the soul RULES the body, opposing appetite and desire, which no
attunement does

NOTE: the harmony objection is the ancient ancestor of every modern
brain-dependence argument. Omitting Simmias is the standard band-loss on 2023.

KANT – THE PARALOGISMS OF PURE REASON

the "I think" that accompanies all representations gives a FORMAL UNITY of
consciousness, not knowledge of a simple persisting SUBSTANCE
rational psychology mistakes a condition of thought for an object of knowledge
CONSEQUENCE: immortality cannot be theoretically demonstrated

RELOCATION : in the second Critique it returns as a POSTULATE OF PRACTICAL
REASON, required by the moral law's demand for the complete good

CONTROL: Kant does NOT claim the soul does not exist. He denies that it is a
knowable substance. This relocation is exactly what 2020 Q5(b) invites.

INDIAN PARALLEL, USED CAREFULLY: atman (Vedanta), jiva (Jainism) and the Nyaya
self are ETERNAL in their systems, and Gita 2.23 gives the canonical image –
but the Indian route is scriptural and systematic, not a priori in Plato's sense.
Compare CONCLUSIONS, never METHODS.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/32: Five argument families and the burden shift

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/32: Five argument families and the burden shift

FAMILY	CORE REASONING	MAIN OBJECTION
SIMPLICITY / INDIVISIBILITY	an immaterial simple soul has no parts to decompose into	simplicity is not established; a simple subject could still cease
IDENTITY / CONTINUITY	stable agency, responsibility and first-person unity need a persisting subject	psychological or causal continuity may do the same work
MORAL ORDER	complete justice or the highest good requires more than one life	postulation expresses moral hope, not theoretical demonstration
DESIRE / FULFILMENT	a deep natural desire for unending fulfilment points to a possible object	desires can be frustrated or socially formed; existence does not follow
RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE / TESTIMONY	experiences read as contact with the dead or an eternal self support survival	interpretation, diversity and alternative explanations

BODY / BRAIN DEPENDENCE OBJECTION

memory, personality, agency and moral capacity vary systematically with
bodily and cerebral conditions

IT DOES NOT deductively prove that no subject survives

IT DOES shift the burden: the survivalist now owes accounts of

(i) INTERACTION (ii) INDIVIDUATION (iii) IDENTITY

GRADED CLAIM-LEVELS demonstration: NO · coherence: on some models · presupposition:
for some practices · postulate: available to practical reason.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/32: Hindu immortality - verse spine and school split

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/32: Hindu immortality – verse spine and school split

WHAT IS ETERNAL AND WHAT IS NOT

SELF (ATMAN)	eternal · unborn · indestructible Gita 2.23 – weapons do not cut, fire does not burn, water does not wet, wind does not wither
SUBTLE BODY (sukṣma-sarīra)	NOT the self – an INSTRUMENT. Carries dispositions (saṃskāra / vāsanā), mind, senses, vital breath
GROSS BODY	discarded like worn-out garments (Gita 2.22)

VERSE SPINE: 2.22 garments (rebirth) · 2.23 indestructibility ·

9.21 return when merit is exhausted (heaven is INSIDE saṃsāra) ·

5.4-5 convergence (balah, not paṇḍitah) · 18.66 surrender (cārama-sloka).

Translations vary: paraphrase, or quote a NAMED translation. Never invent one.

FOUR ACCOUNTS OF WHAT IS DEATHLESS – "Hindu tradition" is not one position

ADVĀITA non-dual awareness identical with Brahman; bondage = ignorance

VISISTĀDVĀITA eternal individual soul, a mode (prakāra) of God; communion

NYĀYA-VAIŚEṢIKA .. eternal self-substance; consciousness ADVENTITIOUS; no bliss

SAMKHYA-YOGA puruṣa, plural contentless witness; strictly never bound

SUPPORTS OFFERED (i) continuity of the knower across waking, dream, deep sleep

(ii) moral bookkeeping across a gap longer than a life

(iii) scriptural testimony (śabda) – NAME it as a presupposition

(iv) beginninglessness (anādi), which blocks "when did it fall?"

MEMORY OBJECTION -> reply: dispositional, not episodic, continuity. Warrant contested.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/32: Karma – act plus potency, and where freedom lives

adrsta (Nyaya-Vaisesika) – a quality of the self
apurva (Mimamsa) – the "not-previously-existing" capacity by which
 a sacrifice produces its distant result

BOTH EXIST TO SOLVE ONE PROBLEM: how a past act produces a future effect across a temporal gap.

SANCITA (stored)	the whole accumulated store, not yet ripening -> DESTROYED by liberating knowledge
PRARABDHA (fructify)	the portion already ripening: this birth, this body, this span -> NOT cancelled by knowledge; runs its course
AGAMI (future)	what present action is now generating -> the liberated agent accumulates none

fatalism: what happens is fixed and effort is idle
 karma : fructifying karma fixes the CONDITIONS, not the response;
 present action generates future karma, so acting is the point;
 the agent is both inheritor and author
 FORMULA : effort (purusakara) WITHIN destiny (daiva) – the hand dealt is
 inherited, the play is not
 niskama-karma (desireless action) USES the law rather than escaping it

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/32: Karma – administration, postulate test, costs

Nyaya · Visistadvaita · Dvaita
God is SUPERINTENDENT (karmadhyaksa)
who RATIFIES and dispenses the fruit
God does not DECIDE that cruelty
deserves suffering; God ensures the
fruit is delivered

- (1) DISTRIBUTION of fortune becomes arbitrary; the tradition's answer to unequal suffering collapses
- (2) REBIRTH loses its rationale – nothing would require a further life
- (3) LIBERATION loses its content – no bondage to be freed from
- (4) RITUAL INJUNCTION loses efficacy in the Mimamsa framework

(a) UNVERIFIABLE – the links are not observable	shared with every eschatology; not a special defect of karma
(b) VICTIM-BLAMING RISK – present suffering read as past fault	explanatory karma licenses NO social judgement; the duty of compassion is untouched
(c) GOD-AND-LAW PROBLEM – God redundant or subordinate	the theistic schools make God ADMINISTRATOR, not AUTHOR, of desert

CONTROL: never omit (b) from a karma answer.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/32: Rebirth - the fit-problem and its three exits

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/32: Rebirth – the fit-problem and its three exits

CLAIM : every morally weighted act matures into its result

FACT : many acts plainly do not mature within one lifetime

GAP : the good suffer, the cruel prosper, and infants suffer before they
can have acted at all

```

                                     |
+-----+-----+-----+
EXIT (a)      EXIT (b)      EXIT (c)
abandon the   postulate a final judge  WIDEN THE FIELD of
exceptionless claim and one post-mortem maturation across many
                settlement              lives
                -> the SEMITIC route:  -> the INDIAN route:
                resurrection and        rebirth within samsara
                judgement
                                     |

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REBIRTH IS EXIT (c). THAT IS ITS PHILOSOPHICAL SIGNIFICANCE (2023 Q7(b)).

WHAT REBIRTH THEREBY CONTRIBUTES

- (i) preserves an EXCEPTIONLESS moral law against the evidence
- (ii) explains INITIAL INEQUALITY: birth-conditions are consequences,
not impositions
- (iii) secures BEGINNINGLESSNESS (anadi) – no "original fault" to explain,
as there is in a Fall narrative
- (iv) gives LIBERATION its content by supplying something to be freed from

VEHICLES OF CONTINUITY, SCHOOL BY SCHOOL

Advaita / Visistadvaita ... subtle body (suksma-sarira): mind, senses, breath

Nyaya-Vaisesika the eternal self, bearing adrsta

Samkhya-Yoga linga-sarira, a product of prakrti – STRICTLY it is
PRAKRTI that transmigrates, not purusa

Jainism the jiva with adhering karmic matter

Buddhism causal continuity of aggregates; NO vehicle-substance

COSTS: regress explains each birth by an earlier one, never the series as a whole;
no past-life memory; moral hazard. Gita 9.21: even heaven is within samsara.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/32: Buddhist rebirth without a permanent self

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/32: Buddhist rebirth without a permanent self

THE FOUR-STEP ARGUMENT

(1) ALL CONDITIONED FACTORS ARE IMPERMANENT

|

(2) NO AGGREGATE (skandha: form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness) IS A PERMANENT SELF

|

(3) CRAVING (tr̥sna) AND KARMIC FORMATIONS (saṃskāra) CONDITION FUTURE CONSCIOUSNESS

|

(4) THEREFORE CONTINUITY OCCURS WITHOUT AN UNCHANGING OWNER

|

REBIRTH (punarbhava) IS SECURED; A SOUL IS NOT REQUIRED

Mechanism: dependent origination (pratityasamutpada).

DENIED

an unchanging, independent,
permanent self
a substance that owns experiences
a self that transmigrates intact
ANATMAN IS NOT NIHILISM: a middle

NOT DENIED

the conventional person, who acts and is addressed
the reality of experience and moral consequence
rebirth itself – Buddhism AFFIRMS re-becoming
the causal descent of the later from the earlier
course between an eternal self and annihilation.

ILLUSTRATIONS – NEVER PROOFS

FLAME -> FLAME the second lamp is lit from the first. Same fire? No.

Unrelated fire? Also no. (the Milindapanha uses the lamp)

MILK -> CURD continuous transformation; no stage identical with another,
yet nothing imported from outside

RESPONSIBILITY OBJECTION: if no same agent persists, who receives the fruit?

REPLY: responsibility requires CAUSAL CONNECTEDNESS, not identity of substance.

The later stream is NEITHER THE SAME NOR WHOLLY OTHER. Ordinary practice already accepts this: the adult answers for the youth.

RESIDUE (concede it): critics answer that causal descent may be thinner than

OWNERSHIP – this pressure is genuine and unresolved.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/32: The modal verdict rail

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/32: The modal verdict rail

CLAIM UNDER TEST: "Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth."

|

SUBSTANTIALIST SYSTEMS

Vedānta · Nyāya · Jainism

YES: a persisting self is what
transmigrates

|

BUDDHISM

anatman + pratityasamutpada

NO: causal continuity of a
conditioned stream suffices

|

ONE COUNTER-EXAMPLE DEFEATS A NECESSITY CLAIM

|

VERDICT: an immortal soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth, NOT NECESSARY.

What rebirth requires is a CONTINUITY-BEARER, and the dispute is only about
whether that bearer must be a substance.

SECOND PRESSURE, FROM INSIDE THE SUBSTANTIALIST CAMP

Samkhya-kārika 62-63: strictly NO PURUṢA is bound, released or transmigrating;
it is PRAKṚTĪ who binds herself, transmigrates and releases herself.

So even a school with an eternal consciousness denies that IT undergoes rebirth.

THE SAME RAIL, APPLIED TO LIBERATION (2024 Q6(a))

ROBUSTNESS TEST: a conception of liberation is robust if it fixes

(i) what bondage is (ii) what is liberated

(iii) what the terminus is (iv) why the terminus is final

Buddhism satisfies all four WITHOUT an immortal soul.

VERDICT: rebirth (or an equivalent bondage-HISTORY) is effectively necessary;
immortality of a SUBSTANTIAL soul is not.

TEMPLATE LINE: "Immortality of a substantial soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth but
not NECESSARY: Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone."

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/32: The liberation parity bench - seven destinations

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/32: The liberation parity bench – seven destinations

TERM	SCHOOL	WHAT ENDS	WHAT REMAINS	CONSCIOUSNESS?
MOKSA (release)	Advaita	ignorance (avidya)	Brahman alone	YES – self-luminous, non-dual
MOKSA (release)	Visista-dvaita	karmic bondage	eternal jiva WITH God	YES – personal, in communion
APAVARGA (cessation)	Nyaya-Vaisesika	pain AND its conditions	the self-substance	NO – no bliss, no awareness
KAIVALYA (aloneness)	Samkhya-Yoga	non-discrimination	purusa, isolated	YES – pure and CONTENTLESS
LIBERATION siddhahood	Jainism	karmic matter	perfected omniscient jiva	YES – the four infinitudes (ananta-catustaya)
NIRVANA (extinguish)	Buddhism	craving, ignorance, suffering	NOT stated as a self	neither "survival" nor "annihilation"
RESURRECTION	Semitic	death	the embodied person	YES – embodied, before God

FOUR STRUCTURAL QUESTIONS THE BENCH ANSWERS

identity / communion / cessation / isolation / perfection – which is it?

is INDIVIDUALITY preserved? (sublated only in Advaita)

is CONSCIOUSNESS present? (absent only in Nyaya apavarga)

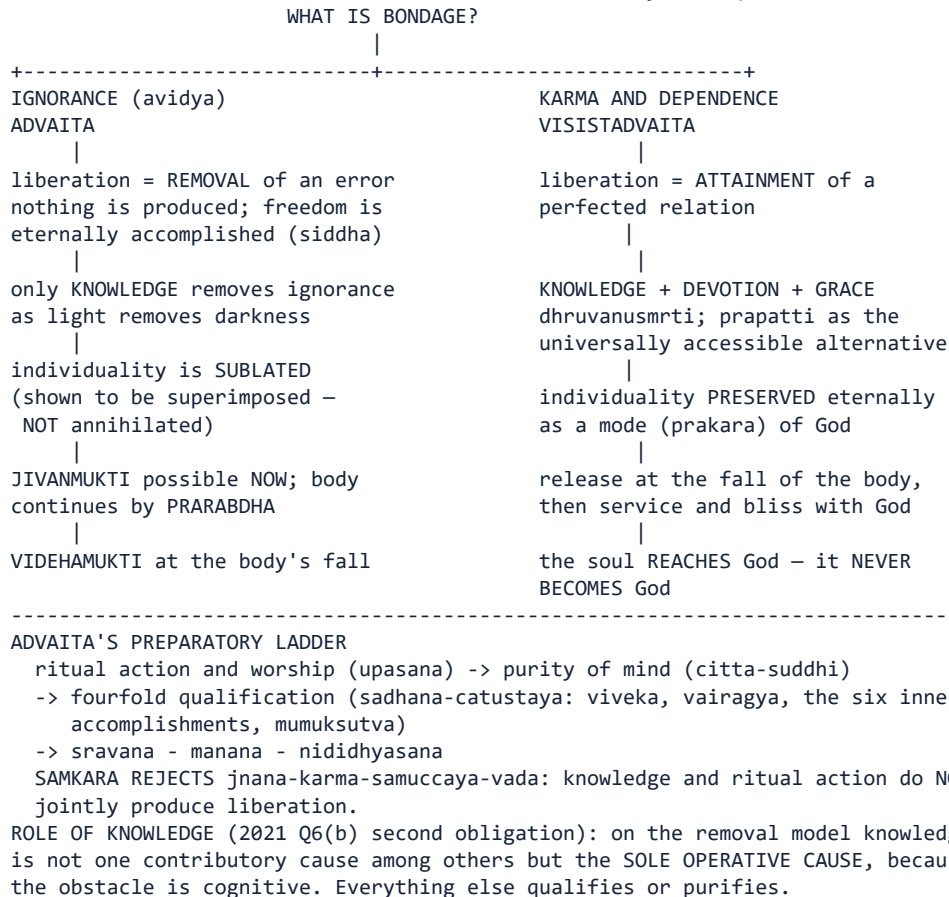
is it attainable WHILE ALIVE? (yes in Advaita and Samkhya-Yoga)

TERMINOLOGY TRAP: kevala in JAINISM = OMNISCIENCE; kaivalya in SAMKHYA = CONTENTLESS ISOLATION. Same syllable, opposite content.

POSITIVE PERFECTION vs MERE CESSATION: Advaita and Jainism are fulfilment-rich; Nyaya is cessation-only; Buddhism refuses both annihilation and hedonic models. Reply to "cessation is unattractive": Nyaya offers freedom FROM suffering, not experiential luxury; promising more would be dishonest about its metaphysics.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/32: Vedanta - one fork, many consequences

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/32: Vedanta – one fork, many consequences



ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/32: Embodied liberation and the real-agent question

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/32: Embodied liberation and the real-agent question

WHY THE BODY REMAINS AFTER LIBERATING KNOWLEDGE

- knowledge destroys SANCITA (stored) and AGAMI (future) karma
- PRARABDHA has already begun to ripen and RUNS ITS COURSE

IMAGE: the potter's wheel continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn at its exhaustion the body falls -> VIDEHAMUKTI

OBJECTION: if ignorance is destroyed, why does empirical activity continue?

REPLY : distinguish destroyed BONDAGE from residual embodied MOMENTUM; the residue is located in the body-mind complex, not in the knower

REJOINDER: critics say a trace of ignorance is smuggled back under another name

CROSS-SCHOOL CONTROL: Samkhya faces the same phenomenon and explains it DIFFERENTLY – SK 67 attributes the continuing body to the momentum of the GUNAS, not to karma; SK 68 gives videha-kaivalya at the body's fall. Shared image, different metaphysics.

2022 Q7(b): CAN LIBERATION BE CONCEIVED WITHOUT A REAL AGENT?

ADVAITA – YES, AND IT MUST BE

- agency belongs to the empirical individual, which is superimposed at the ultimate level (paramarthika) there is no agent, no bondage and hence no one who is literally liberated
- the tradition itself says bondage and release are stated "from the standpoint of ignorance"

VISISTADVAITA – NO

- an unreal agent cannot have real bondage, real striving, real devotion, or a real reward; liberation must happen TO someone, so the jiva is eternally real

HONEST VERDICT: each position pays a price. Advaita must explain how an unreal individual undertakes a real discipline; Visistadvaita must explain how a really distinct soul is nonetheless WHOLLY dependent on God.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/32: The Jain ladder - soul and bondage

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/32: The Jain ladder – soul and bondage

JIVA (soul)	eternal · conscious · uncreated · NO creator God intrinsic nature = ANANTA-CATUSTAYA: infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy CO-EXTENSIVE with the body it occupies, like light filling a room – extension is a MODE of the soul during bondage
PASSIONS (kasaya):	anger · pride · deceit · greed make the soul "sticky"
ASRAVA	INFLOW of fine karmic matter (karma-pudgala)
BANDHA	BONDAGE – matter binds to the soul, obscuring the four infinitudes. Analysed by NATURE, DURATION, INTENSITY, QUANTITY
SAMVARA	STOPPAGE – vows, carefulness, restraint, non-violence: no new inflow
NIRJARA	SHEDDING – austerity (tapas) destroys accumulated karma
KEVALA-JNANA	OMNISCIENCE manifests while still embodied (manifested, NOT produced – it was only obscured)
MOKSA / SIDDHAHOOD	final disembodied perfection

IMAGE: dust clings to an OILY body. The oil is passion; without it the dust does not adhere.

INTERACTION OBJECTION: how can non-material consciousness bind with material karma?

REPLY: extension and embodiment are MODES of the soul during bondage; the jiva is not an unextended Cartesian thinker.

COST: the reply buys intelligibility by weakening immateriality – a substance neither cleanly material nor cleanly spiritual.

PLACEMENT: Jain liberation PERFECTS INDIVIDUALITY – neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without a self. 2022 Q8(b) has TWO nouns: soul AND bondage.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/32: Nyaya-Vaisesika cessation - the chain and apavarga

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/32: Nyaya-Vaisesika cessation – the chain and apavarga

NYAYA-VAISESIKA – THE CHAIN AND ITS REVERSAL

FALSE KNOWLEDGE -> DEFECT -> ACTIVITY -> BIRTH -> SUFFERING

TRUE KNOWLEDGE of the categories and of the self removes false knowledge;
the chain then unwinds link by link to ABSOLUTE CESSATION OF PAIN

APAVARGA = pain AND the qualities that sustain embodied experience END

Consciousness is ADVENTITIOUS – it arises only when the self is conjoined
with mind, senses and body – so the released self exists WITHOUT consciousness,
pleasure or bliss

OBJECTION: indistinguishable from stone-like insentience; who would want it?

REPLY : the school offers the END OF A DEFECT, not a reward. Its value is
negative and complete: no pain can arise again, because the
conditions for ANY experience have ended

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/32: Samkhya - two principles and one misattribution

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/32: Samkhya – two principles and one misattribution

SAMKHYA – TWO PRINCIPLES, ONE MISATTRIBUTION

PURUSA plural · inactive · attributeless PURE CONSCIOUSNESS · witness (saksin)
by nature already isolated (kevala)

PRAKRTI one · unconscious · active · constituted by the three gunas

BONDAGE IS NOT A REAL BOND but AVIVEKA: prakrti's states are MISATTRIBUTED
to consciousness

SK 1 threefold suffering: adhyatmika (self) · adhibhautika (other beings) ·
adhidaivika (natural and cosmic), and the failure of ordinary and
ritual means to end it permanently

SATKARYAVADA effects pre-exist in their cause: evolution is TRANSFORMATION of
prakrti, not creation; consciousness cannot be a product of the
unconscious, hence purusa is distinct

SK 62-63 NO PURUSA is bound, released or transmigrating – PRAKRTI binds,
transmigrates and releases herself. THE HIGHEST-VALUE ITEM HERE

SK 67 potter's wheel – the body persists on residual momentum

SK 68 videha-kaivalya at the fall of the body

LIBERATION = VIVEKA-KHYATI (discriminative discernment); prakrti then ceases
to display herself to that purusa. RESULT = KAIVALYA, aloneness

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/32: Yoga - practice, the non-creator Isvara, and three objections

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/32: Yoga – practice, the non-creator Isvara, and three objections

YOGA – SAME METAPHYSICS PLUS A PRACTICE AND AN ISVARA

YS 1.2 yoga = citta-vrtti-nirodha (restriction of mental modifications)

YS 1.3 then the seer abides in its own nature

YS 2.3 five klesas: avidya · asmita · raga · dvesa · abhinivesa
(avidya is the FIELD of the rest)

YS 1.24 ISVARA IS A SPECIAL PURUSA untouched by klesa, karma, vipaka, asaya –
teacher of the ancient teachers, object of isvara-pranidhana.
HE IS NOT A CREATOR. Yoga = theism WITHOUT creation

YS 4.29 dharma-megha-samadhi

YS 4.34 KAIVALYA = pratiprasava (counter-flow) of the gunas, now empty of
purpose for purusa; equivalently citi-sakti established in its own nature

ASTANGA: yama · niyama · asana · pranayama · pratyahara · dharana · dhyana ·
samadhi – samprajnata to asamprajnata

THREE OBJECTIONS -> REPLIES -> COSTS

plurality of purusas -> difference shown by birth, death, experience ->

Advaitins call this question-begging, since those differences belong to prakrti

why does prakrti act? -> "for the sake of purusa"; milk flows for the calf ->

a purpose in the unconscious is exactly what Nyaya objects to

is contentless liberation desirable? -> Samkhya DENIES kaivalya is bliss; it is

the ENDING of threefold suffering -> an unattractive terminus, accepted for
the sake of consistency

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/32: Devotion as a pathway - textual base and typology

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/32: Devotion as a pathway – textual base and typology

TEXTUAL BASE

Gita 18.66 carama-sloka: abandon all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone

Gita 9.22 the Lord secures what the exclusively devoted lack

Gita 9.32 accessibility of the path

Bhagavata 7.5.23 NINE LIMBS (navadha bhakti), IN ORDER:

sravana (hearing) · kirtana (praising) · smarana (remembering) ·

pada-sevana (service at the feet) · arcana (worship) · vandana (salutation) ·

dasya (servitude) · sakhya (friendship) · atma-nivedana (self-offering)

Narada Bhakti Sutra / Sandilya Bhakti Sutra: supreme love / supreme attachment
to Isvara. Do NOT attach a date or an author-identification

TYPOLOGY (marks lie in the distinctions)

para (higher, disinterested) <-> apara / gauni (preliminary, ritual-supported)

vaidhi (scripturally ruled) <-> raganuga (spontaneous, Gaudiya)

saguna (Tulsidas, Surdas, <-> nirguna (Kabir, Nanak, Dadu)

Mirabai) -> shows bhakti needs a PERSONAL FOCUS,
not an iconic form

five bhavas: santa · dasya · sakhya · vatsalya · madhurya

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/32: Devotion - systematic positions, grace and effort, evaluation

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 23/32: Devotion – systematic positions, grace and effort, evaluation

SYSTEMATIC POSITIONS

- RAMANUJA bhakti = dhruvanusrmti (steady loving recollection);
PRAPATTI / saranagati as the equally efficacious, universally accessible alternative; liberation finally by GRACE
- MADHVA jnana-purvaka-sneha (affection PRECEDED by knowledge);
prasada decisive; taratamya fixes the degree
- VALLABHA pusti-marga, the path of nourishing grace, unearned by works
- CAITANYA prema-bhakti as a FIFTH and higher purusartha – the devotee may prefer service to liberation
- ADVAITA preparatory only: citta-suddhi and one-pointedness qualify one for jnana, which alone removes ignorance
(?) the Vivekacudamani definition – ascription to Samkara DISPUTED: say "the Advaita tradition", never "Samkara wrote"

THE GRACE / EFFORT PROBLEM

- MARJARA-NYAYA the cat carries the kitten -> GRACE ALONE (Tenkalai)
- MARKATA-NYAYA the young monkey must cling -> GRACE PLUS EFFORT (Vadakalai)

EVALUATION CRITERIA (2018 Q7(c) says EVALUATE, not describe)

- ACCESSIBILITY highest – dispenses with Sanskrit learning and ritual entitlement; hence the vernacular movement: Alvars, Nayanars, Basavanna, Kabir, Nanak, Mira, Tukaram
- SUFFICIENCY sufficient and DIRECT in the theistic Vedantas; PREPARATORY only in Advaita
- TERMINUS communion and service, not identity – sufficiency is relative to a Vaisnava conception of the goal

INCAPACITY ARGUMENT: if bondage is beginningless the bound jiva cannot lift itself; only grace can, and bhakti is the posture in which grace is RECEIVED.

OBJECTIONS -> REPLIES

- love presupposes duality -> Advaita AGREES and so classes it as means, not end; the theistic Vedantas deny that identity is the goal at all
- emotionalism -> vaidhi discipline, scriptural regulation, Madhva's knowledge-first if grace decides, effort is otiose -> the cat/monkey dispute IS the tradition's own statement of the problem; neither side eliminates the other term
- bhakti presupposes a saguna God -> nirguna bhakti shows a PERSONAL FOCUS suffices, BUT the objection stands against strictly non-theistic systems

VERDICT FORMULA: bhakti's significance is not emotional but STRUCTURAL – it relocates liberation from ACHIEVEMENT to RECEPTION.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/32: The three-means dispute - apparatus and positions

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 24/32: The three-means dispute – apparatus and positions

THE EXACT QUESTION: are knowledge, action and devotion ALTERNATIVE routes, SEQUENTIAL stages, or COMBINED? Naming the disagreement IS the answer.

THREE DISTINCTIONS THAT SEPARATE A 7 FROM A 12

- (1) DIRECT MEANS (saksat-sadhana) vs AUXILIARY AID (arad-upakaraka)
 - (2) MEANS vs QUALIFICATION (adhikara) – karma may qualify one for knowledge without being a means to liberation
 - (3) PRODUCTION MODEL vs REMOVAL MODEL of liberation
 - if moksa is a RESULT to be produced -> action can produce it
 - if moksa is the REMOVAL of an error -> only knowledge can remove it
- SAMKARA'S ENTIRE CASE RESTS ON THE SECOND

THE POSITIONS

- PURVA-MIMAMSA KARMA ALONE – the Veda is essentially injunctive; knowledge-passages are subordinate to ritual action. This is the purvapaksa Samkara argues against, and naming it shows why the dispute exists
- SAMKARA JNANA ALONE liberates. Moksa is not a producible effect (sadhya) but the eternally accomplished nature of the self (siddha), obscured by avidya. REJECTS jnana-karma-samuccaya-vada. Karma and upasana remain indispensable PREPARATIONS
- RAMANUJA SEQUENTIAL CULMINATION – karma-yoga purifies, jnana-yoga discloses the self as a mode of God, both flow into BHAKTI-YOGA as the direct means; prapatti is the accessible alternative. Accepts a graded samuccaya that Samkara denies
- MADHVA knowledge of the Lord's supremacy is prior; bhakti ripened from it is the means; prasada is decisive

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 25/32: The three-means dispute - text signal, objections and verdict

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 25/32: The three-means dispute – text signal, objections and verdict

THE TEXT'S OWN SIGNAL

Gita 5.4-5: only the immature (balah) declare Samkhya (knowledge) and Yoga (action) to be different; one who reaches by one reaches by the other.

-> CONVERGENCE, which is why SAMKARA claimed it for jnana, RAMANUJA for bhakti, and TILAK (Gita-Rahasya) for karma.

VIVEKANANDA: four yogas (jnana, bhakti, karma, raja) matched to TEMPERAMENT – psychological, not metaphysical, pluralism.

OBJECTION: convergence is diplomatic mush – knowledge that dissolves individuality and devotion that preserves it cannot terminate in the same state.

REPLY : they converge in FUNCTION (dismantling egoic self-appropriation) and diverge in TERMINUS (identity vs communion). Say exactly this.

SECOND OBJECTION: if karma cannot liberate, why does the Gita command action?

REPLY : niskama-karma does not liberate BY PRODUCING moksa; it liberates by dismantling the agency-sense that sustains bondage.

VERDICT FORMULA: KARMA QUALIFIES · BHAKTI RECEIVES · JNANA REMOVES.

Which is DIRECT is settled by a prior question: is liberation PRODUCED or UNCOVERED?

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 26/32: Resurrection and rebirth - two strands and the grid

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 26/32: Resurrection and rebirth – two strands and the grid

TWO WESTERN STRANDS OFTEN WRONGLY MERGED

IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL (Greek/Platonic): the soul is naturally deathless and death RELEASES it from the body

RESURRECTION OF THE DEAD (Hebrew-Christian-Islamic): the person is a PSYCHOSOMATIC UNITY, so survival requires God to restore the WHOLE person; death is real and defeat is reversed only by divine act

OSCAR CULLMANN (1955), "Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?": the two are theologically OPPOSED, not complementary

AXIS	RESURRECTION	REBIRTH (INDIAN)
Number of lives	ONE earthly life	beginningless series
Mechanism	divine act at the end of history	karma maturing through samsara
Judge	God, in a final judgement	the karmic law itself; in Nyaya/Ramanuja God RATIFIES
Telos	restored embodied life in communion with God	EXIT from the series – moksa/nirvana/kaivalya/apavarga
Identity-bearer	person re-constituted by God (soul as form, or replica)	atman/jiva – or, in Buddhism, a causal stream
Body	ESSENTIAL; a "spiritual body" is still a body	discarded like clothing (Gita 2.22); subtle body carries dispositions
Direction of time	linear, eschatological	cyclical, with a linear exit
Moral function	accountability before a personal God	self-regulating desert, no external prosecutor

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 27/32: Identity failures both ways, and rebirth versus reincarnation

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THE IDENTITY PROBLEM, BOTH WAYS

FOR RESURRECTION: the GAP PROBLEM (what exists between death and raising?) and the RE-ASSEMBLY / "CANNIBAL" objection (if matter is shared, whose atoms rise?)
AQUINAS the rational soul is the FORM of the body, securing continuity
VAN INWAGEN God PRESERVES the body (or a core) and leaves a simulacrum
HICK a unique psychophysical REPLICA with memory and character IS the same person for all purposes that matter

DUPLICATION OBJECTION -> if one replica, why not two? Hick restricts to a UNIQUE replica; critics answer that possibility of duplication already shows the criterion is not identity

FOR REBIRTH: the MEMORY OBJECTION – no recollection of prior lives.

Reply: psychological memory is not metaphysical continuity; latent samskaras and vasanas connect lives. (?) Coherent, but evidentially empty.

REBIRTH vs REINCARNATION (2019 Q8(a) DEMANDS THIS)

REINCARNATION (re-enfleshing) presupposes a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-entering a body
-> apt for Vedanta, Nyaya, Jainism

REBIRTH is the WIDER, neutral term and the ONLY correct one for Buddhism's punarbhava without a transmigrating substance

Gita 9.21 (pitryana): those who exhaust their merit RETURN to the world of mortals – even heaven is a WITHIN-SAMSARA stage, not resurrection

VERDICT FORMULA: resurrection asks how a person can survive when the person is essentially embodied; rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when a single life is too short. NEITHER IS A VERSION OF THE OTHER, and the identity problem is unresolved on both sides – for OPPOSITE reasons.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 28/32: Anti-theistic rebirth - the three detachments

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 28/32: Anti-theistic rebirth – the three detachments

(1) KARMA WITHOUT A JUDGE

desert is discharged by an impersonal, self-regulating law
-> answers the DISTRIBUTION question without theodicy

(2) REBIRTH WITHOUT A SOUL

continuity, not substance, suffices (Buddhism)
-> defeats the NECESSITY claim

(3) LIBERATION WITHOUT GRACE

nirvana and Jain perfected omniscience need no deity and no divine favour
-> shows soteriology is not intrinsically theistic

THE TWO SYSTEMS ARE NOT ONE POSITION

	BUDDHISM	JAINISM
Permanent self?	NO – anatman	YES – eternal jiva
Creator God?	NO	NO
Karma	causal conditioning of a stream	quasi-material matter adhering to the soul
Liberation	extinguishing of craving (nirvana)	perfected omniscient individuality
Proves	rebirth needs no soul	rebirth and liberation need no God

TOGETHER they establish more than either alone: Jainism removes the GOD without removing the SOUL; Buddhism removes the SOUL without removing REBIRTH. The WHOLE structure is therefore separable.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 29/32: Anti-theistic rebirth - significance, counter-pressures, limits

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 29/32: Anti-theistic rebirth – significance, counter-pressures, limits

WHY THIS IS "PHILOSOPHICALLY SIGNIFICANT" (2018 Q5(b))

- it ISOLATES the explanatory work: if the same phenomena are explained without a judge and without a substance, neither is doing indispensable work
- it ANSWERS DISTRIBUTION differently from theism: impersonal law explains why THIS person suffers without a divine reason for the allocation
- it RELOCATES the burden: the theist must show what a judge ADDS; the substantialist must show what a permanent soul ADDS

COUNTER-PRESSURES -> REPLIES

- a law with no legislator is odd -> moral causation treated as basic, as natural regularities are treated
- without a self, moral ownership is unclear -> causal descent; "neither the same nor wholly other" (STRONGEST objection; concede the residue)
- without grace, liberation may be unattainable for most -> graded paths and lay-adherent routes

HARD LIMITS

- nastika = VEDA-REJECTING, not atheist
- do NOT merge the two anti-theisms – they differ precisely on the soul
- the conclusion is DETACHABILITY, never a disproof of theism

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 30/32: The directive decoder

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 30/32: The directive decoder

DIRECTIVE DECODER

- "Is X a necessary condition for Y?" -> modal verdict; substantialist YES, Buddhist counter-example, exact claim
2022 Q5(c) · 2024 Q6(a) · 2025 Q7(c)
- "Discuss with reference to [text/school]" -> fidelity to THAT source; the Gita question must cite Gita verses
- "Critically examine [thinker]'s proofs" -> four separate mini-assessments
- "Elucidate ... and explain the role of" -> TWO obligations, both delivered
- "Do you accept that ...? Discuss" -> position first, then evidence, then the strongest contrary case
- "Evaluate X as a pathway" -> criterion FIRST: accessibility, sufficiency, terminus
- "State and explain the doctrines A, B, C" -> three definitions, then relations
- "Discuss the nature of A and B" -> two nouns, both delivered
- "essential postulate" -> REMOVAL TEST, then price the costs
- "How far is it plausible ...?" -> graded plausibility verdict

RULE: the moment a stem names a liberation term (moksa/apavarga/kaivalya/nirvana/jivanmukti), fix that term against the PANEL 15 bench before writing anything else.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 31/32: 17-part PYQ routing and the fourteen standing traps

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 31/32: 17-part PYQ routing and the fourteen standing traps

17-PART PYQ ROUTING, 2018-2025

2018 Q5(b)	10m anti-theistic rebirth	PANEL 23
2018 Q7(c)	15m bhakti as a pathway	PANEL 20
2019 Q8(a)	20m karma, rebirth, reincarnation	PANELS 10, 12, 22
2020 Q5(b)	10m immortality as presupposition	PANELS 8, 9
2020 Q8(c)	15m knowledge, action, devotion	PANEL 21
2021 Q6(a)	20m immortality, Hindu tradition	PANEL 9
2021 Q6(b)	15m Advaita liberation + role of knowledge	PANEL 16
2021 Q8(b)	15m karma as essential postulate	PANEL 11
2022 Q5(c)	10m necessity w.r.t. Buddhism	PANELS 13, 14
2022 Q7(b)	15m liberation without a real agent	PANEL 17
2022 Q8(b)	15m Jain soul and bondage	PANEL 18
2023 Q6(a)	20m Plato's a priori proofs	PANELS 5, 6, 7
2023 Q7(b)	15m significance of rebirth in karma	PANEL 12
2024 Q5(c)	10m Nyaya-Vaisesika apavarga	PANEL 19
2024 Q6(a)	20m robust conception of liberation	PANELS 14, 15
2025 Q5(d)	10m jivanmukti in Advaita	PANEL 17
2025 Q7(c)	15m necessity w.r.t. the Gita	PANELS 9, 14

THE FOURTEEN STANDING TRAPS

- 1 do not equate immortality, resurrection and rebirth
- 2 do not say Buddhism denies continuity – it denies a permanent substance-self
- 3 do not describe Nyaya apavarga as positive bliss
- 4 do not make all Indian liberation doctrines a merger with God
- 5 do not use the flame analogy as proof
- 6 distinguish knowledge destroying ignorance from prarabdha sustaining the body
- 7 do not treat bhakti as mere emotion – achievement to reception is the point
- 8 do not say "Advaita rejects bhakti" – Advaita makes it PREPARATORY
- 9 do not answer the three-means question with "all three are equal"
- 10 do not conflate rebirth with reincarnation
- 11 do not present resurrection as rebirth in heaven
- 12 do not treat kaivalya as a synonym for moksa, or Jain kevala as Samkhya kaivalya
- 13 do not call Yoga's Isvara a creator (YS 1.24)
- 14 do not say Samkhya's purusa is bound and released (SK 62-63)

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 32/32: Graded verdict ladder, mark bands and verdict templates

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 32/32: Graded verdict ladder, mark bands and verdict templates

GRADED VERDICT LADDER

WEAK	~40%	"the soul is eternal and is reborn until liberated" – all schools merged; liberation terms used as synonyms
AVERAGE	~50%	correct school-wise definitions; no argument reconstruction; Buddhism handled as an exception rather than a counter-example
GOOD	~60%	continuity-bearer identified per school; one objection answered; necessary/sufficient distinction still unstated
STRONG	~65-70%	modal verdict precise; parity-bench distinctions live; Western comparator (Plato / resurrection) used deliberately
TOP	~70%+	all the above PLUS a discriminating distinction (production vs removal; saksat vs arad-upakaraka; SK 62-63 misattribution; replica theory) PLUS a statement of what would FALSIFY the position

MARK BANDS: 10m ~150 words · 15m ~250 words · 20m ~300 words.

PARAGRAPH PATTERN: CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION.

THREE VERDICT TEMPLATES

- NECESSITY STEM "Immortality of a substantial soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth but not NECESSARY: Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone. What rebirth actually requires is a CONTINUITY-BEARER, and schools disagree only about whether that bearer must be a substance."
- MEANS STEM "All three are means of different kinds. Which is the DIRECT means is settled by a prior metaphysical question – whether liberation is produced or uncovered – and every school's answer follows from that."
- LIBERATION STEM "The term names a FAMILY, not a state. Once apavarga, kaivalya, moksa and nirvana are separated, the apparent Indian consensus turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering four incompatible destinations."